

BTS

THE REVIEW

A Comprehensive Look at the Music of BTS
Youngdae Kim



Written by [Youngdae Kim](#) Youngdae Kim is a music critic and an author, who serves as a member of Selection Committee for Korean Music Awards. Kim studied business administration at Yonsei University in Korea and completed Ph.D program in ethnomusicology at the University of Washington. Born and raised in South Korea, he moved to Seattle in 2007 where he has been closely observing American pop music trends and the development of K-pop for over a decade. Kim first started critiquing music in the mid-1990s under the online alias toojazzy, publishing widely through online magazines. Kim served as a Selection Committee member for “Top 100 Albums in Korean Popular Music” projects organized by *Kyunghyang* (2007) and *the Hankyoreh* (2018), two of the most influential daily newspapers in Korea. Kim contributes his critical columns in various mainstream media outlets, including *Vulture* by New York Magazine and MTV, and operates a YouTube channel that analyzes K-pop in depth. He is an author of multiple publications in Korea, including *Top 90 Albums of the 1990s and Korean Hip-hop: The Footprints of its Passion*, and translated *American Popular Music: From Minstrelsy to MP3* into Korean.

Translated by [H. J. Chung](#) H. J. Chung studied Korean history and political economy at UC Berkeley, Seoul National University, and University of Washington. She has been a K-pop music junkie for as long as she can remember. When she was a kid, her parents had to pull her away from the TV whenever Lee Ji-yeon—the prototypal solo female idol in the 1980s—performed “Wind, Please Stop Blowing.” After immigrating to the United States, she started frequenting “Soompi Town,” the initial version of today’s Soompi.com, to spazz about H.O.T. with fellow Korean American fans. Currently, she is a translator of texts and multimedia in Korean and English on a wide variety of subjects, including K-pop and K-drama.

What Sets BTS Apart?

The Music Behind BTS' Phenomenal Popularity

What is the secret to BTS' exceptional worldwide popularity, referred as the “BTS Phenomenon”? Is it because of the seven members' X-factor, their amazing talent and explosive energy on stage? How can they be understood within and without the context of K-pop? What do the ARMYs, their loyal brigade of worldwide fans, mean by “BTS-Pop?”

Youngdae Kim, a seasoned critic of Korean popular music, boldly tackles an unprecedented task: an in-depth review of BTS' entire discography. After all, the proper approach to give musicians their due respect is by listening to their music—it's the heart of their message and their route to the top.

BTS in the Eyes of Experts, Industry Insiders, and Fans

- ◆ Bong-hyeon Kim, Hip-hop Journalist
- ◆ Hyeong-cheol Shin, Literary Critic
- ◆ Chang-nam Kim, Chair, Selection Committee of Korean Music Awards
- ◆ Jeff Benjamin, *Billboard* Columnist
- ◆ Hyung-joo Lim, Popera Tenor, Voting Member of the Grammy Awards
- ◆ Brother Su, Composer of “I Need U”
- ◆ Myungji Chae, Fan Translator for BTS

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Prologue

Unraveling the Secret of BTS Phenomenon

The early 1990s was a watershed moment for Korea's popular music industry, led by artists such as Seo Taiji and Boys. This is the period when *gayo*, the trendy local music, started achieving the level of contemporaneity and quality similar to American popular music. Over the mid-1990s, systematic establishments began to industrialize the market for the first time. By the twenty-first century, the focus of Korean popular music shifted outwards, beyond the limitations of its domestic market. There, it was renamed "K-pop." In this up-and-coming music scene, we encountered two turning points that deserve the title of phenomena. The first is undoubtedly PSY's "Gangnam Style" (2012), an international viral sensation that became

the greatest K-pop hit in history. Then there is the rise of Bangtan Boys or “BTS phenomenon,” the topic of this book.

When something rises to the fore, people tend to look for simple explanations and analyses that make sense and are easy to comprehend. I fully understand the psyche behind such desires. Since it is part of my profession to analyze such phenomena, I also try my best to illustrate things in a coherent, comprehensible manner. But the major lesson I learned from studying, teaching, and reviewing music is that most of these convincing, clear-cut analyses tend to be embellished or unrealistic. Although every phenomenon must have its roots, the rationale may not necessarily be logical. Also, even if the surrounding circumstances are logically explainable, the crux of the matter is overly complex and multifaceted to be reduced into a few sentences or paragraphs. The same goes for the BTS phenomenon.

“What differentiates BTS from others?” “What is the essence of the BTS phenomenon?” “What does their success tell us?” People often ask me these questions, as I have followed BTS’ music and activities for quite a while. Though it may sound disappointing, I will not attempt to provide straightforward answers to those questions in this book. If someone asserts that they know such a definite answer, I hope you wouldn’t take it at face value. On the distinguishing features or the special characteristics of BTS and their success, there may exist a myriad of different (and sometimes wrong) analyses depending on each commentator’s expertise. Unfortunately, to my

knowledge, there has not been any analysis that accurately identifies the heart of their success. It is probably because we focus on their success, without paying attention to the process or the journey that resulted in such an outcome. The success of BTS was not built in a day, nor is it a work of someone's magic. Every step of their way is what made them who they are today.

In this book, I will trace the trajectory of BTS' rise to stardom in the U.S. market since 2014 and delineate various contexts of the BTS phenomenon that BTS and their fans have created together. Nonetheless, more than any explanation or interpretation, I believe this process must begin and end with listening to their music and appreciating their messages. People seem to disregard that BTS members are first and foremost *musicians*. Most of the focus seem on their statistic records, sales, and other numerical achievements. While accounting such numbers are amusing, those efforts often miss the point. BTS is a group of musicians, and the biggest appeal and the secret to success are in their music and performances. But not many try to take their music seriously and discuss it in-depth. Perhaps they think that analyzing music is difficult and abstract, and idol music does not require such a sophisticated level of listening. This book will explore the key to BTS' success by listening to their music. However, simply listening will not clarify the issue, either. Unless we take a multidimensional approach as we survey the past and the present topographies of popular music within the context of both K-pop and the global pop music, the answer to the reason

behind BTS' success will not be fully grasped. This is where my persistent effort to research and review music becomes relevant.

The largest portion of this book is dedicated to the examination of sixteen albums that BTS has released. It was an unquestionable, obvious organization for me, albeit it may be demanding for the readers. To write this book, I replayed BTS' entire discography ad nauseam, though I am already familiar with the songs from previous repeated listens. I re-analyzed all the tracks in all of their singles, albums, solo albums, and activities in their entirety from scratch. I replayed same songs too many times to the point of blanking out occasionally. To elaborate the meaning and the appeal of their songs in musical terms, and to formulate a guide for those who listen to their music for the first time, I kept repeating the songs to develop a new framework. As a result, this book became compilation of critiques, reviews, and liner notes. It is my answer to how BTS came to be the sensation they are today. You will not find it in a few sentences or an article, but throughout the analyses of all the songs, lyrics, and the steps of the journey that BTS has taken.

As you read this book, I wish you will turn on your favorite speakers or put on headsets and enjoy BTS' music again as you recap their career from the beginning. You may as well compare and contrast your impression with a music critic's perspective. When you turn the final page, I hope you are satisfied with my answer on the essence and the secret of BTS' success.

“Sipping a warm cup of tea,
I look up at the Milky Way”

Youngdae Kim, Music critic

February 2019

from Seattle

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Part 1

BTS

the Hip-hop Idol

This chapter examines the multidimensional significance of BTS as a “hip-hop idol” within the historical context of Korean popular music, beginning with the onset of “BTS Phenomenon” at KCON USA in 2014, extending to their early music and activities.

BTS: THE REVIEW



Column 01

The Onset of BTS Phenomenon at KCON 2014

Taking the world by storm as we speak in 2019, the BTS phenomenon is a fascinating subject that deserves multifaceted analysis. The most significant milestone they have reached is the “Korean invasion” of the American popular music market, represented by their historic No.1 on the Billboard Album chart. Predating BTS, a legacy of several Korean acts have made memorable advances in overseas markets. When K-pop first began to venture globally in the early 2000s, artists such as BoA and Rain accomplished significant inroads as pioneers of the world stage. BoA is especially notable as K-pop’s first successful case of elaborate localization strategy, whose success presented a direction for the

future of the industry. In the 2010s, idol groups led the K-pop boom that ignited dance cover fevers across the globe, not to mention PSY's "Gangnam Style" and his horse dance, arguably the biggest global viral hit from Korea. But none of these are comparable to the weight of the BTS phenomenon that has gone global since 2017.

In multiple aspects, the BTS phenomenon is distinguished from the established *Hallyu* (Korean wave)-based K-pop boom. First, it is regionally different. The existing Hallyu transpired from East Asia (Korea, China, and Japan), took over Southeast Asia, then spread minimally to the United States, Europe, and South America. In the case of BTS, their explosive popularity in the U.S. is what ignited the fever that passed on to Asia and South America. This unexpected overseas fame went on to detonate their stardom back in Korea, generating the first case of two-way or "reverse import" in the history of global K-pop. The second difference is that this success was predicated on the unprecedented support of a solidified global fandom. The existing popularity of Hallyu or K-pop is generally considered as a development from television drama content to music, both based on the minority fandom focused on Korean popular culture. However, the success of BTS is discrete from the traditional style of Hallyu in that it is a musical phenomenon, backed by the massive support of ARMY,¹⁾ their now-famous fandom with an exclusive character. Though I will reiterate in the later chapters, sometimes they identify themselves solely as BTS fans and not

necessarily K-pop fans. Their avid passion for BTS is nearly unsurpassed among K-pop fandoms.

The Korean press often describes BTS as if they rose to stardom overnight, but their potential as a global star was already visible during the early period of their career. The origin of such a trend was a North American K-pop festival called KCON USA, held in the summer of 2014 in Los Angeles, California. There, something completely unexpected happened. The American fans' response to BTS, a rookie group whose name was barely becoming known, was unusually passionate. Though the sheer magnitude of fan support was incomparable to the K-pop superstars G-Dragon, Girls' Generation, or IU, the wild reception for BTS was quite a surprise. I was not the only one with such an impression. Billboard and other local media quickly picked up on the unpredicted popularity of BTS among American fans. Upon returning, I wrote in editorials and on social media how such enthusiasm was exceptional and unlike anything I have noticed recently in the K-pop community, that it seemed to signal the beginning of a new era. It truly did.

Let's take a closer look. In 2014, BTS was not just a rookie group, but was the only idol group from a new agency called BigHit, nowhere near the caliber of "Big 3"—SM, JYP, and YG—that have asserted dominant influence over promotions and popularity in the K-pop industry, more so abroad. As a former producer and a hit composer from JYP, BigHit producer Bang Si-hyuk certainly was a seasoned expert in artist training, designing, and producing, but the

media didn't pay attention to BTS as favorably as the idols from more established agencies. The buildup of their fandom and any significant response to their activities came far afterwards. Also, the year 2014 was a time when the hype from PSY's "Gangnam Style" was still palpable in the U.S. and K-pop was celebrating its own golden age. IU had just been coronated the queen of K-pop, Girls' Generation and BIGBANG were still the most popular artists, and EXO was gathering traction as the next up-and-coming global act, attracting massive followings in Korea and China. BTS' debut happened simultaneously with the appearance of a slew of male and female idol groups, including B.A.P and Block B that also identified as hip-hop idols. The fierce competition made it even more difficult to generate much buzz. No wonder nobody foresaw the potential of BTS as an international group that catered to the U.S. market.

American K-pop fans' sudden attention to BTS was unexpected in several ways. The composition of the group was not necessarily "U.S.-friendly" or prepared for international fame, compared to those groups with global experience and linguistic capabilities of Korean-American or foreign members. Moreover, though they had musical sustainability and production capacity, BigHit was just a small agency without any infrastructure or connections to local American promoters and the media to fathom systematically promoting BTS in the United States. While hip-hop was becoming the new trend, idols who embraced the genre were often written off as being lame and their skills were downplayed. In the early 2010s, none of the Korean

media paid attention to this group of unknown boys as the “next big thing” in the middle of the cutthroat competition among idol groups. Instead, American fans and the media that harbored less prejudice against BTS recognized their potential first. They were not large in number, but their existence was nonetheless critical.

What did BTS do in the U.S. around 2014? A few months before KCON, BTS held a surprise concert at Troubadour, a small theater in Los Angeles, for a crowd of 200 fans. The scale of the show was far from the typical luxuries that the K-pop industry is associated with, rather closer to those of indie musicians. Regardless of the size of the venue, it was an intense show according to those who attended. Indeed, scale or extravagance does not always entail success in music. The experience of intimate, heartfelt interaction provided to the select few fans in a small space led to incredible reactions at the subsequent KCON. At the Meet and Greet and during the performance, we saw the first march of ARMY, clad in matching black masks and attire. These sparks of light inflamed into massive bonfires at North and South American fan meetings in the following year. In a few years, they transformed into the most pivotal supporters of “the BTS phenomenon.” In other words, they were building an almost indie, grass-roots style of bottom-up fanbase unusual for K-pop idols. Without a single song recorded in English, BTS surged as the most anticipated K-pop act in the U.S. Two years later, when they appeared on the stage as the headliner for KCON at STAPLES Center, one of the largest arenas in the nation, BTS

brought down the house, inducing the loudest screams from the crowd. The fervent uproar seemed to herald BTS' first U.S. tour, which came true in a year later.

If you have been observing these events closely, you may have noticed the clues to BTS' unexpected rise in the U.S. market. BTS was slowly gaining recognition among global K-pop fans through a 2014 cable reality show, "American Hustle Life." The show intended to entice domestic K-pop fans through depicting the innocence of a rookie hip-hop idol group. The show follows BTS as they set foot on American soil for the first time, honing skills and working with renowned American rappers who are their inspirational role models. In hindsight, it has much to offer the viewers, but the immediate reception from Korean music fans was negative, particularly within the hip-hop community. To the avid hip-hop fans who avow strong pride of the genre, it was nothing more than idol dancers' futile attempt at mimicking hip-hop artists. "American Hustle Life" employed the classic strategy of earning credibility through association with genre-specific historicity, such as its "authentic" regional and racial backgrounds. In other words, by displaying the process of BTS members' struggles in America, the show aimed to present their talent and passion as something "genuine." There was an unforeseen twist to this effort: while the show was mocked by the target audience in Korea, BTS started gaining American fans. Although "American Hustle Life" was produced without a particular plan for overseas consumption, the episodes were translated

earnestly by international fans which made it accessible for K-pop fans' consumption, sowing the seeds that later flourished as the American ARMY.

The unusual process of BTS' rise in the U.S. is quite exhilarating to observe. It is especially striking if you know how the paradigm of pop music is maneuvered through systematic promotions. At the heart of all the events and efforts that BTS organized is their sincerity. The element of good fortune certainly played its part, but most critically, the process of their growth was organic and not contrived. BTS strived their utmost, and their modest, passionate, and genuine character moved the hearts of American fans, transcending the linguistic and cultural barriers. They may not have the smoothest manners, but the frank attitude of this rookie boy band was a breath of fresh air. Unbeknownst to most, the flame of BTS phenomenon was thus ignited in the U.S.

Review 01

2 COOL 4 SKOOL

(2013, Single)



Album

Review



Surprisingly, BTS' first step was taken in old-school hip-hop with scratches from the 1980-90s, instead of trendy hip-hop or EDM. At the dawn of 2010s, hip-hop was permeating every corner of the American mainstream music. The trend extended to Korea, where both overground and underground scenes bustled to uphold hip-hop as the genre that embodies the spirit of the day. The debut single by BTS must be understood within the context of such a pervasive breakthrough of hip-hop and the desire of idol music to distinguish itself. Although BTS is in the format of an idol group, the basis of their music and attitude is distinctively hip-hop, as evidenced in their sound and lyrics. The styling of the music video and excessively fierce visuals also reflect the aggressive character of hip-hop. In hindsight, these crude messages and militant attitude of BTS may have bewildered the existing K-pop or idol fans who encountered their music for the first time. It is noteworthy that from the get-go, BTS bluntly laid out the message of self-verification and identification as musicians, which is almost the norm for

idols today. BTS was exceptionally raw and forthright. It marked the beginning of something new, though nobody quite predicted that BTS would become the leader of that era.

Track

Review

1 Intro: 2 Cool 4 Skool(Feat. DJ Friz)

Produced by Supreme Boi

“On behalf of the teens and twenties,
we tell our story freely”

Short and simple, the intro succinctly summarizes BTS’ keywords “youth” and “authenticity” in a sentence. The track also achieves a quite rare distinction in K-pop by combining breakbeat and scratch rooted in old-school hip-hop.

2 We Are Bulletproof, Pt. 2

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, Supreme Boi, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Shattering my limits against
the double standards and countless oppositions”

From the speedy trap²⁾ beats and siren sound effects³⁾ that open the track to the sharp rapping and enraged chorus that follow, the style as a whole pays homage to

old-school hip-hop. The lyrics discuss the prejudice and misunderstanding they have faced since their trainee days, describing them figuratively and literally. In terms of composition, this track can be interpreted as the prototype of BTS' future style of music.

3 Skit: Circle Room Talk

Produced by Pdogg

It introduces BTS members under the premise that they are in a school hip-hop club. Instead of listing each person's profile, they talk about their childhood and dreams, which cleverly reflects the tradition and characteristics of hip-hop as a genre. It is notable how, instead of mentioning other idol groups, Rap Monster (hereafter RM) and Suga name Epik High, a Korean hip-hop group, as their musical inspiration. By implication, they emphasize their hip-hop-based identity and attribute a certain context to their music. Though the conversation is certainly staged, their declaration of musical direction still sounds genuine.

4 No More Dream

(Pdogg, "hitman" bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg

“Why do you tell me to take a different path?
It’s none of your business,
please don’t compel me”

After talking about their dreams in the earlier skit, now BTS acutely criticizes the society that diminishes those dreams to continue the organic storyline. While heavily referencing the style of gangsta hip-hop, which originated from the West Coast and became a new current of the U.S. mainstream music in the 1990s, the positive message in the school setting differentiates it from the typical “ghetto” hip-hop. Rather, the direction is similar to those of Seo Taiji and Boys’ “Come Back Home” or H.O.T.’s “Descents of Warriors” that drew from gangsta hip-hop’s powerful sound to express the angst of youth. Their criticism against the absurdity of school as an institution and the social conditions that deprive youth of their dreams harks back to Korean popular music from the 1990s, reminiscent of songs like “Classroom Ideology” by Seo Taiji and Boys, as well as Shin Hae-chul’s politically conscious lyrics that denounced and urged the awakening of lethargic youth.

5 Interlude

Produced by Slow Rabbit

This track showcases the melodic dimension of Slow Rabbit, who will grow as an outstanding producer next to BigHit's main producer Pdogg. It is an instrumental track with a few simple chords and functions less as a stand-alone piece than the intro for the following track that Slow Rabbit also produced.

6 Like

(Slow Rabbit, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“Not even mine anymore,
but why does it feel like you're stolen away from me”

“Like” is a romantic R&B number that utilizes the minor scale, often found in the blues genre. This style of composition leaves you feeling oddly poignant, musically in sync with the lyrics; the narrator feels complex emotions from witnessing his ex-girlfriend's happy life on her social media. Though BTS identifies as a hip-hop idol group, the timbre and strength of their vocals stand out here powerfully. It was an early indication of their potential to develop into a universal boy band.

7 Outro: Circle Room Cypher

(RM, j-hope, SUGA, V, Jimin, Jung Kook, Jin, Pdogg)

Produced by Pdogg

“Imma wipe you out ‘til you’re done,
we’ll rock it damn hard”

This is the beginning of BTS’ signature Cypher series. It still feels rough at this point, sounding both seasoned and callow, like a bunch of hot-blooded rappers rambling on and on. The voice of “rapper” Jung Kook, hard to imagine these days, is captivating, and Jin’s wholehearted effort until the end is delightful. Absolute skills notwithstanding, their passion as a rookie hip-hop idol is powerfully appealing. Unlike most other idol music that focuses on trendy and chic style, representations of provincial cities like “Daegu” and “Gwangju,” and the unaffected, down-to-earth choice of words are sensibilities unique to BTS.

8 Skit: On the Start Line^(Hidden Track)

(RM, “hitman” bang)

Produced by “hitman” bang

“I will never forget
the ocean and the desert I saw”

Through this very personal confession, BTS' leader and main rapper RM takes the mic to tell what they feel before the imminent debut. In less than three minutes, he channels the anxiety they experienced as long-term trainees and the anticipation and determination for the upcoming debut, integrating both positive and nervous dimensions of their state of mind. His unrefined sensibilities are distinguishable from the polished and processed style of idol music, and the texture of intimate emotions that resembles the sound of an early-morning recording generates a special mood for this track.

9 Path (Hidden Track)

(RM, j-hope, SUGA, "hitman" bang, Pdogg)

Produced by Pdogg

"I thought I wouldn't worry once we're set to debut, but I shut my eyes as nothing's changed in reality"

The final track's theme flows naturally from the previous one. On this old-school hip-hop-style track with lighthearted boom bap⁴⁾ beats, each member shares his journey during trainee years in somewhat heavy and serious tone. The authenticity of BTS is rooted in these plainspoken, unpretentious stories. Instead of cherry-picking the hopeful, promising aspects of debuting as

idol, they are calm and reserved in attitude as they face the upcoming future.

Review 02

O!RUL8,2?

(2013, EP)



Album

Review



I will compare it side-by-side with the debut album, *2 COOL 4 SKOOL*. Although there is no major change in the fundamental elements or attitude of their music, they expand the theme from dreams to happiness as their musical intention develops more broadly. Upon closer look, the lyrics of “N.O,” now considered the theme song of School Trilogy, are in continuation of the context of the 1990’s K-pop in expressing the frustration and defiance of youth under the harsh education system. The resentful attitude in “We On” and “BTS Cypher, Pt. 1” reveal their determination to confront the struggle of proving themselves. This is a rite of passage that they can, or must, go through as a hip-hop idol. The early music of BTS was not properly evaluated compared to the Most Beautiful Moment in Life series. The listeners who don’t empathize with BTS’ music tend to brush it off as their disgraceful period. But strictly in terms of musical achievement, the musical aim and authenticity that the producers at BigHit and BTS members intended were undeniably progressing toward creating their distinct

identity. The playful and energetic appeal as idol through “Rise of Bangtan,” the refined sensibilities in “Coffee,” and the quirky experimental character of “Paldogangsan” coexist to feature a wide spectrum of the record, keeping you guessing where they will go next with enough potential in each direction.

Track

Review

1 Intro: O!RUL8,2?

(Pdogg, RM)

Produced by Pdogg

“Be honest now,
do you remember what your dream was?”

The grand, dramatic theme and fiery rapping combine to hint the upcoming tradition of BTS hip-hop tracks. It is particularly significant as the budding phase of BTS' main rapper RM's musical identity. By questioning the existence of dreams and the reason for dreaming, the track is an extension of their earlier themes.

2 N.O

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg

“Later no more, don't confine yourself
in someone else's dream”

The track asks the meaning of happiness while questioning how to lead an independent life, establishing

the central theme of School Trilogy. It also defines the character of BTS' early career. The combination of raw atmosphere, trap beats, and strings gives off a somewhat crude ambience, but such unrefined qualities differentiated BTS from the existing K-pop trends. The theme resembles that of "No More Dream," as in the despair of youth against the social system that deprives youth of their dreams and options in life, which resonates in the hearts of their peers today.

3 We On

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

"My skills of controversy,
don't you come to a hasty conclusion
I'm killa Jack the Ripper
Piercing you with sharp blades of my tongue"

As with "We Are Bulletproof, Pt. 2," "We On" expresses the anger toward those who unfairly bash BTS, expressly for taking up hip-hop as an idol. Utilizing heavy hip-hop sound in line with "No More Dream," the track eliminates elaborate effects to trim it down to dry, piercing rap. RM's calm tone that chews out the haters contrasts SUGA's unrefined outburst of anger. Such blend of

rationality and emotions reflects the complex appeal of BTS' music, especially their rap sections.

4 Skit: R U Happy Now?

Produced by Pdogg

In the end, they must be satisfied with the simple fact that their “dream” since the trainee days has come true. But most of us tend to forget such basic happiness, which makes this declaration all the more relevant.

5 If I Ruled the World

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“I know this doesn't make any sense,
this is the silly me singing”

BTS exhibits clear exertion of swagger, now considered the symbolic sentiment of hip-hop, as they fill the track with ostentatious and playful messages. The use of subjunctive expands the story of their dreams, then concludes with devotion to music, exhibiting the type of wholesomeness as a K-pop hip-hop idol. Restating their keen interest in old-school hip-hop, the track adopts G-

funk, a genre popularized in Los Angeles in the early 1990s.

6 Coffee

(Urban Zakapa, Pdogg, Slow Rabbit, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg, Slow Rabbit

“Farewell is bitter like Americano,
my memories still visit that cafe”

The song displays pure romantic sentiments, a tendency relatively less found in BTS’ discography. The lyrics allude to a former relationship as coffee. The bitter aftertaste resonates with the lyrics, also reflected in the sentimental composition that emphasizes the romantic mood with the electric guitar sound.

7 BTS Cypher Pt.1

(Supreme Boi, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Supreme Boi

“Try to put me down, you’re helpless and jealous
You better hide your ip address”

“BTS Cypher Pt.1” is a hip-hop idol’s retort to the haters (who may be underground rappers or hip-hop fans) motivated by their pride of hip-hop. This track is the beginning of the legendary Cypher series. The rappers’ provocation of the underground scene, especially as idol rappers, marks an amusing page in music history. To the listeners who are not familiar with BTS’ music, it may seem unusual or out of context, but the witty counter-punch is intensely cathartic.

8 Rise of Bangtan

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg



2018 Mcountdown

“Who are we, the rising Bangtan Boys”

A harmony of vintage funk beats, brass, and soulful melodies created this retro hip-hop track. As the title states, it announces the anticipated emergence of BTS, and their light swagger is the major appeal of the track. The uplifting, positive mood of the song can be described as “innocuously aggressive.” It’s even more captivating on stage than the recording.

9 Paldogangsan

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Why do we fight between tongues of Korean
Look up, we’re under the same sky”

“Paldogangsan” features a whirlwind of rap in *saturi* (regional dialect), a rare endeavor for idol music, if not the Korean hip-hop scene in general. Particularly notable is its deviation from the general tendency of idol music, which normally highlights the trendy dimension and downplays the regional flavors. Instead, they boldly and explicitly proclaim their local identities. The confident avowal of their periphery sentiments is not only a critical element of BTS’ authenticity since their early career but an exemplary Korean adaptation of American hip-hop’s emphasis on one’s roots. This attempt is significant for taking a step further in experimentation with music by organically incorporating the distinct intonations and nuances of each dialect into rap, instead of inserting them plainly. It’s interesting that RM uses standardized dialect as the “mediator.” The song is also conscientious for delivering the positive message that we must alleviate

regional conflicts, extending beyond the assertion of regional characters.

10 Outro: LUV IN SKOOL

(Slow Rabbit, Pdogg)

Produced by Slow Rabbit, Pdogg

“Hey girl, wanna go out with me?”

It faithfully reenacts the romantic ambience of the 1990s slow jam.⁵⁾ The track also demonstrates the BTS singers’ potential as R&B vocalists. Compared to other contemporary boy bands, their style is trendy and shows vocal techniques without vapid vibes.

Review 03

SKOOL LUV AFFAIR

(2014, EP)



Album

Review



SKOOL LUV AFFAIR is the last of School Trilogy that develops various musical efforts in previous albums into more acceptable, if not more palatable, forms for mass popularity. It coincides with the shift in the album's theme from abstract concepts like dreams and happiness to something more realistic and tangible like love. The general public was still new to the format of hip-hop idols, but the final product was rather something familiar and acceptable. "Boy in Luv" not only packed BTS' energy in a more concentrated form, it also integrated their straightforward message and easy-listening music to lead the track toward commercial success. On the other hand, "Just One Day" is a track with contemporary sensibilities that entices the existing K-pop idol fans. The soft nuance exhibited in gloomy lyricism and innocence distinguishes BTS from other groups based on hip-hop or urban genres. In any case, the best track in the album is "Tomorrow." The poetic lyrics and dramatic melodies harmonize beautifully to present the most unforgettable moment in BTS' early career.



Track

Review

1 Intro: Skool Luv Affair

(Pdogg, Slow Rabbit, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Like you’ve never been hurt in love
If you take my all, I would give even more”

This track uses three different beats to wittily unpack each member’s personality and continues seamlessly from “Outro: Luv in Skool.” It proves how BigHit’s production teams create albums with the big picture in mind, from the general sound to specific beats. Based on the concept of puppy love at school, the production elaborately matches changing beats with the style of rap and romance in the lyrics.

2 Boy in Luv

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg

“I wanna be your *oppa*
I yearn for your love so much”

It reconfirms their interest and application of old-school hip-hop. The hard rock guitar tone with distortion⁶⁾ is reminiscent of the 1980's hip-hop masterpieces, such as Run D.M.C.'s "Rock This Way" in rap-rock genre. The development from the verse to chorus, as well as major melodic characteristics and the song's overall grandiose atmosphere demonstrate features more akin to hard rock than hip-hop.

3 Skit: Soulmate

Produced by Pdogg

"Ah, I don't know what to do about the skit"

The skit captures a moment of day-to-day footage from their studio.

4 Where Did You Come From

(Cream, Hangyeol, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Layback Sound

"I'm from Busan, you're from Gwangju,
but we're just the same"

If “Paldogangsan” was the first attempt at saturi rap under the theme of regional reconciliation, this track speaks on behalf of those who want to truly fall in love regardless of their origins. Musically, the discrepancy between trendy urban hip-hop sound and rustic dialects is refreshing. It is pleasant to listen to the lovely touch of synthesizer and the building of harmony that enriches the latter half.

5 Just One Day

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Just for one day, if only I could be with you
Just for one day, if only I could hold your hand”

Minimal yet sparse sound meets the sweet, wistful lyrics to bring out BTS’ most gentle and sensitive dimension. While using hip-hop beats, each element of the drums, bass, and keyboard are polished smoothly. Towards the end, the continuation of vocal ad-libs without the beats is especially elegant. The gentle and romantic appeal as a “boy band,” as opposed to a “hip-hop idol,” is accentuated in the song, a rarity for BTS.

6 Tomorrow

(SUGA, Slow Rabbit, RM, j-hope)

Produced by SUGA, Slow Rabbit

“There’s a long way ahead, but why am I static
I cry out of suffocation, but it echoes in vain”

This was originally SUGA’s pre-debut composition that he revised for official release. The theme of finding hope amid despair balances its lyrical and tragic undertones. It’s fascinating to listen to the interlude following the first verse that lingers on, the clear contrast between the vocal parts (particularly V’s processed voice), and the intensity of explosive guitar sound toward the end. This is one of BTS’ hidden gems.

7 BTS Cypher Pt. 2: Triptych

(Supreme Boi, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Supreme Boi

“With my period, I slash the artery
of your musical career”

To BTS, the Cypher series is where their essential motivations converge: the outrage against their haters⁷⁾ and the desire for authentic hip-hop. As a group that identifies as a hip-hop idol, it is an inevitable fate for

them, whether they like it or not. It is also a step outside of their narrowly defined idol concepts, a relief from musical stagnation. The rappers' wits on Supreme Boi's beats have become both sharper and more skillful than the previous projects. The attacks against underground rappers who criticize BTS have become more specific, perceptibly notable in SUGA's parts.

8 Spine Breaker

(Pdogg, OWO, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Slow Rabbit, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg, OWO

“But I’m great at what I do,
I don’t depend on my mom and dad
The real back breaker is you,
all grown up but still living with your parents”

This track references the 1990’s West Coast sound, think Warren G and Dr. Dre. V models the low-pitch vocals after hip-hop singers like Nate Dogg, a G-funk artist popular in the 1990s’. The title “Spine Breaker” refers to the craze over expensive padded jackets among Korea’s middle and high school students, which poses a social problem by figuratively breaking their parents’ financial backs to keep up with the trends. BTS condemns the foolish youth and the society that caused such a

phenomenon, blasting their dependency on parents and the coward attitude without standards of their own.

9 JUMP

(SUGA, Pdogg, Supreme Boi, RM, j-hope)

Produced by SUGA, Pdogg, Supreme Boi

“Even if we live one day,
we will never regret
Let’s give it a go”

The sound and arrangement closely resemble “Jump,” a 1990’s mega-hit by an American hip-hop group Kris Kross. It’s no coincidence that the album description includes the name of hip-hop producer Jermaine Dupri, who discovered and produced Kris Kross. While referencing old-school hip-hop and rap sounds, the track transforms into a more contemporary style by switching to dubstep⁸⁾ arrangement in the middle to resemble the K-pop soundscape. Following the transition, the bursting performance of rappers effectively reflect their identity.

10 Outro: Propose

(Slow Rabbit, Pdogg)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“We used to be a bit awkward,
but I wanna give you my all”

It is a very traditional, lyrical R&B song based on medium-tempo hip-hop beats. Usually, the rappers were in charge of the outros in BTS albums, but the vocals take up the role to nicely wrap up the album’s overall theme of sweet puppy love.

SKOOL LUV AFFAIR SPECIAL ADDITION

(2014, Repackage)



Track

Review



11 Miss Right

(RM, j-hope, SUGA, “hitman” bang, Pdogg)

Produced by Pdogg

“Put on denim shorts, a white t-shirt,
and Converse high tops”

Among early BTS music, this well-made track showcases high-quality production with smoothest and most romantic beats. The main chord work repeats while the beats, vocals, and rap parts blend pleasantly without bumps. It’s also the first instance of their affection for Converse high tops, which develops into an independent track later on.

12 Like(Slow Jam Remix)

(Slow Rabbit, RM, j-hope, SUGA, Pdogg, Brother Su)

Produced by Brother Su, Pdogg

Unlike the original track which highlights the rhythms, the remix version emphasizes the sensuous groove, suitable

for slow jam as stated.

Column 02

The Evolution of K-pop Idols

The Significance of BTS in K-pop Idol History

The biggest change within the global popular music trend in the 2010s, including American pop music, is the mainstream takeover of hip-hop. Originating in street culture, hip-hop first emerged in the market in the 1970s through popular media until becoming widely commercialized in the 1980s. Over the mid-1990s, hip-hop was established as the most popular and influential genre in the United States. The late 1980s is the crucial period in understanding the context of hip-hop and rap in Korea. Initially, hip-hop was introduced through discothèques and nightclubs during the disco fever of the late 1970s. Dancers based in Itaewon, where many foreigners reside, started imitating the style of African American breakdancing

and eventually joined the Korean popular music scene. But rap music only enjoyed a short run during the heydays of Seo Taiji and Boys, Deux, and Hyun Jin-young, without having much presence in the mainstream music market. In the late 1990s, a new trend developed out of online communities to reinstate hip-hop as one of the important indie music genres in the early 2000s.

Korean hip-hop in the 2000s is markedly distinguishable from the earlier current. The sound is based on the trend of trap, a new rap genre favorable for dancing. Also, hip-hop took off as an umbrella culture that spans fashion and lifestyle in general, far more extensive than the prior focus on music. The most direct influence of this movement is “Show Me the Money,” a music variety show that launched in 2013. This show marks the watershed moment for rap music, which had remained an underground genre for twenty years in Korea. It didn’t just usher hip-hop into the mainstream, but heavily influenced idol music and the entire K-pop scene as well. The trend of idol music was occupied by synth pop or EDM, dubbed “hook songs,” but it drastically turned toward the urban sound of black music like hip-hop and R&B, spearheaded by the likes of BIGBANG and its member G-Dragon. The emergence of “hip-hop idols,” who prominently feature rap as the central part of the music as opposed to an addendum, became the alternative form that tested the new potential of K-pop boy bands. BTS is a team that appeared in the middle of such a great transformation to hybridize the genre and the attitude of hip-hop using the formula of an idol group.

From the perspective of musical history, the word “hip-hop idol” is an oxymoron. As widely known, hip-hop originated in the inner-city ghettos of New York in the 1970s as a part of the subculture. This unrefined part of street culture started becoming commercialized in the mid-1980s. Gangsta hip-hop triggered the cultural voyeurism of middle-class white consumers by extensively portraying the lives of poor black people, sometimes in a ridiculous or exaggerated manner; in turn, the genre took off dramatically in the mainstream. Since the root of hip-hop is the slum communities called “streets” or “hood,” more rigorous sociocultural standards are applied to the music. Hip-hop explicitly expresses the racial identity of “black music,” and obsesses over the authenticity of messages, similar to punk rock or folk music. While the genre has been reinvented into pop following commercialization, overriding racial and national bounds, the distinction between “real” and “fake” is one of the oldest forms of censorship in hip-hop. There are rappers whose careers were destroyed over failing to fulfill such requirements. Despite nurturing multiple billionaires, the genre is still predicated on the spirit of DIY. Against the powerful wave of industrialization, the movement to protect the spirit of hip-hop in the underground scene remains active to this day.

In contrast, idol music stands on the farthest side of the popular musical spectrum from hip-hop. Idol pop is rooted in the tradition of vocal harmony groups, which branched out from the 1950’s R&B. The music group Motown⁹⁾ firmly established the genre among the

young audience. The system and control of labels and producers were accepted as the norm, and easy-listening music for popular appeal was considered the most desirable objective as opposed to musical experimentation. Though this part will be elaborated further later, this tradition of American pop idol was inherited by the idol industries of 1980's J-pop¹⁰⁾ and 2000's K-pop. Regardless of their genres, music production and training headed by producers and agencies comprise their fundamental components. K-pop enhanced the J-pop system by merging visually remarkable music videos with an impeccable level of choreography. They also successfully fused the foreign element of hip-hop with the long tradition of boy bands for the first time in the history of popular music.

How was this antithetic combination of idol and hip-hop possible in K-pop? The most critical reason is that rap and dance comprise the foundation of K-pop idols. As noted by many others, the prototypical model for Korean idol music was established by Seo Taiji and Boys. Although they didn't rely on an agency-driven production system, they represent the early example of new mainstream K-pop for merging rap and dance, as well as employing on-stage performance and visual elements as major appeals. Inadvertently, the legacy of Seo Taiji and Boys' industrial revolution in music was inherited by idol music. Lee Soo-man gathered and trained five talented boy dancers to form H.O.T. They presented gangsta hip-hop sound with fierce messages similar to Seo Taiji and Boys, on the one hand, and candy-coated dance music on the other.

Yang Hyun-suk, a former member of Seo Taiji and Boys, established his agency “YG” and incorporated hip-hop sound in the format of idol music to successfully produce a black music-based duo, Jinusean, and 1TYM, a group most similar to today’s hip-hop idols. Their streak is inherited in eight years by another urban hip-hop idol, BIGBANG. The success of BIGBANG is historically significant for demonstrating that black music, including hip-hop, can make it big within the establishment of Korean popular music industry. As such, hip-hop has always occupied an important position in the history of K-pop.

BTS is a team that has inherited the contexts of both Korean hip-hop and idol music, and they are simultaneously evolving in a new direction. The most important element is that they relentlessly and seriously explored rap and hip-hop unlike any other idol in the past. BTS didn’t simply borrow hip-hop; they are one of the few idols that embraced the genre as their identity. This extensive identification differentiates them from other idols, who introduced rap or hip-hop elements but could not faithfully materialize them in music and attitude. In idol music or mainstream K-pop in general, rap functioned more or less as an addendum than the core of their music. Even BIGBANG, a group that fully implemented the identity and attitude as a hip-hop idol, could not establish their rap as a category by itself. This is where BTS is different. Their distinction is clear in the format of the group. BigHit formed the team around the rappers RM and SUGA because they initially intended to create a hip-hop group instead of an idol. When you listen to BTS’ music, rap

is not employed as the spice to the main dish or the customary filler between the chorus. As clearly evidenced from the Cypher series, their messages are highly explicit, and the rap techniques are very skilled, almost unlike an idol group.

The most important aspect is their attitude and authenticity. Contrary to other contemporary groups, they did not adopt hip-hop as a temporary concept. Despite the criticism from underground hip-hop communities and even other idol groups, they continued to level up and maintained their identity. The unsatiated thirst for rap during group activities were quenched through individual mixtapes and solo endeavors, which are also examples of hip-hop attitude rather than those of an idol. To BTS, who identifies as a hip-hop idol, the genre isn't just about the music. This is in line with the attitude mentioned above, of having the initiative in their own music (beats) and lyrics. On this issue, they cannot be completely free from criticism against idol music. They were selected and designed according to producer Bang Si-hyuk's plan, and their music is largely indebted to talented producers Pdogg, Slow Rabbit, and Supreme Boi. Even so, it is difficult to doubt their identity because they have always had a sense of ownership and continued to improve their music. Since the amateur trainee days, they created beats and wrote lyrics. Instead of regulating their originality, producers Bang Si-hyuk and Pdogg fostered their creativity and provided them with necessary technical expertise. The products from such processes are often crude and unrefined but were very real and authentic.

The innovative identification as a hip-hop idol was successful in terms of distinction, but it is unlikely an elaborate strategy for mass popularity. Still, it was unquestionably the reason for BTS' huge and unique breakthrough with their international fandom. This discourse of authenticity was especially central in the American market. BTS' methodology of being responsible for their own music and incorporating their honest stories go beyond those of an idol, which propelled them significantly against the stereotype that K-pop is artificially manufactured. At the same time, it earned them a whole new set of fans who have never followed existing K-pop groups. When BTS arrived on the scene in 2014, it was the heyday of idol music where 2NE1, Taeyang, EXO, and Girl's Generation were vying fiercely for the throne. BTS seemed to have nowhere to stand. The situation in the U.S. was a bit different. At their KCON debut stage, BTS already had a number of noticeable local fans. The local media also paid attention to their performance. At the time, I carefully projected that "Show Me the Money" and BTS will become the key factors for the upcoming future of K-pop. In a few years, this became a reality.

Popular music trends reflect the consciousness and desires of contemporary masses. For example, the music of "new generation" in the 1990s—most prominently Seo Taiji and Boys—prompted the generational replacement of music consumers. Beginning in the 2000s, when the paradigm of the music market shifted to digital sales, it intimidated the musicians and altered the market toward

extreme conservatism. In the meantime, the idol industry, aggrandized with ample capital and strategic planning, made important inroads in globalizing K-pop, the current that continues to this day. On the other hand, the preference of general public in Korea increasingly turned superficial. The majority of music that topped the charts were not widely enjoyed and whatever remained of the experimental music resorted to the appreciation of a handful of enthusiasts. International K-pop fans also experienced similar frustrations. By the mid-2000s, K-pop idol music that flourished with the launch of YouTube was inundated with extremely predictable music. Despite the exceptional success of PSY and the Hallyu fever of K-pop, Korean popular music was still nothing more than exotic spectacle. International fans began browsing hip-hop or indie rock genres as the alternative to K-pop idols, identified by frank attitudes and artistry. Their radar picked up a boy band named BTS, who proclaimed their raw spirit rooted in hip-hop. In retrospect, this was the harbinger of significant transformation in K-pop and its followers, though it almost went unnoticed.

Review 04

DARK&WILD

(2014, Album)



Album

Review



In terms of both narrative and theme, this album is an extension of the School Trilogy, and it is also a transitional album that hints at the upcoming Youth series. The composition and sound of the album characterize it as the grand finale of School Trilogy. Concurrently, it goes beyond the setting at school to express in various ways all the disorientation and befuddlement that boys go through before becoming grown-ups.

The central theme of the album's lyrics and attitude emphasizes the traditional notion of masculinity. This characteristic is stressed in the first half of the album in a candid way. Perhaps it channels the masculine sentiments of maturing yet youthful desires and impatience for romance, as succinctly summarized by the title, "*DARK&WILD*." The album's incorporation of bold rock sound is sharply edgy. "Danger" and "War of Hormone" are the tracks that represent such directions most effectively. They may differ in genre or details of the arrangement, but they both fuse grungy electric guitar

sounds of rock within the framework of hip-hop to accentuate the masculinity in lyrics.

The elevated presence of R&B urban tracks is notable. It rather caters to the changing trend in the overall K-pop scene, but it also represents the organic development of the vocal members from their experience and growth. Though only about a year has passed, the special effort for the full-length album reveals a considerable level of growth in the details of their performance. Their rap techniques have become much sharper since debut and the vocal textures are far more refined and smoother. Compared to the earlier series in School Trilogy, which evoke the atmosphere of a rowdy school festival, the rappers and vocalists in this album focus more faithfully on their roles. In particular, the rappers' individualities stand out.

Track

Review

1 Intro: What am I to You

(Pdogg, RM)

Produced by Pdogg

“Not that I wanted to beat you,
but neither did I want to keep losing”

As the first full-length album that follows the graduation of School Trilogy, *DARK&WILD* starts with the story of a young man suffering from falling out of his immature love. Dreamy but also confused at times, the stormy romantic emotions are expressed by gradually escalating strings, and RM's explosive rap gushes out the feelings of a man in despair. The strings arranged in the middle of the song follow a peculiar chord work, portraying the state of an upset heart. At the climax, the narrator in irrevocable agony finally screams, “What am I to you?” toward the object of his affection. On the one hand, it is an expression of aggressive masculinity, but on the other, it's a desperate plea. In line with the theme of the album, it articulates the “dark and wild” self but narrates the vulnerability against the uncontrollable emotion of love and the disturbing inability to do anything about it.

2 Danger

(Pdogg, Thanh Bui, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“You’re without me

But I’m filled with you, it drives me crazy”

Busting out with beatbox, the track integrates new jack swing (an R&B genre deeply influenced by hip-hop) with heavy rock sounds, reminiscent of Michael Jackson from *Dangerous* era. The B section, sung by the vocalists, alleviates the accumulation of aggression in the rap parts, adding lyricism and sentimentality to the track. In turn, it leads right into the intense chorus to complete a logically solid structure. While the overall sound is empowered and compact, the corresponding lyrics and music video still highlight the sweet charms of the members. This odd contrast results in a rather crude and unpolished mixture, as opposed to something trendy and refined. Such boldness is the particular appeal of this album that also persists throughout BTS’ early career. The rappers’ sturdy performance, Jin’s sentimental vocals, and Jung Kook’s empowered voice enhance the melody’s sensuous mood of the song.

3 War of Hormone

(Pdogg, Supreme Boi, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Once I win the battle with hormones, I’ll study up.
Your existence itself is against the rules”

Combining rap with scratches set in heavy rock guitar sounds, this track resembles the heyday of rap-rock, a fusion subgenre of rock and hip-hop in the early 1980’s U.S. and the U.K. It boasts the most accentuated chorus out of the whole album, expressing teenage boys’ interest in romance in an uninhibited way. In addition to the lyrics, the incorporation of aggressive rock sounds, fiery and crude rhythms, and unprocessed elements all seem to signal the end of School Trilogy era and BTS as a hip-hop idol. Hereafter, the music and concept of BTS undergo a dramatic transformation.

4 Hip-hop Lover

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Still makes my heart beat
You make me want to be my true self”

A drum machine starts rapid trap rhythms for this track with a cheeky title. Contrary to this first impression, the song has a twist: it confesses their pure, devoted passion for hip-hop. The track emphasizes how the essence of BTS is in hip-hop, that the label “hip-hop idol” is not just illusory rhetoric. It might not be one of their top tracks, but it’s an important thematic anthem. RM name-drops a whole list of great rappers who illuminated the prime time of hip-hop, followed by SUGA’s confession of deep affection for the genre. With j-hope strutting his maturity as a rapper, every phrase has something to offer. It is uncommon for idol music to explicitly express their devotion to hip-hop, and this is the distinction that BTS music offers. The vocalists’ beautifully harmonized falsetto¹¹⁾ in the chorus is another enjoyable element.

5 Let Me Know

(SUGA, Pdogg, RM, j-hope)

Produced by SUGA, Pdogg

“Reluctance holds me from ending it”

As in “Tomorrow,” we discover SUGA’s producing skills in “Let Me Know.” With dramatic style and compact structure, it is the most memorable track in the album. In

retrospect, the melodramatic and emotional atmosphere of the song seems to portend the era of *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life*. V opens the song with reserved though fully present vocals, Jung Kook shows off delicate and flawless techniques in the chorus, then Jimin follows with an elaborate high-pitch scat and beautiful singing. The cornucopia of fascinating sounds is satisfactory to the ears. The elements of arrangement take up this exhilarating momentum and rush on intensely, nothing short of marking this track as the masterpiece of their *DARK&WILD* era.

6 Rain

(Slow Rabbit, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“In the reflection on that puddle of raindrops,
I seem especially shabby today”

“Rain” is typical jazz hip-hop, which intermixes blue notes¹²⁾ in jazz piano and jazz samples with hip-hop beats. This style is not just a one-off and becomes a recurring mainstay within the BTS discography. “Rain” is also a subject that continues to return in their music, especially in RM’s lyrics. By overlapping the image of rain with the urban ambience of jazz, the track effectively

enhances the sentiment of otherness, solitude, and gloominess evoked in the metropolis of Seoul.

7 BTS Cypher Pt. 3: KILLER_(Feat. Supreme Boi)

(Supreme Boi, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Supreme Boi

“I’m confident on the beats
You’re out of both money and skills”

The clarity of its theme, keen messages and effective offense, and the competent techniques of this track mark the pinnacle of BTS’ Cypher series. The edge of their blades are earnestly sharpened with more refined ego than the earlier EPs. As with other Cypher series, those who listen to this track for the first time may wonder why they write such lyrics. Only when you understand how they were mocked and criticized as an idol group, before becoming the biggest boy band in the world, you will recognize the context of such an aggressive attitude. The pent-up anger and anxiety as underdogs are quenched by rumbling rapping, a stimulating example of catharsis that only the Cypher series can offer.

8 Interlude: What Are You Doing Now

Produced by Slow Rabbit

If the cypher is the outro for the first half of the album, this interlude is the intro for the second half. It is modeled after the beats of West Coast hip-hop or G-funk of the 1990s.

9 Can You Turn Off Your Phone

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Though we communicate more,
Only loud silence remains between us”

This track provides social commentary, one of the seminal aspects of BTS’ early career in addition to their devotion to hip-hop and self-verification. In line with the rest of the album, the expressive style is crude and less refined, but their boldness and fierce energy as a growing artist are captivating. Contrasting the critical nature of the lyrics, the soft beats and smooth vocals alleviate the overall tone of the song.

10 Embarrassed

(“hitman” bang, Shawn, Slow Rabbit, Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by “hitman” bang, Shawn, Pdogg

“Why did I do that, my brain rings
I resort to kicking my blanket in embarrassment”

The uplifting beats led by a clean tone of electric guitar fill this exceptional track. The song focuses on the mundane emotions of youthful romance, with outstanding musicality that aptly organizes the necessary elements. SUGA’s rap and vocal members’ delicate falsetto are neatly balanced, and simple but stylish melody tickles your ears.

11 24/7=heaven

(Pdogg, Slow Rabbit, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“To me every day’s Sunday
Cause you’re the sun in my sky”

It is similar to “Embarrassed” in sound and theme, but this track’s main feature is the refreshing appeal of a boy band than the identity as a hip-hop group. The familiar but effective chord progression is repeated to set the overall mood, then completes a naturally flowing development with consecutive interjections of smooth

rapping and vocals. Jung Kook's fine falsetto in the bridge melody is beautiful.

12 Look Here

(250, Jinbo, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Hobo

"You're the flower, I'm the bee
You're the honey, I'm the bear"

From the entire album, "Look Here" has the most distinct style of arrangement and sounds. It doesn't come as a surprise since it's the only song written by the producers who are not from BigHit. DJ 250 and singer-songwriter Jinbo created the beats and the melody, and Hobo produced this track. The genre is modeled after the Motown-esque retro R&B that Pharrell Williams is known for. More precisely, it references Robin Thicke's funky soul pop, "Blurred Lines."

13 Second Grade

(Pdogg, Supreme Boi, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Is there an exam here, too?

Are we successful singers when we’re No.1?”

The indispensable distinction of BTS music is their self-confession that sincerely narrates what they feel at the moment and this track is a classic example. For closing their ambitious first album that extends from the School Trilogy, they posit the general public as their teacher and themselves as second-grade students (musicians in their second year). It includes their concerns during the preparation of the album and the determination for the future. The arrangement employs trendy trap beats to lift the mood from becoming too heavy.

14 Outro: Does That Make Sense?

(SiMo, Supreme Boi)

Produced by SiMo, Supreme Boi

“I hate you to death,
but I still think of you”

This is the last track of *DARK&WILD* album that also marks the grand finale of the School Trilogy era. Uncommon for an outro, this R&B tune was sung only by the vocal members in a romantic and mesmerizing style. The genre usually emphasizes delicate sensuality, but

this one takes up a rough tone of rhythms and sounds as a consistent track of *DARK&WILD*. Despite the apparent theme of romance, the melody chords and progression of arrangement exhibit a hint of solemnity.

Review 05

RM BY Rap Monster

(2015, Mixtape)



Album

Review



Self-vindication: this term concisely expresses BTS' leader and main rapper RM's first mixtape in a word. The album is faithful to the process of proving who he is. We must pay attention to the context behind this mixtape. The origin of BTS was in their identification as a hip-hop idol. There was an inevitable price to pay for messing with hip-hop, a genre that commands a large brigade of prickly fans who are eager to verify artists' authenticity. Their format as an idol, regardless of their actual talent, bound them in a certain style of music and performance. This gave the critics an excuse to slam them.

Some of the hip-hop community members aimed at the main rappers RM and SUGA, but the game was unfair from the start. This mixtape was born out of such a context. Despite the concerns surrounding "an idol rapper's solo work," the rap skills in *RM* are nearly impeccable, even without the label as an idol. The beats were deliberately chosen to reveal his musical preference and various grains of his techniques.

It has several musically interesting points. “Throw Away” and “Joke” are technically noteworthy. “Joke,” in particular, flaunts his fancy techniques including speedy rapping, elaborate rhymes, and fluent delivery, befitting the moniker “Rap Monster.” “Do You” has a narrative consistency with the School Trilogy, but he relocates the entire context into his perspective and interests to ask the perpetual question: “What do you really want?”

RM’s most impressive strength as a rapper is his diversity and tolerance. He is a rapper, but not an exceptionalist of hip-hop as a genre. With a musician’s disposition, he focuses on the narrative and the message as a whole, rather than fixating on the techniques themselves. “Voice,” similar to an autobiographical essay, stays true to his style in that sense. It also gives us a sneak peek into his future trajectory as an independent musician.

To return to the keyword self-vindication, RM strives to prove his qualification as an MC who shouldn’t be underrated for his idol status. He has an array of styles and techniques to show for it. It may seem overwhelming, but to him, these were the necessary steps as a musician. Still, RM knows he is an idol, an artist inside the system. He knows this best. In this record, he doesn’t attempt to hide that fact.

Track

Review

1 Voice

Produced by Slow Rabbit

The phrase, “without letting anyone know, I turn up the volume of my voice” epitomizes the song and the entire album’s message. Naming the song of his first mixtape “Voice” reflects RM’s desire to vindicate himself as a rapper, and its solemn introspection makes his serious attitude very persuasive. With just a simple piano loop playing in the back, the track only focuses on telling his story and does not try to achieve technicality in rap or avant-garde sounds. This blunt opening track is enough to reevaluate RM’s identity as a rapper.

2 Do You

(Original Beat by Major Lazer - Aerosol Can)

One of the recurring messages in RM’s lyrics is his advice to lead an autonomous life. It reiterates the expression, “be the ruler of your own world,” denoting both the desire for freedom and the recommendation to follow your own way of life, rather than trying to fit into the

society's standards. The message is concisely condensed into the title, "do you." RM's message is sharp and intelligent, and the delivery of his rap maintains the bright mood amidst the monotonous beats.

3 Awakening

(Original Beat by Big K.R.I.T. - The Alarm)

What are they "awakening" from? RM unleashes his first take on the oldest topic for BTS, "idol vs. artist," in the most straightforward way. Without hiding his identity, he frankly admits. Mentioning loyalty, he asks who will hold his hands until the end. It may be his friends or the fans who support him. As it happens, the title of the original beats used in this track is also "The Alarm," perfectly in line with the title of this track.

4 Monster

(Original Beat by J. Cole - Grown Simba)

Alluding to his stage name, RM introduces himself as the "monster." Though he spends parts of the lyrics to retort his haters, the overall sentiment is rather positive. The style of his rap also focuses on naturally engaging the

heavy groove of the beats, as opposed to showing off techniques.

5 Throw Away

(Original Beat by Chase & Status - Hypest Hype)

“Throw Away” nicely merges boisterous beats with intense lyrics. The chorus demands you to discard all prejudice and bias. The rest of the message and narrative is quite straightforward. RM’s signature baritone timbre shines through the rowdy beats.

6 Joke

(Original Beat by Run the Jewels - Oh My Darling)

When evaluated only based on rap techniques, this is hands down the standout of the album. It functions as a showcase for his skills that were not overt as an idol rapper. Here, “joke” denotes nonsensical pun rather than something funny, a stream of consciousness that goes on and on. It doesn’t necessarily have a grand message, but amid the seemingly meaningless wordplay, you can occasionally spot biting punches.

7 God Rap

(Original Beat by J. Cole - God's Gift)

This is one of my personal favorites of the album. The low baritone of RM goes very nicely with the heavy boom bap style, and it highlights RM's trademark intellect that shines when tackling abstract and symbolic themes. Though it draws from religion and god, the core of the message is the vindication and belief in himself. RM's rapping is relaxed and skillful without being intimidated by the hip-hop superstar J. Cole's beats.

8 Rush (Feat. Krizz Kaliko)

Produced by Pdogg

This is a new track created in collaboration with Krizz Kaliko, a rapper from Strange Music led by the famous rapper Tech N9ne. RM's rap lyrics are also all written in English. The laid-back, easy-listening approach effectively blends with RM's fluent rap delivery.

9 Life

(Original Beat by J. Dilla - Life)

On the distinguished beats by J. Dilla, often selected as one of the best DJs in hip-hop history, RM shows the most composed, calm rapping in the album. In-depth examination of life, death, and solitude separates the track's theme from BTS' contemporary narratives. The content and sentiment of the music reflect RM's unique sensibilities, and the examination of dualities such as "life and death" and "light and darkness" later resurfaces in the second mixtape, *mono*.

10 Adrift

(Original Beat by Drake - Lust 4 Life)

RM portrays himself as a wandering drifter in the ocean (or the outer space) in utter desolation, contemplating the true objective of life and happiness. Both the theme and relatively calm style of rap are in line with the previous track "Life." It confirms RM's rich melody making skills as a composer.

11 I Believe

Produced by Slow Rabbit

The album that started with the story of "voice" closes on a positive note of believing in himself. Following the

series of edgy responses to his critics, the introspective insecurity, and doubts about life, he finally concludes to go forward. Despite the treacherous nature of people and the world, his determination to trust himself and push forward portends the LOVE YOURSELF series in the future.

Interview 01

BTS, the Underrated Rappers

Bong-hyeon Kim, Hip-hop Journalist



Since BTS was designed as a “hip-hop idol,” their early albums cannot be fully comprehended without knowing the musical context of hip-hop and the intersection of hip-hop and idols positioned within the history of Korean popular music. I recapped the controversy

surrounding hip-hop idols, prejudices and misunderstanding about BTS, and their achievement and significance with hip-hop journalist Kim Bong-hyeon.

Youngdae Kim You're one of the earliest and the closest among music journalists to follow BTS. How did you first get to know them?

Bong-hyeon Kim I don't remember exactly. I think producer Bang Si-hyuk gave me a call. He was planning to debut an idol group whose identity was hip-hop, and he wanted my advice. His call was probably why I became interested in BTS.

Youngdae Kim You weren't used to listening to idol music. What did you think of BTS' music at first listen?

Bong-hyeon Kim When I listened to their first album before BTS' debut at Mr. Bang's studio, I remember it was better than my expectations. I purposely lowered my hopes before listening, but it was nicer than I had anticipated. Then I found out that their producer Pdogg is a long-time hip-hop fan, which must have affected the quality. RM and SUGA stood out even back then. It felt like they naturally liked hip-

hop growing up, not because they had to debut as a hip-hop idol. Their rapping skills were also technically quite good.

Youngdae Kim As producer Bang mentioned, BTS identified as a “hip-hop idol” from the beginning. Although the style has changed slightly, the basic approach seems to be more or less similar. Speaking of hip-hop idols, their history goes all the way back to 1TYM then up to BIGBANG. As a hip-hop critic, what do you think is the significance of hip-hop idol as a format?

Bong-hyeon Kim 1TYM is the first group to identify as a hip-hop idol. I think it was H.O.T.’s “Descents of Warriors” that first suggested a model that combines hip-hop and idol, but to them, hip-hop was more of an instrument. On the other hand, 1TYM took it up as their own identity. You can replace instruments, but you can’t discard your identity. Unlike H.O.T., 1TYM’s music throughout their idol career was based on hip-hop and R&B. From start to finish, they didn’t veer away from black music. 1TYM was Yang Hyun-suk’s groundbreaking design. Based on his experience of producing Keep Six, he organized Jinusean, then built on that experience to produce 1TYM. They laid the groundwork for BIGBANG. The appearance of 1TYM opened a new

category in Korean hip-hop history. High-quality production, provided by the likes of Perry, amplified their relevance.

Youngdae Kim In fact, when H.O.T. and 1TYM were active, there wasn't a distinct concept of "hip-hop idol." I remember it was more along the lines of "idols who would rap, clad in hip-hop style of clothing." Not many people could differentiate them from the so-called "rap-dance *gayo*."

Bong-hyeon Kim During 1TYM's years, I don't think their identity as a hip-hop idol was taken seriously in Korea. It was more of rhetoric that represented their sounds and fashion. At least that's how people accepted the idea. Considering it was the 1990s, that's not necessarily surprising. Back then, these hip-hop communities on BBS(bulletin board system) would consider 1TYM and YG's music as "fake" and not "authentic hip-hop." In hindsight, they were shallow and vague criticisms. Including myself, I don't think any of us had an in-depth and comprehensive understanding of hip-hop. That's how things were.

Youngdae Kim While hip-hop was "declared" as a genre in the early 2000s, I believe the public began to understand what it really is after the 2010s, following the overwhelming success of "Show Me the Money." The idols who appeared

after this recognition were probably accepted in a different context compared to 1TYM. Certainly, the criticism against them also became more specific. For instance, 1TYM was mainly chastised for the quality of their music. People would say, “That’s not authentic hip-hop that I know.”

Bong-hyeon Kim Because BTS debuted with an identity as a hip-hop idol, they encountered harsh attacks from many hip-hop fans. They were specifically bashed in terms of authenticity and legitimacy. Their smoky makeup and perfectly arranged choreography became the target of condemnation. People would question, “Why are men wearing makeup?” or “Why would rappers dance?” I don’t agree with all the doubts directed against BTS, but I do think this process was inevitable for the period of transition. It made me realize how idols and hip-hop inherently conflict with one another.

Youngdae Kim I’ve presented on this topic at an American music conference. Many Americans were interested in finding out how idols and hip-hop can coexist together. They were wondering the self-contradictory nature of the idea. Like you said, hip-hop idol is an oxymoron, like “hot ice.”

Bong-hyeon Kim The image (and the essence) of “service” and “strategically created product” that applies to idols is

inevitably in conflict with the hip-hop attitude and sentiments, which are rooted in street culture and the spirit of defiance. I still lament that the quality hip-hop tracks in BTS' albums and RM and SUGA's rap skills were also written off as one lump just because these elements collide.

Youngdae Kim Rather than what's right or wrong, if we look at it in terms of the influence of hip-hop, perhaps this can be an example of its popular impact as a genre.

Bong-hyeon Kim In the end, I believe the advent of hip-hop idols was inevitable in the process of popularization and expansion of hip-hop. Some may refer to it as spoiling or killing hip-hop, but I don't subscribe to that idea. When there is something new, it would always be called fake or encounter resistance. To me, hip-hop idols were always an impending future for the genre. I wouldn't call them the more evolved form, but it is one of the future forms that hip-hop had to embrace.

Youngdae Kim Instead of obsessing over how hip-hop can be in the form of an idol, perhaps we should take a detailed look at their attitude or what they are saying.

Bong-hyeon Kim At the core, I don't think we can completely understand hip-hop idols by approaching them in

dichotomous domains of hip-hop and idol. For example, iKon's Bobby is known for behaviors that are prohibited to idols, such as swearing or revealing their past without qualms. Rather than perceiving that as an idol being absorbed by hip-hop or pretending to be hip-hop, I see it as a fusion of two domains to form something new. Same goes for Jay Park. Instead of thinking an ex-idol has entered the hip-hop scene, we should think that Jay Park pioneered a new path and chartered his territory.

Youngdae Kim The format of hip-hop idol may seem like they are adopting it in a shallow way, but you can also consider their role in widely promoting the talents of Korean hip-hop and rap to the global K-pop fans. In fact, aren't many artists in Korean hip-hop receiving new limelight due to the rise of K-pop and hip-hop idols? Especially abroad, idols and K-pop are leading these indie or minor genres of music.

Bong-hyeon Kim I agree. As with everything, the level and the perspective affect the interpretation. I definitely think such positive effects must not be overlooked.

Youngdae Kim Going back to BTS, in the early days of their career, Korean underground hip-hop communities were not very favorable toward them, though such sentiments mostly

disappeared by now. I mean both hip-hop musicians and fans. One of the prime examples is an episode of your podcast, "Hip-hop Invitation." In fact, I know there was more covert criticism toward BTS than what we've heard. Do you think such a disapproving tendency still exists in the hip-hop scene?

Bong-hyeon Kim I think there's less of it nowadays. To me, this reality is pretty ironic. RM and SUGA demonstrated styles that were closer to hip-hop in the early days, and both had good rap skills. Even back then, I tried my best to evaluate their abilities fairly instead of judging them by their cover as an idol group. But all I received from hip-hop communities was a backlash. They'd say I'm sucking idol asses, and such. On the other hand, now that BTS has obtained top worldwide prestige, their attitude flipped again. It left a sour taste in my mouth.

Youngdae Kim Disregarding their status as idols, how do you evaluate the BTS rappers' skills? Ultimately, that's where they must earn their credibility. Personally, perhaps because of his heavy baritone voice, I can sense the influence of both classic American and Korean hip-hop from RM. As for SUGA, his lyrics and tone highly reflect the clout of Dynamic Duo and other domestic rappers.

Bong-hyeon Kim RM's techniques were excellent from the beginning.

The Cypher series and his solo mixtapes prove themselves. Same goes for SUGA. His rap has a rawer feel to it compared to RM (not in a negative way, but they have different styles), and his skill has been competent since debut. I am repeating myself, but I have always thought both of them were good rappers from the beginning.

Youngdae Kim BTS' music not only has dance tunes with hip-hop elements but also highly authentic rap music like the Cypher series, "Outro: Her," and "Outro: Tear" in the recent albums. What do you think is their most notable hip-hop track?

Bong-hyeon Kim I like all the Cypher series. My favorite is "BTS Cypher, Pt. 3: KILLER" out of all of them. This was unfiltered fury and came straight from their heart. It will probably go down in history as the most explicit, or the most hip-hop moment from a Korean idol boy band.

Youngdae Kim The role of their producers including Pdogg and Supreme Boi was also integral to BTS' success. Compared to other idol producers, they had a deep understanding of old school hip-hop as their basis, and their strength is integrating multiple elements from various trendy music. As

a hip-hop columnist, how do you assess their composition or producing style?

Bong-hyeon Kim Pdogg is not only a producer but a big follower of hip-hop. When I talked to him, I could tell right away that he is very knowledgeable about American hip-hop from the 1980-90s. Pdogg also kept up with what's trendy and has incorporated those elements in BTS' music. While people mostly focused on the lyrics of "Go Go," anyone who has followed American hip-hop can spot the influence of the newest hip-hop trend. During a phone conversation with Pdogg in 2018, he told me, "The foundation of BTS' music is hip-hop. Over time, they expanded their boundary toward pop. The guideline for making music for BTS was meeting the 'global standard.' We didn't try to emphasize their Korean identity because they are from Korea, nor did we attempt to cater to the Americans preference. All we did was keeping up with the trend and where the universal standard is heading."

Bong-hyeon Kim

Bong-hyeon Kim is often called a music critic, but he prefers the title "hip-hop journalist." Kim has written and translated several books on hip-hop, including *Hip-Hop: How Black Music Took Over the World* and *Hip-Hop Revolution*. He has

organized Seoul Hip-hop Film Festival and produced a hip-hop documentary called Respect for theatrical release.

Part 2

BTS

the New Model of K-pop

In this chapter, I analyze BTS' music and career during The Most Beautiful Moment in Life era when they became an alternative K-pop group with the narrative of youth and authenticity. The answer to "Why BTS, out of all idol groups?" is obviously found in their music, featuring sentiments and attitudes that set them apart from those of conventional K-pop artists. Their fandom, ARMY, was also a part of proclaiming the new age of K-pop.

BTS: THE REVIEW



Column 03

Narrative and Authenticity over Localization

BTS and their ARMY: the Alternative Path of K-pop Globalization

American popular music, represented by genres such as jazz, rock and roll, and hip-hop, has dominated the absolute position in the center and solidified the structure of unilateral dissemination. American pop was synonymous with pop music in general, and almost every genre and style were created in the U.S. before spreading worldwide. Aside from British pop, which is intimately connected to American pop and must be considered as part of one scene, no agent has breached or appeared as a significant alternative to this current. Genres like mambo, bossa nova, and reggae have had occasional moments in limelight amid the dance

music frenzy, but strictly speaking, Latin music is also an internal strand of American popular music that has been overshadowed by the black-white racial dichotomy. It left even less room for Asian music. Ethnic music gained followers in cities such as San Francisco on the West Coast, but the consumption was essentially limited to immigrants. J-pop garnered some interest in New York in the early 2000s, but it was more of a hipster culture distant from the mainstream. Then out of nowhere, K-pop arrived on the scene. K-pop, nominally PSY's "Gangnam Style," was catapulted from social media and demonstrated for the first time that the transmission and the trend of pop music are no longer unilateral. It is particularly interesting because the central agent was not from the U.S. or a western nation. How was it possible for a popular music trend that wasn't from the U.S. but Korea occupy Asia, the largest continent, then become popular in Europe, South America, the Middle East, and even captivate North America? To an extent, it showcased the possibility of a pluralistic structure, a significant event in the global cultural history.

In the beginning, K-pop was not necessarily ambitious about taking over the world. It started as a venture in other parts of East Asia to escape the saturated domestic market or was a spillover of popularity from the Hallyu drama sensation. H.O.T.'s popularity in China and Clon's unexpected success in Taiwan, the major events that led to the coinage of the term Hallyu, were accidental successes without strategic effort. But these small achievements provided the

important precedence for founding the K-pop industry, a whole new, unknown continent.

It was tough to start from scratch. The initial destinations Japan and China were prone to strong cultural exclusionary tendencies with high language barriers, despite belonging in the Asian cultural sphere together. To overcome the obstacle, the K-pop industry's key cultural technology, localization strategies were devised. The first target destination was Japan—the style of trendy music was similar to Korea, and linguistic training was also relatively easy. Through an audition, SM Entertainment discovered BoA at age twelve and began training her to target Korea and Japan simultaneously under “Sinbi Project.” The amount of SM's investment totaled almost 3 billion won in 1997, a whopping sum for a time of severe national financial crisis. In addition to dancing and singing, BoA was taught English and Japanese. Her identity was created as a J-pop, instead of a K-pop, singer. After releasing a Japanese album in 2002, she topped the charts in just a few years. The key elements of experience that SM gained from producing BoA were applied not only to the production of their subsequent idols but to K-pop idols in the entire industry.

The localization strategy of idol singers following BoA does not largely deviate from this model. The strategy of prioritizing Japan is still very much in place. However, actively promoting as a localized artist like BoA requires a tremendous amount of preparation, and it was limited from responding flexibly to the expanding global market. To address the problem, the agencies incorporated foreigner or

overseas Korean members as cultural mediators. Today, you can find one or more international members selected through overseas auditions in many idol groups that are popular abroad. Tiffany and Jessica in Girls' Generation are Korean Americans, BamBam in GOT7 and Lisa in BLACKPINK are Thai, and in TWICE, Tzuyu is Taiwanese, and Momo and Sana are Japanese. In the global market, they play the role of K-pop ambassadors and cultural interpreters. They are responsible for interviewing and handling rap parts in English, Japanese, or Chinese, and their representative presence often becomes the decisive factor in local promotions. The secret behind the status of TWICE in the Japanese market and the explosive popularity of GOT7 and BLACKPINK in Thailand seems glaringly obvious.

However, K-pop's localization strategy was a specialized model for Asia, with a focus on East and South East Asia. It was evidently limited in the West, especially in the United States, the home base and potentially the largest market of popular music. Granted, there have been earlier attempts that yielded a certain level of results. Based on the success and recognition in Japan, BoA released an English album *BoA* in 2009. She entered the Billboard album chart for the first time as a K-pop singer. In the same year, Wonder Girls received media attention with "Nobody," the first hit single for K-pop. These are doubtlessly important moments to remember for breaching the Billboard chart, which used to be considered nearly impossible. BIGBANG, the first K-pop artist to complete a large

arena show in the U.S., and Girls' Generation, who made the first appearance in an American talk show on public broadcast, gave credence to the expansion of K-pop's popularity in the U.S. However, these achievements were limited in their scope. While entering the charts certainly proved their potential, reaching the upper ranks seemed an impossible task. Until PSY's "Gangnam Style" became an international viral sensation, none of the K-pop singles released in the U.S. reached the higher ranks of Top 40. Similarly, out of twelve K-pop albums that made their way to Top 200, only two records had made it to Top 100 prior to BTS in 2016. Given the general prominence of K-pop, it is unfair to view this as a failure. Although it is difficult to quantify, when I observed BIGBANG, 2NE1, EXO, and other K-pop groups' activities and their fans' reactions, I was able to sense the huge change in the interest, if not "fever," for K-pop. The clout of K-pop was definitely growing in an unprecedented scale.

A common thread is found in the previous examples. In the history of K-pop, the success in the North American market and the Billboard charts had been monopolized by the artists in Korea's "Big 3" agencies—SM, JYP, and YG. Based on their large accumulation of capital and long-term experience, they were effective at producing trendy and stylish music and were equipped with systematic strategies of localization. General music fans may not be aware, but for an artist or a piece of music to become successful, the role of a local agency or promoter and its relationship with the press and

broadcasting stations are immensely critical, if not the decisive factor in the U.S. music industry. For Asian musicians who have limited opportunities for exposure, TV appearances and advertisement crucially affect the sales volume. The most successful case in the U.S., PSY, was also backed robustly by the industry's top promoter Scooter Braun. 2NE1 member CL's American promotions are also made possible by Braun's expertise and influence. However, the U.S. market was a solid fortress that wouldn't budge, even for the Big 3.

The fact that BTS knocked over all such obstacles on their own and transformed the terrain of the market is nothing short of a miracle to those who know the mechanism of the industry. Since their debut, all of their achievements in the U.S. market have set new records in K-pop history. When they were still rookies in Korea, they introduced two albums on the Billboard 200 in 2015. With *WINGS*, they ascended to the 26th place, finally breaking the barrier of Top 40. Since 2016, BTS ranked a total of eight albums, two solo records (mixtapes) in the top 100, three of which rose to the top 10 and two albums reached no.1. As of February 2019, thirteen K-pop singles have made it in the top 100, and five of those are by BTS. "Fake Love" and "IDOL" achieved tenth and eleventh places, respectively. They have yet to produce something comparable to PSY's "Gangnam Style," but these are astonishing records. Longevity on the chart is even more important as it shows the staying power of their influence. It was the weakest vulnerability of K-pop, as their

fans are relatively small in size and hurdles were high for continuous promotions through broadcasts, including radio. Besides PSY, no other artist had remained on the charts for over two weeks prior to BTS. It was the ultimate obstacle that K-pop's localization strategy could not overcome. Although numbers don't explain everything, BTS is conquering every limitation in K-pop history with their record-breaking career.

If K-pop acts essentially cannot succeed in the international market without localization, and that localization strategy is highly limited in the U.S. market, how did BTS become the only artist to top the U.S. charts without even the most basic strategies? To answer this question, we need to reexamine the nature of K-pop and consider why it received spotlight in the global market to begin with. Only then we will find the clues to both the limitations of existing K-pop and BTS' success. The basis of K-pop—especially idol music—is providing the “total package” of comprehensive experience. It entails the harmony of handsome looks, trendy music, and spectacular performance. The precondition for this collective experience is achieving global aesthetics that eliminates national traits. Since the early 2000s, K-pop idol agencies have developed a number of similar methodologies to establish this ultimate package. One of them is a system that fosters “trainees.” K-pop's exceptional training system minimizes national traits and individualities, as well as generates consistent qualities of music and artists. This is the

central driving force that has enabled K-pop to sweep virtually all music markets besides the U.S. and Europe in the 2000s.

But in the case of the United States, things are different. First, the edgy contemporaneity of K-pop is lost when competing with American pop, its original model. Inevitably, the absence of originality in music accompanies the weakness of authenticity in message and attitude. The American press and the general public have high standards on artistic authenticity and are prone to consciously or unconsciously resist the standardized nature of K-pop. On the surface, they seem to be fascinated and enchanted at the splendor it offers, but in most cases, Korean idols merely serve as exotic spectacles. Negative impressions against K-pop's artificial "star-making system" also surface occasionally. In the early 2010s, one of the terms used to report the global success and the rising interest on K-pop in the U.S. was "factory idols." The connotation was negative, depicting K-pop artists as manufactured products indistinguishable from one another. It may indicate the mainstream stereotype against Asians and the obscure anxiety against the rise of K-pop. Historically, Asians have been boxed into certain stereotypes in the U.S. An example is the unattractive Asian male who lacks sexual appeals. Increasingly, K-pop idols' handsome looks and powerful dance moves are conquering these ideas, but it also confirms and reinforces the belief that their music is manufactured, deficient in individuality.

Is BTS entirely free from such prejudice? We cannot overlook the fact that they are also idols who are designed and trained by their K-pop agency. They certainly have the fundamental limitations that still binds them under similar perspectives. However, they have managed to at least partially overcome these restraints in distinctive ways. BTS did not purposely record or produce albums in English. They did not target the U.S. by employing the essential elements of K-pop localization, such as transnational collaborations with foreign composer or producers, Korean American or foreign members as the token presence of contemporaneity and cultural mediators to American popular music. To be precise, they had no concept of advancing to the U.S. market. Paradoxically, the absence of such a strategy distinguished them musically and provided the basis for their unexpected success. The minimal (or absent) strategy that fascinated the closed U.S. market and set unprecedented records is closely related to their identity as an “un-K-pop” K-pop group, in terms of authentic musical attitude and narrative. Admittedly, BTS also underwent a similar training system as any other idol group, but the crucial difference is that all the BTS members were either recruited with creative abilities or engaged in music production in the early stages of their career. Based on such foundations, the synergy was maximized with the existing strength of K-pop, e.g., trendy music and spectacular performances. To top it off, they adopted the language and attitude of hip-hop, the trendiest genre that represents the spirit of the age, to express their thoughts genuinely, however

unpolished they may sound. Their refreshing style was recognized widely by the U.S. media, critics, and audiences who viewed idol culture unfavorably and were sensitive to artistic authenticity. Now, is it fair to attribute their success simply to good luck?

According to the ARMYs I have encountered in the U.S. over the past few years, BTS' music is "different" to them. They feel something special that was missing in American pop music, including hip-hop, and previous cases of K-pop music. While there are multiple reasons, the key to such "difference" may be the universality and the wholesome nature of their messages. BTS is the one and only K-pop group that has embraced the narrative of youth and growth, previously avoided in idol music, as their central concept and identity and integrated them into profound messages and trendy music. Following the School Trilogy, their narrative started to develop solidly through the Most Beautiful Moment in Life series. It differed from the conceptual and fictional world view of existing K-pop idols. They were also distinguished from the American mainstream hip-hop, indulged excessively in self-verification and the narrative of macho swagger. The scorching energy of "Dope" and "FIRE," the dauntless young musicianship demonstrated in the Cypher series and "Mic Drop," sharp social critique in "Go Go," and the despair, sorrow, and hope of the wounded youth in "Epilogue: Young Forever" and "Spring Day" have propelled them over the greatest weakness of K-pop—the limitations of authenticity in message and attitude. These

diverse, sincere, and universal words cannot be created by training and localization strategies.

The authenticity of the BTS narrative, which has become the essence of their career, is reflected constantly in their everyday life and communication with fans on social media. Even in the early days of their career, when most idol agencies control their artists' activities on social media or only show what is immaculately planned due to various risks, BTS overcame their shortage of capital by fully utilizing the new media revolution as they fostered intimacy with fans. The key to this was their consistent attitude and genuine sincerity. Their presence online directly reflected their narrative without any awkward, pretentious gestures. The unity of words, actions, and music by BTS became the major reason for the expansion of their voluntary and enthusiastic fandom, ARMY.

International ARMYs sympathize with the music of BTS despite having different nationalities and cultures, and have a similar, if not higher, level of enthusiasm that they would show toward local artists. I think it's because BTS doesn't artificially localize to fit specific region or culture, but incorporate their own identities in the narrative and stay faithful to the most fundamental methodology of music. Regardless of their nationalities, ARMYs identify with and understand BTS' experience of hardship as underdogs, their growth, anxieties, and joy over the years. In American and Japanese idol cultures, the concept of "growth" is limited to the superficial and hypothetical realm of artistic expression. However, BTS' authenticity

permeates every part of their music and life, providing an extreme sense of unity and comradeship to their fans. This is a revolutionary shift in pop music that normally regards fans as external entities.

Here, we must pay attention to BTS' ARMY for defining a new notion of fandom as the product of powerful unity and comradeship. ARMYs are not passive fans who simply go to concerts and buy CDs. They generate critical discourses within the fandom, analyze music and lyrics as much as critics if not more, and strive to exonerate BTS from misconceptions about them. The international ARMY has already achieved beyond what any PR department of K-pop agencies is capable of. "The White Paper Project,"¹³⁾ created by international ARMYs when BTS was criticized by the Japanese right-wing media and a few Korean media in response to the "Liberation Day T-shirt controversy" in 2018, was an innovative feat. For those in cultural studies, it was an impressive example of how sophisticated a fandom can advance, as the sheer scale of research and logic they accumulated, comparable to the level of professional scholarly articles, provided more than sufficient defense for BTS.

Another ingenious culture among the ARMY is their unique network and bond. In general, the cultural ownership of K-pop groups, including BTS, is considered to belong to Korean fans. However, within the particular context of the BTS phenomenon—especially in the U.S.—the North American ARMY's agency in their devoted effort does not lack in any way compared to their fans in the motherland. Witnessing the borderless phenomenon

that BTS is creating together, they respect the presence of each other and display an exceptionally strong attachment as a group. They translate each other's texts into multiple languages, share them widely, discuss cultural differences, and encourage each other to help BTS achieve higher performance when their records are released. This is how international BTS fans, endearingly called "I-Lovelies (international lovelies)" have become the first historical agents among K-pop fandoms. Fundamentally, this was possible because BTS' music contains universal messages that can appeal across cultures, seamlessly binding a diverse array of fans.

It is unclear whether BTS's strategy of "narrative authenticity" can be similarly effective for other K-pop groups. The current direction of development in K-pop is the enhancement of existing localization strategies, regardless of the success of BTS. Last year, J. Y. Park of JYP declared an era of "globalization by localization" at a presentation titled, "JYP 2.0." He proposed to develop, produce, and release music by utilizing the talents from all over the world. Reportedly, Park has launched a six-member boy band recruited in China, "Boy Story," in June last year, and a girl group is planned to debut in Japan in the latter half of 2019. SM Entertainment revealed their strategy early in 2016 with "NCT Project." In this system, SM also recruits members from each region to form groups or units that promote locally. Their China unit has already launched. As such, K-Pop is now evolving from the consolidated training system to the phase of localized modularization.

At the same time, the success of BTS in the global pop market, especially in the United States, is also inducing a new trend among other groups. An increasing number of idols, including Monsta X and Stray Kids, have begun to engage in production of their music seriously. They are starting to present more authentic messages and coordinating the consistency of their narrative and personalities. They seem to be following the path that led BTS to success. The trend is also joined by SM, the agency on the opposite side of the spectrum that used to focus on perfection of musicality rather than narrative authenticity. For their major project at the moment, NCT, SM started releasing materials that vigorously integrate personal stories of members. Though their authenticity and individuality are not replicable, BTS has provided lessons for K-pop in ways that no one had anticipated. Led by BTS and their ARMY, a new era of K-pop globalization is beginning to unfold.

Review 06

The Most Beautiful Moment in Life, Pt. 1

(2015, EP)



Album

Review



Completing the journey that explored the meaning of youthful dreams and happiness with *DARK&WILD*, they take a step further by expanding the narrative and images with *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life*.

Though their wild masculine energy as a hip-hop idol has not completely disappeared, hip-hop is now embraced as a basic attitude and one of many musical aspects, rather than an encompassing concept. Their vocals began to emerge more prominently, and the role of rap parts were revised to reinforce the concept and mood of the music, as opposed to displaying techniques for show.

Two of the most eclectic representations of these changes and new musical intentions are “I NEED U” and “Dope.” These songs are also the archetypical songs of BTS’s entire discography. The center of musical gravity that had geared more heavily toward the rap members RM and SUGA is now more balanced as each member’s skills matured. Accordingly, the direction of production also began to try much more diverse experiments. This

is the point of origin for BTS' unique world view and imagery, leading all the way to *LOVE YOURSELF* album.

Track

Review

1 Intro: The Most Beautiful Moment in Life

(Slow Rabbit, SUGA)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“I throw at the rim all the concerns
and worries about life”

The first step of the Youth series begins with the bouncing of a basketball on the ground. It sounds as if you're watching a scene from a television drama or an animation about the growth and agony of youth. As you listen to the track, it helps to think about how the keywords “sports” and “youth” both evoke the image of dream, passion, and challenge. In fact, the stage name for SUGA was also derived from the basketball position “shooting guard.” His rap skills have improved significantly since the School Trilogy, combining technique, philosophical lyrics, and emotional dimension wonderfully to achieve musicality.

2 I NEED U

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Brother Su)

Produced by Pdogg

“I’m sorry (I hate u),
I love you (I hate u),
forgive me (shit)”

This is an unforgettable song in BTS’ career. When the lyricism of the initial exotic melody meets the sorrowful chorus, they create an intense and melancholic atmosphere. The overall impression of the song is memorable for its sentimentality, in spite of the tense progression created by the powerful trap beats and the rapping of the verse. In terms of BTS’ career, this song was the first shot toward nationwide success for a rookie hip-hop idol.

3 Hold Me Tight

(Slow Rabbit, Pdogg, V, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“You still sparkle brightly,
like a fragrant flower”

As it is arranged based on sexy and sensual slow jam R&B, if you don’t listen carefully to the lyrics, you might have a completely different impression of the song. But when you follow the lyrics, it expresses a youth

desperately craving for love, which sounds more wistful than sensual. The vocal members' savvy groove over the beat is particularly notable here.

4 Skit: Expectation!

Produced by Pdogg, "hitman" bang

"You think you can reach No.1?"

No longer the excited newcomers, BTS anticipates and worries candidly about their imminent success.

5 Dope

(Pdogg, Earattack, "hitman" bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

"The press and the adults write us off
why do they kill us before we even try"

It is a hip-hop dance track that effectively presents the distinct character of BTS, from the intense title "Dope" to the intro that teases with "Welcome to BTS," and the ferocious atmosphere of the music. The immaturity of the title and the narration might give a shallow impression, but the lyrics stress their hard work behind the scene.

Such unexpected wholesomeness is at the heart of the quintessential “BTS style,” as referred in the lyrics. By placing a drop¹⁴⁾ part in the chorus instead of a melody, the track was a fresh attempt to amplify the destructive effect of their performance.

6 Boyz with Fun

(SUGA, Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, j-hope, Jin, Jimin, V)

Produced by SUGA, Pdogg

“Don’t ask me I’ve always been this way,
I don’t know myself either
From the start to finish, this is who I am”

The retro funk revived by British producer and DJ Mark Ronson’s “Uptown Funk” has influenced K-pop quite significantly. “Boyz with Fun” by BTS is one of the most notable examples. Musically, when this type of genre is transplanted to K-pop, it is critical to avoid sounding dull while maintaining the repetitive groove of the song. This track does not drop the “fun” until the end as the tone of the rappers keeps varying and additional ad-libs continue to fill the void.

7 Converse High

(Pdogg, Slow Rabbit, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg, Slow Rabbit

“I’m gonna meet the person who made Converse high tops, and tell him, you saved the world”

Cheerful guitars and sentimental chord work continue the youthful imagery of the School Trilogy. Footwear brands are a common reference in the hip-hop genre. This song illustrates romantic feelings toward a love interest with Converse high tops as a metaphor.

8 Moving On

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Imma take it up a notch
from being an idol
Goodbye now”

The track begins with RM speaking to SUGA, an unusual style for idol music that makes it one-of-a-kind. The title originally denotes the literal relocation of residence, referring to the real-life story of BTS moving out of their old dorm to better accommodation. But the translated title in overseas streaming platforms, “Moving On,” signifies

something deeper. For BTS, the rookie years may have been exciting, happy years after finally making a debut, but it was also a period when they were doubted, disregarded, and undervalued. Finally, they are past those sorry years as they go forward, moving on to the next chapter in lives and career. The heartfelt imagery of a young man who, “on [his] way out with the luggage, pause[s] and take[s] a look around,” is gently moving; as one graduates from one stage of life, he is maturing over time.

9 Outro: Love Is Not Over

(Jung Kook, Slow Rabbit, Pdogg, Jin)

Produced by Jung Kook, Slow Rabbit

“Without you,
I just can’t go on”

The development of the first half is quite special, carried out only on the minimalist piano. It demonstrates how the vocal members have grown in their expressions. Jung Kook’s vocals in particular very aptly portray the jazzy and sentimental aspects of the song, and this is the track he produced for the first time, expanding the reach of his musical involvement beyond the early period of career.

Review 07

The Most Beautiful Moment in Life, Pt. 2

(2015, EP)



Album

Review



Part 2 of the Youth series focuses on the serious and speculative aspects of youth, distinguished from Part 1 that depicts their playful, uplifting dimension. The lyrics became more thoughtful and profound, and the nuances of music also became subtler and more complex.

Some might say that transformations in idol music are merely a change in the conceptual setting that the producer intended. However, I view this as the inevitable change when the BTS members started becoming aware of themselves as professional musicians, during the process of multiple transformations they experienced as a group. “Run” and “Silver Spoon” merge the tried-and-true style of Pt. 1 with BTS’ identity at a more mature level, while “Butterfly” and “Autumn Leaves” are well-made tracks that demonstrate the culmination of BTS’ style of composition. Also, their musical experimentation in “House of Cards” affirms their self-confidence and maturity, as professionals who have broken out of their shell and are on track to become full-fledged musicians.

Track

Review

1 Intro: Never Mind

(Slow Rabbit, SUGA)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“If you’re gonna crash, hit it harder, dude”

As in the Intro of Pt.1, Slow Rabbit’s beats are joined by SUGA’s voice. The loud cheers at a concert hall, inserted at the opening of the track, reveals the huge change in their popularity just a few months after the previous mini album. SUGA is now speaking seriously about “success,” discussing his desire and will to go one step further without losing what he has accomplished. Thrilled about everything they have started to achieve, confidence overflows in every corner of the track.

2 RUN

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, V, Jung Kook, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Even if I can’t have you, I’m all right

This foolish fate, curse me out”

The intro induces an exotic atmosphere, possibly suggesting an emotional connection with the hit “I NEED U” from the last album. Apropos to the title “Run,” the fearless rushing of the beats and the burst of rugged rock in the chorus part adhere faithfully to the grammar and the sentiment of EDM music. The raw, youthful energy coupled with subtle lyricism is signature BTS-style.

3 Butterfly

(“hitman” bang, Slow Rabbit, Pdogg, Brother Su)

Produced by Pdogg

“I wanna stop the time
Once this moment’s gone,
will it become nothing?
I’m afraid of losing you”

Out of the whole album, this track has the richest musical texture. The phrase “Butterfly” in the chorus is beautifully played in several different voicing variations. The melody is quite expressive, but Jung Kook’s vocals that render the breadth of delicate and profound emotions and V’s contrasting voice that enhances the stylish appeal are at the heart of this song. This is one of the trademark tracks from *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* era, which marks the watershed moment that signals BTS’ transition into a

new direction. It was remixed into two different versions later.

4 Whalien 52

(Pdogg, Brother Su, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by Pdogg

“Can I, a desolate island, shine brightly?”

It is a hip-hop song using the “high-pitch sample” technique, which increases the pitch of the vocals as if the music is played fast. It was popular in the mid-2000s among American hip-hop artists, including Kanye West. Here, it was used to add pizzazz and not as the core methodology of music composition. Based on the creative premise of “a whale singing at the frequency of 52Hz,” its lonely struggle becomes a touching allegory for BTS’ journey.

5 Ma City

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Wherever you live, wherever I live”

In hip-hop, being honest about your origins is probably the most important for obtaining musical authenticity. Out of all the idol groups, has anyone else been this frank about their origin? This is where BTS' career is downright distinguished. Though it sounds like a song of affection for the city they were born and raised, the fact that BTS looked back at their roots at the moment of recognizable success implies that they are determined to maintain their initial mentality.

6 Silver Spoon

(Pdogg, Supreme Boi, RM, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by Pdogg

“They call me a crow-tit,
we’ve suffered, this generation
Quick, go chase ‘em
Thanks to the stork, my crotch is scarred”

“Silver Spoon” is the purest hip-hop track, typical of *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* era. On trendy trap beats, they allude to themselves as a crow-tit, the suffering younger generation of the day who have to challenge unfavorable conditions in the world constantly. The varied styles of rappers and the sensible melody validate this signature BTS track.

7 Skit: One Night in a Strange City

Produced by Pdogg, “hitman” bang, Slow Rabbit

Anxiety often looms over those at the threshold of success. “Maybe this is a dream.”

8 Autumn Leaves

(SUGA, Slow Rabbit, Jung Kook, “hitman” bang, RM, j-hope, Pdogg)

Produced by SUGA, Slow Rabbit

“You’re my fifth season,
I want to see you but I can’t
See, you’re still blue to me”

A particular musical synergy is achieved in joint efforts by SUGA and producer Slow Rabbit. “Autumn Leaves” is a hidden masterpiece in that line of distinctive lyricism. Employing the metaphor of dried-out autumn leaves for an expected end of romance is very classical and literary. V’s moody voice and Jung Kook’s precociously sensual voice amplifies the allure of the song.

9 Outro: House of Cards

(Slow Rabbit, Brother Su, “hitman” bang)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“In that house of cards,
until we see the end,
even if we collapse”

With “Butterfly,” this is one of the most iconic songs in the album. The deep tone of the contrabass leads the solemn structure, the rush of string orchestra fills the instrumentals, and the jazzy chord work coalesce together to create an unprecedented level of refined sounds in previous BTS music. More than any other song, the level of unity and concentration achieved makes them sound like a vocal group.

Review 08

The Most Beautiful Moment in Life: Young Forever

(2016, Repackage)



Album

Review



The Most Beautiful Moment in Life: Young Forever was the ultimate breakthrough. Although it is a special album in a repackaged format, the added new songs are important works that symbolize their growth and performance, both commercially and musically. The world view of the Youth series, which deserves to be distinguished as an era, obtained the internal integrity of the narrative through the grand finale of *Young Forever*. The music achieved an exquisite balance of popular appeal and commerciality while establishing the signature sound of BTS that could not be easily emulated. Harking back to BTS' career that started as underdogs who endured ups and downs, this was indeed a poignant turning point.

"FIRE" is a significant track that demonstrated how their raw, youthful energy can become explosively popular to the masses while still maintaining BTS' identity of a hip-hop group. This was the song that imprinted their presence to the wider public. "Save Me" is one of the most BTS-esque pieces that show how trendy

genres can be transformed into BTS' signature style of music through ingenious lyrics and elaborate production. Above all, "Epilogue: Young Forever" is an impressive masterpiece that condenses the essence and sentiment of all the themes in the Youth series. It provides the reason for this album to be evaluated on its own. This is decidedly one of the most important albums of BTS' career.

Track

Review

1 FIRE

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, Devine Channel)

Produced by Pdogg

“Be the ruler of your own world, it’s your life anyway
Don’t fret too much, it’s okay to lose”

I was in utter shock after watching this performance at KCON 2016. The clue to the unusual appeal of this piece is in the enormous energy that the song and its performance exude. The energy emanating from the chorus exploding at the outcry of “Fire” is something that intuitively drives listeners and viewers wild. That is, even without including the reactions to the music video. The incredible energy of the sound itself also stands out among many contemporary dance music. If we analyze the song only from the technical dimension of music, is “FIRE” the most sophisticated and meticulous song out of the entire BTS’ discography or contemporary K-pop? Not necessarily. But the peculiar strength of this song is not simply in a few lines of melody, rap, or choreography. It is in the synergy of music, dance and the individuality of

each member. This is a characteristic that cannot be easily reproduced or imitated.

2 Save ME

(Pdogg, Ray Michael, Djan Jr, Ashton Foster, Samantha Harper, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Listen to my heartbeat,
it’s calling you”

Regardless of genre and style, BTS music has a particular sentiment of vulnerability and poignancy. It induces nostalgia and evokes protective instincts, sorrow, and lament from the listeners. It’s lamentable, but not so miserable. These emotions are not necessarily only applied to romantic music with a slow tempo. The doleful lyrics, “Give me your hand” matches the sophisticated, variegated tropical sound, creating a signature style of BTS. Such sensible placement of these musical details is probably the reason that it’s often picked as the most symbolic piece for BTS, though the specific reason is difficult to pinpoint for many.

3 Epilogue: Young Forever

(Slow Rabbit, RM, "hitman" bang, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by RM, Slow Rabbit

"I wanna be today's myself forever
I wanna be a boy forever"

All the messages that BTS intended to express through the Youth series are collected for a beautiful conclusion. The gospel-like chorus and the calm yet resonating rap part meld nicely with the sentiment of hope and sadness in the outcry, "I wanna to be a boy forever." The "youth" discussed here is not exclusively about the age but refers to anyone who has a dream. This was the first time that RM participated in producing. It left me with a positive impression to anticipate his future work as a musician.

Interview 02

Becoming Musicians Beyond Idols

Brother Su, Composer



Among idols, BTS is a team that frequently discusses their music-making process with plenty of hidden stories that have not yet been told. We have a sneak peek of the untold episodes from their *The*

Most Beautiful Moment in Life days from talking to Brother Su, the composer of “I NEED U.”

Youngdae Kim You worked on several tracks with BTS during their *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* days. A lot of them are considered masterpieces among the fans. How did you first begin working on BTS’ music?

Brother Su Singer Ra.D introduced me to producer Bang Si-hyuk in late 2013. They were preparing *SKOOL LUV AFFAIR SPECIAL ADDITION* and the first project I worked with them was the remix of the track “Like.”

Youngdae Kim The current trend in K-pop is having multiple composers divide up the work in music making process. What was your role in songwriting for BTS?

Brother Su It depends on each project. The first job I participated as a track-maker,¹⁵⁾ but in *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* series, I mostly worked on the melodies and lyrics.

Youngdae Kim As you said, your first BTS project was the remix track for “Like.” Were you surprised that you were requested to

remix a song, instead of writing one?

Brother Su It wasn't even the lead single, but this track was already well known in the social media after they debuted. I had known the song before I met them. Prior to launching my career as a singer-songwriter/composer, I had won several prizes in the remix competitions organized by hip-hop communities. I was confident about working on the remix commission.

Youngdae Kim Did you intend the "slow jam" remix from the beginning?

Brother Su Not really. After I lowered the BPM¹⁶⁾ by half, then added piano and electric piano instrumentals, as well as the pluck synth¹⁷⁾ at the end of the chorus, the sound might as well be slow jam, so I decided on that style. The basic structure was a loop, so I gave several variations in the middle section for fun. Pdogg revised the arrangement of the latter part to finalize the current form.

Youngdae Kim Let's discuss your work during *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* era, beginning with "I NEED U." The fans consider it one of the signature BTS songs. Its rather exotic sentiment gives off a distinct ambience from other

contemporary idol music. Being the first popular hit is certainly significant, too.

Brother Su This is the first track I worked on from The Most Beautiful Moment in Life series. The most memorable experience was when Mr. Bang explained the sentiments that he wished the song to embody before I started composing it. He suggested not just music for reference but a wide range of art, including films, and told me that he wanted a mutual theme that permeates those pieces. Usually, they give me the musical genre and references with the commissions I receive. His way of working was pleasantly surprising. It was also incredible to see how on the track that Pdogg prepared, the melodies created by producer Bang, BTS members, and me would be integrated or moved away from the original positions to become new melodies.

Youngdae Kim “Butterfly” is my personal favorite from *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* album. I think it’s one of the best compositions in the entire BTS discography. The original track is solid, but the sensibility of the prologue version is outstanding.

Brother Su Among all the songs I worked on with BTS, “Butterfly” is one of my favorites that I play the most. The earlier version

of the song was used in the comeback trailer for *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life, Pt. 2*, then included as a Prologue Mix in *Young Forever*. Of course, I like the original, but because I listened to the Prologue Mix version throughout the project, I have a personal attachment to it. When I worked on the song, I was abroad on a trip with a friend that was scheduled much earlier. The toplining¹⁸⁾ process was done remotely with Slow Rabbit and Mr. Bang over an online messenger. I remember recording and sending the guide at the Airbnb we were staying, while my friend was asleep. You could say that was my first experience of working overseas.

Youngdae Kim "Whalien 52" has quite a unique subject and a theme.

It's notable that you used the high-pitch method from hip-hop composition, which was prominent in the mid-2000s.

Brother Su It started from Mr. Bang's story of "a whale that sings in the frequency of 52Hz." I work much more efficiently with a story or a theme, and that subject excited me in a way that nothing had done in a while. The producer Pdogg resampled high-pitch sources to create the beat in hip-hop style. It had a gloomy feel to it and made it easy to come up with a sentimental melody. I'm proud that it came out all right in a short period. I was happy that everyone loved the

lyrics to the chorus, “Can I, a desolate island, shine brightly?” I am also really fond of the lyrics that the rap line members wrote.

Youngdae Kim “House of Cards” is quite a unique song among the BTS music. I find it interesting that the depressed mood of the minor scale isn’t something you or producer Slow Rabbit usually prefer.

Brother Su It was such a memorable project to me personally. I tend to favor working with upbeat chords in major scale, so I didn’t have much experience in writing in a minor scale. I was eager to write something dark around the time I was involved in the project. Slow Rabbit also was more used to writing beats that were lighthearted, so it was refreshing in many ways when I listened to the first time. The theme of “House of Cards” was already set before I worked on the song. According to the theme, I went onto toplining and writing of lyrics. I remember it was finished quite fast. After going through producer Bang Si-hyuk’s ideas and melody revisions, the final product came out nicely. I’m especially satisfied that so many BTS fans love it.

Youngdae Kim How was the division of labor between you and the BigHit producers Pdogg and Slow Rabbit? Was it similar to

the process of song camps¹⁹⁾?

Brother Su BigHit Entertainment usually works in teams. All the studios were located on one floor of the BigHit building, and whenever someone came up with melodies, tracks, or lyrics, we readily exchanged them to complete the writing. It's similar to a song camp, but instead of working in sessions, it was a natural cycle that went on every day.

Youngdae Kim You have extensive work experience with other agencies as well. Would you say there is something special or particular strength of BigHit behind the success of BTS?

Brother Su Usually, composers are commissioned to complete a single track in an album, as a piece of a bigger picture. But at BigHit, several of us simultaneously draw the big picture together. Since the writers continuously communicate with one another, the organic connections between the tracks and the overall narrative become more potent.

Youngdae Kim When I listen to BTS' music, there is an element of differentiation from other idols. The impression I receive from the structure and the composition of their music is more organic or unfettered. Do you think this is due to their work process?

Brother Su The work process is definitely a big part of it. In the music production team, producer Bang Si-hyuk's ingenious ideas, melodies, concepts, and producing, Pdogg's amazing musical spectrum and deep understanding of genres, as well as his refined and rich sound, Slow Rabbit's warm and sweet sensibilities, and Supreme Boi's trendy and intense wildness all coexist and harmonize in balance to amplify that unfettered atmosphere. Throughout the projects, I was constantly stimulated and inspired.

Youngdae Kim I became curious about BTS' capacity as musicians, not just as idols. As a composer who worked with them, what do you think about the strength and style of BTS vocals and rappers?

Brother Su Though RM is a rapper of the group, he seems to have a very keen sense of melody. He contributed his ideas and took the essential role in many of the tracks. As for SUGA, he impressed me with excellent producing and track-making abilities. I think j-hope really demonstrated his style with the recent mixtape. Personally, I was truly surprised at Jung Kook for his vocal tone and perfect pitch.

Youngdae Kim The members have participated directed in rap making and such since debut, and their expansion into composition, arrangement, and producing seems to be very positive. While they are idols in industrial terms, attaining that musical agency is crucial.

Brother Su Right. I'm glad they're participating more recently. It's great that the members' individual skills are improving and they are getting more opportunities to express own style. Each one understands the features and strengths of his voice and knows how to utilize them. I personally listen to "Magic Shop" in *Tear* co-produced by Jung Kook.

Youngdae Kim As a musician who has worked with BTS, what do think is BTS' greatest strength? To you, what is their secret to becoming a worldwide superstar?

Brother Su The biggest appeal of BTS is that they have a distinct character that cannot be replaced by anyone else. Both rap and vocal members have unique characteristics that stand out, which they incorporate into their albums proactively to make their music all the more special. I would also include their strong teamwork and endless practices.

Youngdae Kim It seems like everyone who worked with BTS mentions their great teamwork and passion. You can't leave out their unaffected, raw individuality and personal charms.

Brother Su Since they don't promote when we make music, they have relatively more time to enjoy that leisure. It really touched me when the members came to the practice halls and studio almost every day during the holidays or long weekends to work on something or practice. I'm not the best people person, so it takes me a long time to approach others. The BTS members said hi to me first and greeted me warmly at the studio. They really are charming boys. I was pleasantly surprised the first time I met them, and they amaze me every time. I'm very much looking forward to their future.

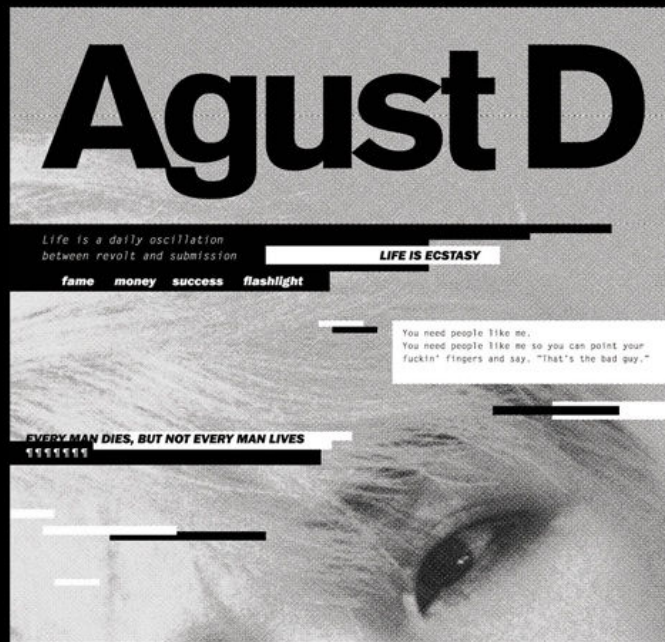
Brother Su

Brother Su is a Korean singer-songwriter and producer who debuted in 2010 with an EP and an album. He has composed and written lyrics for artists including BTS, Zion.T, Heize, and BLACKPINK among others.

Review 09

AGUST D BY AGUST D

(2016, Mixtape)



Album

Review



What does it mean for an artist to release work under a new name? Usually, artists make such a decision to break the existing framework that had confined them. A new name denotes a new artistic ego, and a new identity as an artist who has never been presented. There must be numerous reasons why this album's artist name is "Agust D" instead of "SUGA." One of the important motivations is probably to showcase his unprocessed raw self, to be evaluated properly for his music. If you recap the situation before the mixtape came out in 2016, you will discover why SUGA was so determined to express himself artistically.

BTS, right after debuting as a hip-hop idol, had to face acute criticism from the indie hip-hop scene and the existing K-pop idol fandoms. The attack from the hip-hop community, the supporters of their musical genre, must have been especially painful. While SUGA is also a rapper and a producer, the few advocates who supported BTS' music recognized them as "RM's group." The attention paid to RM, a leader and main rapper with

mature musicality and elaborate techniques, may be justified. But from the standpoint of SUGA, the label as a hip-hop idol may have hindered him from fully conveying his musical perspective and growth. At the beginning of The Most Beautiful Moment in Life era, BTS reorganized as a versatile boy band than a specialized hip-hop idol, followed by their commercial success. As an idol, a producer, a composer, and a rapper, SUGA's prestige has grown incomparable to his prior self. He has also achieved success, the most important fruit of labor. At the same time, the thirst and desire for his own music were becoming more and more intense. This is when his mixtape was produced. RM's first mixtape intended to vindicate himself, to prove that he is a skilled rap technician on par with anybody, a musician beyond an idol. What about *Agust D*? The work candidly reveals the genuine, personal dimensions and musical potentials that Min Yoon-gi as an individual and SUGA as a producer had kept to himself.

This album exposes SUGA as himself, if not more frankly. From the first track to the last, he spits out what's on his mind coarsely, vehemently and acutely, instead of dwelling on detailed techniques or musical customs of rap. Namely, "The Last," is striking, even for those who are familiar with his rap and musicality as a BTS

member. The breadth of the message is broader, and the nuance is more complicated than the music of BTS. He is quite composed as he depicts the past from his childhood, his trainee days and rising to stardom. His maturity as an MC shows as he questions the significance of all the success, instead of bragging about the accomplishment. SUGA's music is merciless against the attackers, but also frankly admits his vulnerability and weak ego. Within a group, a member is always remembered as a specific image or a part of the music. Likely, SUGA was not an exception. BTS's hidden talent and musical backbone, SUGA proved himself as a musician with a distinct ego in the toughest, most straightforward, and truest form.

Track

Review

1 Intro; Dt sugA(Feat. DJ Friz)

(Agust D, Pdogg)

Produced by Agust D, Pdogg

The intro is an edited version of “Agust D,” the subsequent track. DJ Friz, who provided scratch for the first track of BTS’ career, returned here to showcase the style of classic turntablism²⁰) hip-hop.

2 Agust D

(Agust D)

Produced by Agust D

This is “self-introduction,” a staple element of hip-hop. With an unfriendly and aggressive attitude, SUGA unleashes the identity of being reborn under the name of “Agust D,” using fast and precise rap techniques. The main theme is similar to those often found in the music of BTS. He counteracts the fact he is ignored and depreciated for being an idol. At the same time, he is confident about his already successful prowess. The emblematic phrase, “the category of K-pop has a size

unfit for me,” denotes the desire for showing his own music, different from both the music of BTS and other idols. The influence of old-school hip-hop is evident in deep and intense bass and large-scale soundscape.

3 Give it to me

(Agust D)

Produced by Agust D

In line with the stories that SUGA has told as a member of BTS, he launches full-on diss tracks toward his haters. Instead of denigrating other rappers’ skills or pompously excusing himself, SUGA counters the rappers who focus on putting down others without paying their dues. It’s a hip-hop version of “mind your own business.”

4 Skit

Produced by Agust D

The skit shows a short glimpse of why the mixtape is released under Agust D instead of SUGA. All the following tracks consist of content that explores SUGA and Agust D as a human being and as a musician.

5 724148

(Agust D)

Produced by Agust D

The story about himself begins amid the bass sound of old school hip-hop. The first track is about what “success” means to him. Just as he does in BTS’ music, SUGA refers to his hometown Daegu several times, being very open about his hometown. It reflects the unique characteristic of hip-hop, which posits the confession of one’s origin as a major factor in the musical authenticity. The story of a boy starts with his dreams about music and unfolds all the way vividly to achieving success. The contrast between Daegu and Seoul and a trainee who used to receive 300,000 won for monthly allowance and certain “someone” whose parents gifted an imported car right after graduation is amusing. He reminisces his childhood when money was scarce, which in turn made money the motivation for success.

6 140503 at dawn

(Agust D, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by Agust D

Comprised of minimal beats, this simple piece reflects SUGA as he encounters his true self in the early morning.

It is a story about the looming depression from having to hide underneath another identity, instead of revealing who he truly is. The situation is a “mask” and a “prison” at the same time. He reveals his deepest vulnerability in this track.

7 The Last

(Agust D, June, Pdogg)

Produced by Agust D, June, Pdogg

Apart from the title track, this is the most important and impressive piece on the album. More than the dramatic ambience and beats, or the rap techniques, it is the raw energy and honesty that makes it superb. Depression, obsession, and hidden vulnerabilities eventually lead to the stage of self-hatred. The narrator pessimistically portrays his soul on the verge of being consumed. However, Agust D ultimately chooses to reverse it into victorious pride before being swallowed by depression. Pointing out “who didn’t, instead of couldn’t” do it, he demands to know who deserves the right to suffering and success. From the first day as a trainee in 2010 to rising to the stardom today, he pours out all the pent-up frustration and distress to his heart’s content.

8 Tony Montana (Feat. Yankie)

(Agust D, Pdogg)

Produced by Agust D, Pdogg

Scarface, a masterpiece gangster film directed by Brian De Palma, was released in 1983. Played by the acclaimed actor Al Pacino, Tony Montana is the main character who is referenced extensively in pop culture, including music, movies, comics, and even games. In this track, Agust D portrays himself as a brutal ambitionist of hip-hop, akin to Tony Montana. Based on trap beats, the overall mood of the music also creates a bleak and cruel image of a gangster movie. The auto-tune²¹) effect generates an appropriately raspy voice, which grimly talks about success, ambition, and envy.

9 Interlude: Dream, Reality

(Agust D, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by Agust D, Slow Rabbit

While the lyrics only consist of the word “dream,” the title states both “dream” and “reality.” Depending on how you interpret what “dream” is, the hidden nuances of this song may also be varied. It may refer to the state of sleeping, an ideal you wish to achieve, or a futile hope. For Agust D, all of these meanings may be relevant.

10 So far away (Feat. SURAN)

(Agust D, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by Agust D, Slow Rabbit

Though overshadowed by his skills as a rapper, SUGA is a musician with producing style rooted in pop music. Such musicality is especially evident in the soft, lyrical songs he creates with Slow Rabbit. He asks the essence of the word “dream,” when the real world continuously force-feeds the idea. While he talks about withdrawing to a distant place, what the lyrics truly mean is the desire for a bright future, not an escape from reality.

Review 10

WINGS

(2016, Album)



Album

Review



WINGS attempts the most mature transformation since debut. This is a masterpiece created in the darkest and most depressed (at the time) tone, combining the keywords youth—presented by *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life*—temptation, and ordeal. Temptation—expressed as “evil” in the intro—as well as lies and stigma (which are also titles) imply the album’s religious theme. The narrative of “tempted youth” strongly reveals heroic and mythical influence.

The most impressive musical accomplishment in *WINGS* is the members’ potential and individuality as independent musicians, not just as parts of the group. Their solo tracks, attempted for the first time in their career as a major effort, acutely distinguish the musical style and direction of members from each other. This kind of omnibus structure is applied similarly to their later albums. *WINGS* develops further the concepts based on keywords “youth” and “growth” as presented in the Youth series, followed by the density of repackage album *YOU*

NEVER WALK ALONE, which completes the narrative of consolation and encouragement. The relationship between these two albums is similar to that of a question and answer, or a proposal and conclusion. This pattern, where one album offers clues to the answers provided by the next, recurs in *LOVE YOURSELF*. The premise is philosophical and literary in nuance. “Spring Day” became the impetus for BTS to overcome their limitations as an idol group, transforming into a universal band that appeals to a wide range of music fans. In elements external to music, *Wings* and *YOU NEVER WALK ALONE* gave rise to a more visible following that presaged the BTS phenomenon in the United States.

WINGS achieved an amazing feat by ranking 26th on the Billboard 200, which had remained the highest record for K-pop before BTS broke it a year later. “Blood Sweat & Tears” demonstrated that the expressive ability and narrative of BTS were evolving toward universal appeal, and as “Spring Day” in *YOU NEVER WALK ALONE* attracted the fans across generational boundaries, it signaled the opening of a new chapter in the BTS phenomenon.

Track

Review

1 Intro: Boy Meets Evil

(Pdogg, j-hope, RM)

Produced by Pdogg

“I know everything
Love is the other name of evil,
don’t hold those hands”

“Temptation,” the recurring theme of the album, is alluded to as “evil.” In this variation of the Christian narrative, the subject experiences agony and growth through trial. j-hope’s musical potential as a performer and a musician newly blooms in the track. His dance break in the music video is overwhelming enough to dominate the entire screen.

2 Blood Sweat & Tears

(Pdogg, RM, SUGA, j-hope, “hitman” bang, Kim Do-hun)

Produced by Pdogg

“Other than you, I cannot serve anyone else
Knowingly, I still had to drink from the poisoned chalice”

One of the most distinct musical transformations since debut, this track represents the crossover from the formula of hip-hop idol to become a pop group. It was highly influenced by multiple genres popularized in the mid-2010s, such as dancehall (a genre of Jamaican pop music) and its subgenres reggaeton and moombahton.²²⁾ Unlike the party atmosphere of the original genres, this song joined symbolic lyrics with Baroque-style mysticism to create something entirely different from the genre's customs. Without any intro, Jimin's voice starts the intense beginning. Each movement maximizes their sensuality on stage. In every way, this is one of the most archetypal songs of BTS' career.

3 Begin

(Tony Esterly, David Quinones, RM)

Produced by Tony Esterly

“Love you my brother, Thanks to you,
I have feelings now, I've become myself”

Unique sounds and unorthodox arrangement of the intro capture your ears. Exotic melodies and unpredictable tropical sounds meet the sensuality of R&B to generate a peculiar, unprecedented atmosphere. Jung Kook's signature vocals that densely sing each line about

“brotherhood” exudes the kind of wholesomeness unusual for R&B music.

4 Lie

(DOCSKIM, SUMIN, “hitman” bang, Jimin, Pdogg)

Produced by DOCSKIM

“I’m still the same me,
I am still right here,
but now the big lies
are about to engulf me”

On sorrowful strings, the exotic melody of the acoustic guitar joins, then Jimin’s alluring voice leads the track over trap beats. Distinctive chorus and vocals accumulate the sense of poignancy until the sudden transition in the refrain as if black-and-white turns into technicolor.

5 Stigma

(Philtre, V, Slow Rabbit, “hitman” bang)

Produced by Philtre

“You suffered for my sins instead,
how frail you were”

This neo soul²³⁾ track showcases all of V's strengths, especially his wide range of low to high-pitch falsetto. In addition to the provocative sensuousness of neo soul, the groovy and jazzy mood created by the string session features prominently with rather composed and crisp vocals. The falsetto ad-lib captivates the ear as it closes the song.

6 First Love

(Miss Kay, SUGA)

Produced by Miss Kay, SUGA

“Our relationship is now over
but please don't be sorry”

The greatest strength of SUGA as a producer is his candor and how he unravels that character. You don't need to overanalyze his message, but take it at face value. That candidness could be part of being “hip-hop,” but as an artist, it also attests to how genuine his attitude is. The narrative development centered around an object, a piano in this case, resembles those of movies.

7 Reflection

(RM, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by RM, Slow Rabbit

“Everyone knows their place
but I wander aimlessly”

RM’s signature lyricism shines through. The minimalistic arrangement that suppresses emotions and a spacious rendering of synthesizer akin to electronic instrumentals, coupled with RM’s perceptive lyrics maximize the emptiness, desolation, and lyricism. It’s a relatively unknown masterpiece.

8 MAMA

(Primary, Pdogg, j-hope)

Produced by Primary, Pdogg

“Only Mom’s hands can heal me
You’re forever my placebo”

Primary, a Korean hip-hop producer, joined as a trackmaker, implementing jazz hip-hop elements proactively. Despite its upbeat and pop-like look on the outside, it’s not all about the fun as the lyrics tell a son’s heartfelt confession for his mother. It shows an early potential of j-hope’s individuality as a solo artist.

9 Awake

(Slow Rabbit, Jin, j-hope, JUNE, Pdogg, RM, “hitman” bang)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“I answered, no, I’m so afraid
but I keep walking, grabbing tightly six stems of flowers”

While they are not the majority of BTS’ music, sentimental ballads and rock songs are occasionally included. This is one of them. Elegant and classical string arrangement is superb, but the highlight of the song is Jin’s vocals. From the delicate parts to deeply emotional sections, his rich expression reveals a step forward as a vocalist.

10 Lost

(Pdogg, Supreme Boi, Peter Ibsen, Richard Rawson, Lee Paul Williams, RM, JUNE)

Produced by Pdogg

“Getting lost is the way to find your path”

This masterpiece showcases the vocal members’ techniques and appeals in the most effective way out of all of BTS’ discography. It also demonstrates the most

intricate musical quality in the entire album. The chorus climaxes concisely and effectively, and the development of the song is logical, with all the elements placed properly. While all the vocals are excellent, Jung Kook's vocal tone is superb at portraying the message of despair and hope in the lyrics.

11 BTS Cypher Pt. 4

(C. 'Tricky' Stewart, J. Pierre Medor, RM, j-hope, SUGA)

Produced by C.'Tricky' Stewart, J. Pierre Medor

"I know I know I know myself
Ya playa haters you should love yourself
Brr"

If "Cypher Pt. 1" and "Pt. 2" gave the old-school hip-hop and gangsta sound a bold, classic feel, "Cypher Pt. 3" was mainly about the technical level of the rap that poured fiercely into the more modern trap beats. In "Pt. 4", the harmony of mastery and fluency creates the most carefree and confident feast of rap in the series. The phrase "love yourself" appears once again.

12 Am I Wrong

(Sam Klemptner, James Reynolds, Josh Wilkinson, RM, Supreme Boi, Gaeko, Pdogg, ADORA)

Produced by Sam Klemptner, James Reynolds, Josh Wilkinson

“If you read at the news and don’t feel anything about the comments, and that hatred, you’re not normal, an abnormal”

In terms of the message, it follows “Silver Spoon,” asking whether you can live without becoming insane in this crazy world. In the album mainly composed of sophisticated sound, the atmosphere and melody evoke the early days of BTS. It is a song that shows off their unrefined charms.

13 21st Century Girl

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg

“Tell me I am strong, I am enough”

Encouragement and comfort instead of complaint and criticism is a key appeal in the message of BTS. When most artists refer to contemporary issues, it is easy to stop at criticizing the situation, but they cleverly escaped the trap. The energy of vocalists that decorate the bridge

parts exclude incredible energy. They have grown mature enough to take on difficult passages.

14 2! 3 !

(Slow Rabbit, Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, j-hope, SUGA)

Produced by Slow Rabbit, Pdogg

“In the shadow behind the stage,
I didn’t wanna show you all the pain in the darkness”

This song is dedicated to fans is one of the best songs of the album, which is both unusual and meaningful. In an asymmetrical merge of massive beats and delicate lyrical poetry, it repeats the heartwarming message, “Bad memories will be forgotten and only good days are ahead of us.”

15 Interlude: Wings

(Pdogg, ADORA, RM, j-hope, SUGA)

Produced by Pdogg

“I believe in me, my back hurts for the wings to grow”

Musically, it is the most deviant song on the album. The influence came from both Chicago-style house²⁴) popular

in the 1980s, and Eurodance from the 1990s. The music alone can be an interesting part of the BTS discography, but the message is particularly important for discussing the overarching theme and the keyword of the album, “wings.” It is also unique that the song was named “Interlude” instead of “Outro” in consideration of the sequel.

YOU NEVER WALK ALONE

(2017, Repackage)



Track

Review



1 Spring Day

(Pdogg, RM, ADORA, “hitman” bang, Arlissa Ruppert, Peter Ibsen, SUGA)

Produced by Pdogg

“Cherry blossoms are blooming,
this winter is over
I miss you, I miss you”

It unexpectedly, though in many ways, has become one of the most important songs for BTS since debut. It is not an exaggeration to say that even the people who do not know BTS or aren’t their fans have heard this song. Given the tragic and gloomy image of the music video that portrays collective melancholy associated with spring, it is hardly written for mass appeal. At a glance, it seems to consist of beats and arrangements that are nothing unusual, but all the elements come together absolutely beautifully and exquisitely. The different parts that comprise the song have clear melodies, and the nostalgia and sorrow embodied in “past the end of the cold winter” are particularly moving. This song opened a

new chapter in aesthetics of BTS by employing the lyricism of pop and rock, instead of the sensibility of hip-hop that they had represented previously.

2 Not Today

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, Supreme Boi, JUNE)

Produced by Pdogg

“Don’t kneel, I won’t cry, hands up
Not not today”

The contrast of moombahton sound adopted throughout the song and the dry, simple sound of the verses is quite notable. Though the genre is similar to “Blood Sweat & Tears,” the magnificent scale of arrangements is in line with the stadium house sound that was popular in Germany and across Europe in the late 1980s and early 1990s. The lyrics deliver the message of encouragement to the despaired youth. With intense and uplifting sounds, they assert that it’s not the time to admit defeat no matter what kind of irrationality, injustice, or prejudice they are facing.

3 Outro: Wings

(Pdogg, ADORA, RM, j-hope, SUGA)

Produced by Pdogg

“I don’t cry or hang my head on my way
It’ll be the sky where I’m flying”

This track inserts a new rap verse with future²⁵)-based beats on “Interlude: Wings.” j-hope’s rap highlights the ultimate theme of *Wings* once again to bring it to close.

4 A Supplementary Story: You Never Walk Alone

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg

“Even if this road is long and tough,
will you join me?
If I fall and sometimes get hurt,
will you be by my side?”

This track serves as a bonus title, but it is nevertheless insignificant. Encompassing the central theme of the repackaged album *YOU NEVER WALK ALONE*, it consoles and encourages the fans, the companions of their future path, and the youth who belong in the same generation and live this age together. Their genuine

message goes beyond the conceptual façade and
inspires powerfully.

Interview 03

Fan Translators: Leaders of Content Distribution in the Age of New Media

Myungji Chae, Operator of BTS Fan Translation Account



The proactivity of their fandom, ARMY, was decisive in the international success of BTS. Their global fandom is a fascinating research topic in itself. The activities of fan translators, mostly active on Twitter, are quite special. They are all voluntary accounts who translate the lyrics of BTS music and relevant media content into

English or other languages. Through their effort, contents related to BTS are translated almost real-time and shared with the fans worldwide. I discussed the characteristics and essence of fan translation accounts with freelance translator Myungji Chae (@BTSARMY_Salon), who operates a translation account with over 100,000 followers.

Youngdae Kim How did you first begin to translate BTS-related content? I assume becoming a translation account wasn't something you intended when you became their fan.

Myungji Chae I started Twitter to check out the real-time content of BTS. When BTS went to the Billboard Music Awards(BBMAs) for the first time, a lot of overseas media wrote articles. One of the outlets especially wrote something very extensive. I searched but couldn't find a Korean translation. I wanted to share it with the Korean ARMYs, so after some thought, I translated and posted the article. That was my first activity. After that, as I translated more English articles related to the BBMAs into Korean, I ended up becoming a translation account.

Youngdae Kim When you started becoming a full-on translation account, it must have been quite busy to juggle it with your professional career. What is your translation process during the day like? You must be checking out their content almost real-time. It must be no small task considering the sheer amount.

Myungji Chae When BTS wasn't often discussed in Korean media, I would regularly search for good articles and translate them whenever I had free time. Recently, there are too many articles, so I mostly translate those shared by the agency, each member's tweet or comments, and acceptance speeches during awards seasons. On Twitter, many accounts are specialized in news delivery. I would check those to translate articles whenever I have time.

Youngdae Kim For the international fans who cannot read Korean content, translations become the primary source. If you don't properly explain the cultural context, it may be difficult to fully understand everything from the translation.

Myungji Chae The lyrics of BTS music are filled with symbolism and pun. Even for Korean fans, it takes time to recognize their meaning and intention. They contain numerous elements that can only be understood as part of Korean culture or

social norms. One of the most difficult but fun lyrics to translate in this sense was “Ddaeng.” I had to flesh out various contexts of *ddaeng*, as in the onomatopoeia for bells ringing and the buzzer for wrong answers, as well as *sampalgwangddaeng* from the flower card game. I didn’t know much about the flower card game, so I had to study before explaining.

Youngdae Kim It’s hilarious how you had to learn about card games to support BTS. Does it ever feel like a burden, considering how much you work as a fan? It’s not like there is any financial reward for it.

Myungji Chae For the ARMYs who are waiting for the news, I have to translate as fast as possible. When songs or content are released, I have to start working on them right away before appreciating them myself. But I’m more motivated by the desire to have other ARMYs understand and enjoy them simultaneously, so I try to clarify all the context within the content.

Youngdae Kim How you choose your words may change the implications of BTS’ lyrics and comments, which may cause misunderstanding among foreign fans. I assume you may have certain pressures or burdens about this. Especially

since you can't edit on Twitter but it spreads so quickly, are you ever worried about mistranslations or mistakes?

Myungji Chae Yes. Because I can't edit the content on Twitter, I am extra careful to translate what the members said. Direct translation isn't necessarily the best translation, but it's usually safer that way. When I paraphrase or explain the cultural context, I write additional comments to minimize misunderstanding. Recently, for lyrics and long articles, I tend to post them on my blog first and edit them before I post the link on Twitter. When I find typos or minor mistakes later despite all the effort, it's really disheartening.

Youngdae Kim From what I've observed, there's always something being talked about among idol fandoms, whether it's positive or negative. No matter how good your intentions are, you never know what you will be criticized for. Because international fandoms have such a wide variety of nationalities, races, and ethnicities, sometimes it's difficult to communicate. Things can become very controversial over what is politically correct. Some fans only favor certain individuals in the group, and they would have conflicts with one another. As a translation account, I guess you can't help being cautious about these issues. What is your own way of minimizing trouble?

Myungji Chae I always try to be extra careful when I tweet. It's not only because I am a translation account, but a reflection of my tendencies. Since our fandom is so big, it's difficult to care about everything that happens inside. Even if something bothers me, I try not to express it through my account. Also, unless I don't fully understand the cultural context of the issue in both ways, I wouldn't hastily comment on it. Twitter has a limited word count and doesn't let you edit, which may cause the readers to misunderstand. I try my best to prevent any elements that could lead to a conflict. Unless there's a special occasion, I don't translate assumptions or lyrics that may be controversial. Recently, I've come to realize how much influence translation accounts have on the readers. Whenever there's an issue within the fandom, I take extra effort to think through before I express my opinion.

Youngdae Kim In K-pop fandoms, and especially in ARMY, translation accounts have as many followers as celebrities and are quite influential. Sometimes, even if it's not related to your translations, your tweets can be taken as seriously as a celebrity among the fans. Are you aware of this?

Myungji Chae I don't think I'm a celebrity. Though as I mentioned, as the fandom size increases, it's undeniable that the translation accounts have certain influence. Whether I translate or not, I am still one of the millions of BTS' fans. It is a bit daunting. Within the fandom, there are many other activities including fanart, video and photo editing. It's just that I've picked translation. Still, the fandom has grown much bigger than expected and because my account delivers words, I am especially more careful before I tweet.

Youngdae Kim What was the most memorable content you translated?

Myungji Chae The comeback date for *LOVE YOURSELF 轉 'Tear'* fell on May 18. The album had nothing to do with the May 18 Democratization Movement. However, because we usually trend hashtags on Twitter to celebrate on the day of comebacks, I was worried that international ARMYs who don't know Korean might confuse the hashtag for the democratic movement. On my blog, I posted an English article on the issue and introduced a related film to elaborate so that the fans wouldn't confuse the hashtags. Incredibly, many ARMYs worldwide sympathized with the issue and took special care as they used Korean hashtags that day.

Youngdae Kim When International ARMYs first become BTS fans, they start from consuming their music and performances, but go on to learn about Korea quite seriously.

Myungji Chae ARMYs are amazing; after they read my posts, they would start a whole new discourse about democratic movements in their home country or explain the atmosphere of their societies. Since the content requires us to explore so much, our discussions often lead to profound conversations. The blog post I mentioned was especially meaningful and worthwhile because it was based on the resources that a lot of Korean ARMYs sent me.

Youngdae Kim As a translation account, taking such a role would surely make it feel more worthwhile.

Myungji Chae In general, I feel like I'm my job is important when I explain culturally specific context that the original Korean writing has, and observe how the ARMYs who encounter it for the first time are amazed or excited, then get to understand the overall circumstance. It's also very rewarding to see secondary translations in other languages based on mine.

Youngdae Kim Although this is voluntary labor of love, some might take it for granted while others are grateful.

Myungji Chae Personally, I received so much comfort from the ARMYs. At work, it was not at all easy to hear expressions of acknowledgment or gratitude from others. When I posted my translations, the phrase “thank you” piled up to fuel my daily energy. The delight I receive from direct communication with the ARMYs is something different from the message of hope and consolation from BTS.

Myungji Chae

Myungji Chae works as a project manager at a translation and interpretation agency and a freelance translator. She didn't think she will follow an idol after age twenty, but she fell in love at first sight when she saw the intro to the “Blood, Sweat & Tear” music video online. Her top bias is BTS and the second bias are the ARMYs. She co-translated *BTS, Art Revolution: BTS meets Deleuze* from Korean to English.

Interview 04

Consolation for the Distressed Youth

Hyeong-cheol Shin, Literary Critic



A significant part of their musical appeal is in BTS' unique worldview and messages. Their lyrics are very raw and lyrical, yet exhibit philosophical and literary aspects that are considered much beyond

the limits of idol music. I discussed with literary critic Hyeong-cheol Shin the appeal of BTS' music, focusing on their messages.

Youngdae Kim As I requested to have this conversation, I couldn't help thinking of the early 1990s when we were part of the "Generation X." In the music industry, Seo Taiji and Boys appeared out of nowhere and turned everything upside-down. As teenagers, perhaps we were fortunate to have witnessed and experienced it. When I listened to BTS album *LOVE YOURSELF 結 'Answer'* last year, my review pointed out that just like Seo Taiji in the 1990s, now BTS is asking what K-pop's zeitgeist is. Some people may be displeased to hear my comparison of BTS to Seo Taiji, who was called the "Cultural President," but it's a kind of déjà vu for me.

Hyeong-cheol Shin As you know, the cultural hero of the "Generation X" was Seo Taiji and Boys. Their music, performance, and music videos were all simply a marvel. On the day of "Comeback Shows" right before the release of their new albums, we would lose our minds in front of the TV and even feel a glorified sense of participating in a historical event. Since then, I have watched the process of popular music industry reorganizing around the three major

agencies as they developed K-pop as a brand, and loyally followed all the distinguished songs that were released intermittently, but I have never felt the same level of marvel from 1992-1995. Something good is entirely different from something revolutionary. Of course, if a revolution happens frequently, it wouldn't be a revolution. To be honest, I skimmed through the early works of BTS. The music video of "N.O" was nothing new to the generation who experienced "Classroom Ideology," and "Boy In Luv," exploding with teenage narcissism and macho masculinity didn't kindle much interest in a man in his forties. After that, I lost interest, and I missed all of the activities during *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* and *WINGS* series. Then it was the end of last year when the media was hyped about the BBMAs, that I finally listened to "Mic Drop." After twenty years or so, I experienced that marvel again. I started to trace their releases in reverse order. I was just stunned when I found "Not Today" and "Fire" belatedly.

Youngdae Kim From the songs you mentioned, I understand what you mean by "marvel" that you experienced. Speaking of Seo Taiji and Boys, rap and dance music existed before they arrived on the scene. But the moment Seo Taiji and the Boys sang, "I Know" on the stage, it just felt totally different. It's hard to explain the details, but I know my body was

telling me that what I'm listening to, and everything that is going on that stage are entirely something else. Is that what you felt when you listened to BTS' music?

Hyeong-cheol Shin When you think something is good, it means you can tell the difference. It's that feeling of something more advanced, going one step further in sophistication than what is existing. However, some cases make you wonder how it was even possible to achieve such a level. Listening to the previous three songs, I felt that unfathomable difference. All three of their music, performances, and music videos were cohesively fused in such a distinct way. Such trinity of marvel—perhaps because I wasn't as diligent—was the first I experienced since Seo Taiji.

Youngdae Kim To a literary critic, I assume “the BTS shock” was not just about their sounds or visuals. I've examined K-pop for a long time, but aside from the sounds, even the messages alone are extremely distinguished, in their so-called Youth series during *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* era and subsequent album *WINGS*. Under a consistent theme, the narratives of youthful dreams, happiness, temptation, frustration, and hopes are blended densely with music. All of this also forms a sense of unity with each member's

personality. This level of impeccability was never found in idol music.

Hyeong-cheol Shin I am aware that the discography of BTS forms its own universe, which cannot be grasped in its entirety with a few songs. As a literary scholar, this is definitely the enticing factor for me. I have never seen a team that consistently writes a collective narrative by characterizing each member. It is incredible that the phenomenon is not just a processed product of stars' lives, distant from the fans and unilaterally supplied for their consumption. Rather, they are evoking the universal emotions of the contemporary youth who identify with them, positioning their narrative as the screen for the youth to project their circumstances. In this narrative, the creator and the recipient appear to be one and the same.

Youngdae Kim That's an interesting way to put it. In the history of music, I think the pieces that defined each era or have universal qualities of the times, are celebrated for intimate interactions between the music (or creator) and the audience, rather than being flawless musically. If the music provides 80%, the rest is filled by the relationship it forges with the listeners. What do you see in the BTS universe as the key to enabling such empathy?

Hyeong-cheol Shin To be honest, I don't fully understand the BTS universe yet. However, I have wondered if the underlying theme of the narrative is the existential vulnerability of youth in their teens and twenties. Living as a young person, you are inevitably distressed by mental and physical violence from family and peer groups. All the while, the mainstream popular music, which posits this generation as their major consumers, was long occupied by the rhetoric of temptation—"my baby!"—that reproduces banal gender roles without paying attention to their wounds. I believe *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* and *WINGS* that filled that void. When BTS, who endured and progressed through the unfavorable conditions since debut, wrote their own narrative of growth, the fans in their peers found themselves in those songs.

Youngdae Kim Curiously, LOVE YOURSELF series was inspired by the central theme of "self-affirmation" or "self-love." To people who have not closely listened to their music, it may have seemed surprising. But the context is still about the youth as they experience enlightenment, in line with their previous works. I think it is all the more stirring because it's directly related to their identity as an artist.

Hyeong-cheol Shin In the song “IDOL,” the grand finale of LOVE YOURSELF series, I found the following lyrics remarkable. “Inside me I find tens and hundreds of myself, Today, I encounter a new me; But they’re all me anyway, I’m just gonna run and not worry” My immediate reaction was “dividualism” advocated by Japanese novelist Hirano Keiichirō in his book *What am I? From Individual to Dividual* (2012). He asserts that a human being is not an undividable “individual,” but a “dividual” who can identify in plural forms. In other words, I can exist in multiple forms within myself, as having a relationship with a particular person gives birth to the existence of a new, specific “myself.”

Youngdae Kim That’s why I felt that “IDOL” was the ultimate (as of now) conclusion to what BTS has always consciously questioned since debut. Being a hip-hop idol, their existence was a contradiction. It was also the most vulnerable and liable characteristic. Instead of resorting to self-loathing, they resolve this conundrum with a message of self-affirmation. Rather than choosing either an “artist” or an “idol,” they declare that they can be both. Whoever they are, being themselves is what liberates them.

Hyeong-cheol Shin To add, Hirano Keiichirō was motivated to write *What am I?* because of the rising rate of suicide among

Japanese youth. When someone decides to give up their own lives, it is probably because they can't affirm who they are. But if there are more than one "me," perhaps they might like one or two of them. Hirano asserts the life worth living as that "dividual," with those who allow you to exist as such a being. In short, the idea that you can exist as multiple beings increases the possibility of affirming who you are. After all, isn't this in line with BTS' message to "love yourself"? That's what I felt, anyway.

Youngdae Kim Perhaps this is why a lot of people say they were "healed" or received "comfort" from BTS' music, instead of being simply impressed. What's even more interesting is that such feelings of healing and comfort are felt not only by Koreans but also by BTS fans all over the world. I am amazed that such a positive message is spreading through upbeat and sweet "pop" music, instead of a more intricate or complex one.

Hyeong-cheol Shin I believe the theme of vulnerability among the youth, shared by BTS and their fans, received such a global sympathy in part because of specific contemporary contexts. As you know, the regime of neoliberalism dominates the world we live today, demanding extreme competition among individuals that results in the defeat of

absolute majority. This system cunningly disguises structural disadvantage as individual failures. Listening to the exploitative voice that condemns you as a failure of self-management and urges you to exploit yourself further to rise as a victor, we become “auto-exploiting laborer in his or her own enterprise.” (Byung-Chul Han, *The Burnout Society*, 2012)

Youngdae Kim BTS opposes the label on today’s youth as “N-po generation,” a neologism for giving up a number of things, including courtship, marriage, and childbirth. Perhaps it’s because such a label may misdirect the blame to the victims of social structure and focus on the act of “giving up,” due to their lack of effort and willingness. After exploring the meaning of dreams and happiness, it came as a shock when they said, “It’s okay to stop, it’s fine to be without a dream.” Still, this is markedly different from defeatism or nihilism. Isn’t this the same context in which young people, as well as older generations, receive comfort from?

Hyeong-cheol Shin Everyone knows that the biggest victim of this system created by the neoliberal regime is today’s younger generation. As teenagers observe the despair of these young people, they are preparing for their own destitution. Under these conditions, except for very few (prospective) winners, most (prospective) losers have a high risk of being

consumed by self-loathing. There are many catastrophic consequences of this. To overcome self-hatred, some will resort to hating and victimizing others, and some will become depressed and engage in self-harm. Vulnerability has always been an inherent potential of the growing process, but the self-loathing injected by neo-liberalism is driving today's youth to self-injury. In this context, BTS' recent messages—"Be yourself, Speak yourself, Love yourself"—are not only reasonable but appropriate. In my interpretation, these imply that "We have finally succeeded in loving ourselves, so we hope you will be able to do the same." I once read a comparative analysis that I quite agreed, which points out how self-absorption is exhibited as "swagger" in the world of hip-hop and that this idea is constantly reproduced within the neoliberal system. In contrast, BTS' message is distinguished because they declare that everybody has the right to be loved as who they are.

Youngdae Kim In a way, their proclamation "to love yourself" may be perceived as a naïve statement. What do you think about this view?

Hyeong-cheol Shin In fact, I have come across criticisms of this "BTS Mantra (Love yourself)," dismissing the declaration as a

variant of the egocentric “self-consolation” fad. Before making such a hasty judgment, I would advise them to consider its enormous influence on today’s young generation all over the world. If the mantra could pull today’s youth out of their self-hatred and transform their souls to become “bulletproof,” what more could you ask for?

Hyeong-cheol Shin

Hyeong-cheol Shin is a literary critic. Born in 1976, he entered Seoul National University in 1995 and studied Korean literature for a decade. He began writing literary critique in spring 2005 and is serving as a member of the editorial board at the periodical *Literary Community* since summer 2007. In winter 2008, he published his first critical anthology, *The Collapse of Ethica*. He has since written *The Community of Feelings*, *An Experiment of Accurate Love*, and *The Sorrow of Studying Sorrow*. Shin is also a professor of Creative Writing at Chosun University.

Part 3

BTS

the World's Most Popular Pop Group

After presenting a new model with *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life*, BTS elevates the quality and prestige of their music to a new level through the LOVE YOURSELF series. They encounter a new moment as the alternative of global pop, beyond the top K-pop artist.

BTS: THE REVIEW



Review 11

LOVE YOURSELF 承 'Her'

(2017, EP)



Album

Review



BTS, following their depiction of growth and conflict of the tempted youth, and the empathic words of encouragement and consolation through *WINGS* and *YOU NEVER WALK ALONE*, now embark on a new series *LOVE YOURSELF* to pioneer the entirely uncharted issue, in their pursuit of more essential questions and answers. That is, the enlightenment of self-love. The theme already presents a whole new undertone from those of other K-pop albums. The narrative intimately blends in with the music to effectively convince the listeners.

“Wonder” in the “起承轉結” sequence was essentially only released as a short film that includes “Euphoria.” *Her*, the album that represents “承” in the series, is one of the major turning points in BTS’ career. Within the bigger narrative, this is the album that describes the joy and happiness of falling in love. Also, perhaps due to the external conditions that put BTS in the center of global attention—winning the Top Social

Artist category at the BBMA's in the same year—it has escaped the dark and heavy mood of the previous record. With experimental and eclectic elements that coexist in the tracks, the album expanded their appeals to a wider audience than before. Jimin's "Serendipity," one of the most memorable solo tracks in BTS' career, and the series of tracks that pour out their identity as a hip-hop group—"MIC Drop," "Go Go," and "Outro: Her"—are all superb tracks. However, the core tone of the album is determined by "DNA" and "Best of Me," the tracks that further enhanced their character as a pop group. Considering the format as an EP, it didn't include as much spectrum or depth, but this shortfall is more than made up in the subsequent *LOVE YOURSELF 轉 'Tear'* album.

Track

Review

1 Intro: Serendipity

(Slow Rabbit, Ray Michael, Djan Jr, Ashton Foster, RM, “hitman” bang)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“You’re my penicillium that saved me”

This is the most delicate and vulnerable out of all of BTS’ intro. Jimin’s vocals, significantly matured since the last album, are silky smooth, elegantly delivering the lyrics. Creative expressions such as “Calico cat” and “penicillium” in the lyrics are aesthetically pleasing, and Jimin’s lovely traits characterized by “just, just” shine through in this excellent piece. The contrast from the heavy tone of the previous album contributes significantly to the direction of the new album.

2 DNA

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, KASS, Supreme Boi, SUGA, RM)

Produced by Pdogg

“Don’t worry, love

None of this is coincidence”

Their identity transition as a pop group, perceived since “Blood, Sweat & Tears,” is reinforced with this song. Musically, it’s quite concise and sensible. Their new, experimental sound isn’t just something to try, but concludes in a direction that is acceptable to a wider audience. As is the case with all of their music, the effort to disintegrate the common practices in pop music is particularly interesting. The unique placement of the whistle in the intro and the future bass-based drop section reconfirm that BTS is leading the overall trend of the K-pop scene. This is the track that signaled the beginning of BTS phenomenon in 2017.

3 Best of Me

(Andrew Taggart, Pdogg, Ray Michael Djan Jr, Ashton Foster, Sam Klemptner, RM, “hitman” bang, SUGA, j-hope, ADORA)
Produced by Andrew Taggart, Pdogg

“We don’t have laws between us,
but there are rules in romance”

This track follows the new direction set by *Her*. The melodic tendency is not entirely different from previous BTS music, but the increased influence of electro pop, the newest trend in the U.S., is noteworthy. This track is smoothly produced in the most pop-friendly style in BTS’

discography by Andrew Taggart, a member of the EDM group the Chainsmokers. SUGA's transformation as a vocalist is also a delightful element.

4 Dimple

(Matthew Tishler, Allison Kaplan, RM)

Produced by Matthew Tishler, Crash Cove

“Was it an angel's mistake, or a deep kiss?”

From composition to producing, this is the only song that wasn't handled by the producers at BitHit. Without taking detours, the track concisely hits the main points as it rushes to the chorus, indicative of the trendiest electro pop in America. The flexible groove performed by the vocals, especially Jimin, is superb at expressing the song's cute and lovely appeals. It also contributes to the overall romantic sentiment of the album.

5 Pied Piper

(Pdogg, JINBO, KASS, RM, SUGA, j-hope, “hitman” bang)

Produced by Pdogg

“Just like the forbidden fruit, my flute awakens it all”

This track stands out, not only in terms of the peculiar theme but musically out of all the BTS discography. The slow disco groove glows without a dramatic climax. It's a rather mild song. Still, the falsetto exquisitely musters up tension and culminates at the chorus.

6 Skit: Billboard Music Awards Speech

Produced by Pdogg

What more can I say?
It's a historic moment for K-pop.

7 MIC Drop

Pdogg, Supreme Boi, "hitman" bang, j-hope, RM

Produced by Pdogg

"Sorry, Billboard. Sorry, worldwide
Sorry your son's such a big shot, Mom."

The first half of the album represents the transformation of BTS as a pop group; the three songs following "Skit," particularly "Mic Drop," exposes BTS' roots as a hip-hop idol. Signature beats reveal the song's identity no matter which part you play; SUGA's full-on confident swagger impeccably merges with it. The original version with raw

sentiments is nice, but the remix version by EDM superstar Steve Aoki's sensible producing packs more momentum for mass-appeal. Certified as Platinum Record (over million sales) by RIAA (The Recording Industry Association of America), this is the most successful BTS single in the U.S. to date.

8 Go Go

(Pdogg, "hitman" bang, Supreme Boi)

Produced by Pdogg

"YOLO YOLO YO

Squandering fun, squandering fun, squandering fun"

Though overshadowed by the success of "MIC Drop," this song is the first attempt at Latin-based trap hip-hop, significant for the critical message in the lyrics. In contrast to how trap is increasingly criticized in the U.S. for forgetting its roots and being excessively self-indulgent, this song chastises such hedonistic indulgence, represented by "YOLO" and "squandering fun" as well as the social system that resulted in such a structure in a balanced manner.

9 Outro: Her

(SUGA, Slow Rabbit, RM, j-hope)

Produced by SUGA, Slow Rabbit

“The answer to all of my wonders
I call you her her
Cuz you’re my tear tear”

Out of their entire discography, BTS’ interest and knowledge in old-school hip-hop is most meticulously materialized in this song. The first part that plays elaborate jazz chords resembles the heyday of 1990s jazz hip-hop, and RM’s traditional initial rapping reminds me of Public Enemy’s Chuck D in the 1980s or 2pac from the 1990s. Even without speedy beats, the rappers show off their relaxed, skillful mastery.

10 Skit: Hesitation and Fear^(Hidden Track)

Produced by “hitman” bang, Pdogg

The idol industry is all about selling their glamour. Certainly, BTS has also emphasized their extravagance and accomplishments in a confident way. But under the title “hesitation” and “fear,” BTS demonstrates their reflection upon their success. Has anyone else in the K-pop idol scene shown such candor lately? In the face of uncontrollably enormous success, they always look back

at the path they have taken, instead of indulging in their achievement.

11 Sea (Hidden Track)

(RM, Slow Rabbit, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by RM

“I wanted to have the sea so I swallowed you up
But I’m even thirstier than before
Is what I know really the ocean? Or a blue desert?”

To BTS, and in particular their leader RM, the sea is a perpetual theme. They always repeat and change it up; the sea is the past of where deserts exist now. The message of finding hope in hardship is very common, but it is amazing to find such a profound message of enlightenment in an establishment K-pop idol’s lyrics. They urge one to plunge into despair in order to suffer, fully aware that where there’s hope, there is also despair. In the greater framework that fuses electro sound with hip-hop, the music isn’t about the melody, but only about the ambience and sentiments.

Column 04

ARMY'S New K-Pop Discourse

The Implication of "BTS-pop" and the Division of K-pop Fandom

BTS' un-K-pop methodology, represented by "hip-hop idol" and "narrative authenticity," is a significant transformation from the existing idol industry that intends non-national or transnational products for the global market. Coinciding with the properties of YouTube and other social media, they started an unprecedented international sensation. But the BTS phenomenon is fundamentally different from the popularity of other idols, in their intensity and essence. The most important point is that they are based on a consolidated fandom, not just something "viral." Also, they have attracted a new group of audience en masse who were not existing follower of Hallyu, which separates them from the general popularity

of K-pop. While BTS is undoubtedly a group from the K-pop scene and has grown with a K-pop based fandom, since they made their initial appearance in the U.S. in 2014, the situation is abruptly changing. BTS is absorbing a vast range of music fans beyond K-pop, and they are uniting on and offline to identify as “BTS fans” as opposed to “K-pop fans.” It is specifically notable that such a trend is forming around the U.S. market.

Through the history of BTS’ career trajectory and the growth of their fandom, we will have better access to that context. As aforementioned, BTS unexpectedly garnered positive responses from their Meet and Greet and stage performance as a rookie performer at KCON 2014. BTS’ popularity, catalyzed by their KCON performance, expanded widely through a U.S. tour in the following year. *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life* was the first album from a small agency to rank in the Billboard chart. From this point, they have taken huge leaps at the U.S. media’s special care and attention. The mainstream American music industry’s continued courtship toward BTS, including their win one year later at the BBMAs in 2017 and an invited performance at the American Music Awards(AMAs), signifies the earlier recognition of BTS phenomenon in the U.S., more so than their home country. In this sense, it implies that the ownership of the BTS phenomenon is in America. Furthermore, when BTS became an awardee at the BBMAs again in 2018, it gradually prompted critics to analyze that their local

popularity has already overcome the scope that can be fully explained as part of K-pop.

To understand the essence of their US-based success and its specificities, we should examine the controversy surrounding the success of *LOVE YOURSELF 承 'Her'* on American K-pop communities in 2017. It was about whether or not BTS is K-pop. These so-called “fan wars” about who’s better than another are extremely common in both Korean and American K-pop communities. It doesn’t require specific reason or opportunity, but it happens as the fans of most popular contemporary groups have conversations online. Sometimes they remain rather polite discussions, but the “war front” may expand quite seriously. The controversy about BTS was peculiar in several dimensions. First, it didn’t start from a rivalry between specific fandoms, but between general K-pop fans and BTS fans on K-pop forums and Twitter. Around the time of BTS’ success in the U.S., the presence of BTS was expanding within the overall K-pop fandom. Presumably, the bickering started between existing K-pop fans and BTS fans about the distinct nature of BTS music on social media.

The argument didn’t necessarily start from the disparity of the fans’ musical preference. As apparent it was, the conflict was due to BTS’ exceptional success. Although they didn’t necessarily target in preparation, BTS became the most successful group in the U.S. As a group that wasn’t produced in the “Big 3” agencies, their accomplishment was solely thanks to their fans’ support. The

massive hit of *WINGS*, which ranked no. 26 on the Billboard Album chart, followed by winning an award at the BBMAs in 2017, and the invited performance at the AMAs all highlighted the exceptional nature of BTS' accomplishments. The word "BTS-pop," originally a sort of derogatory term to make fun of BTS and fans among K-pop fans, now took on an entirely positive meaning. The declaration of "BTS-pop" by the ARMYs was diffused throughout the social media and news sites such as Reddit and K-pop portal Allkpop, evolving into serious musical debates, which later transformed into an endeavor to understand BTS in a separate category from K-pop.

From a non-fan's point of view, it may seem no different from the usual fan wars. It's not like fans of all artists enjoy such debates or new categorizations. But, this phenomenon is clearly suggesting a new transformation of American K-pop fandoms, which have been lumped generally as "Hallyu fans" or "K-pop fans." Let's examine the situation in the mid-2000s when K-pop started targeting the global market. The K-pop fandom in the U.S. explosively expanded amid the flood of K-pop blogs, online magazines, and social media services. Their major characteristic is being a part of "multi-fandom," also called "K-poppers" online. Considered "Hallyu fan" in a wider sense, they have basic tendencies of following Korean popular culture in general, such as TV dramas, films, and music. In music, they tend to support their "bias" and the releases from their bias's agency. Such multi-fandom tendency of American K-pop fans is the identity generally observed from media outlets such as *Koreaboo*,

Soompi, and Allkpop, which have introduced Korean popular culture in the U.S., as well as general forum-style communities that discuss K-pop, such as Reddit.

The multi-fandom propensity of American K-pop fans has supported and continues to support the overall K-pop industry, before and after the emergence of BTS. The obvious barometer is the growth of KCON USA, a Hallyu festival held in the United States. Organized by online Hallyu media Koreaboo and CJ in 2012 when PSY's "Gangnam Style" became a gigantic hit, KCON has conspicuously grown each year. By 2018, it mobilized a combined audience of almost 100,000 in Los Angeles and New York. Including the cost of lodging and flight, the event requires an expenditure of over \$2,000 per person. The growth of this festival alone proves the sustaining presence of K-pop fans. Even so, there was a new wind of change—the BTS phenomenon and the appearance of the ARMY. I already discussed the exceptionality of BTS' success, but their fandom ARMY is expanding into something entirely different from the existing nature of K-pop fans. For instance, the crowd response to BTS at KCON in 2016 was so wild that almost made me confuse it for BTS' solo concert. Considering it was before BTS' popularity exploded, it was beyond belief. It made me assume that a separate fandom for BTS was forming in the U.S., independent from the existing K-pop fandom. As BTS continued to take over prestigious stages uncharted by K-pop, including BBMAs and AMAs, their lead was becoming more pronounced than ever. Such a trend was not

only observed physically in person, or on the music charts, but also big data such as Google Trends. Beginning in 2016, the amount of search volume for “BTS” started to surpass “K-pop” in the United States. After that, the difference was as high as sixfold. The gap is similar in comparison to other contemporary K-pop artists. Certainly, K-pop and other groups’ search volumes are also on the rise. These two currents are not necessarily mutually exclusive, though partially independent. In sum, the exclusive performance and expansion of fandom for BTS in the U.S. are similar in the trajectory of K-pop’s growth, but they also are walking on an independent path that breaches the multi-fandom culture. In turn, this requires a new perspective in K-pop studies, which has employed Hallyu as the major framework to explain phenomena.

Let’s return to our key question. What’s so special about BTS that evokes such firm support toward them from the American ARMYs? According to the fans, the most distinctive factor is the ingenuity of their music. Although BTS music is based on American pop, it’s different from American pop music or the existing kind of K-pop that they are used to. Some of them argue that BTS incorporates more Korean elements in comparison to others, such as the sentiment of *han* (a culturally distinct form of grief) and sorrow, the discourse of youth and social critique that aren’t often found in another K-pop idol music. The other factor is their authenticity in lyrics and attitude. When American BTS fans describe their music, they use words like “genuine,” “authentic,” and “raw” to point out the

major discriminating factor from existing K-pop, especially idol music. Certainly, people's evaluation of music is subjective, and the authenticity of artists cannot be ascertained solely from their works.

Nevertheless, if you've been paying attention to BTS' music and lyrics, you will have an idea about the context of these opinions. The differentiating factor that they argue is discovered in the process and the general attitude, not just from BTS' music. As I've discussed several times, the individual members' personalities and perspectives are most effectively reflected on BTS among many K-pop idol groups. When they participate in producing music, they present attitudes such as writing lyrics straight from what they feel in real life, as opposed to fabricating stories. This fulfills the major condition of authenticity, most essentially required for the musical artistry of hip-hop or punk.

In contrast to the existing K-pop music, created by songwriting camps between composers who encompass a wide range of genres, the music of BTS was organically created by an up-close and personal collaboration of BigHit producers and BTS members. The fact that BTS was not part of the mainstream K-pop produced from the "Big 3" was also an indirect factor that differentiated and provided credence to their music. Within the power structure of mainstream K-pop, they see that the special position that BTS held as a relatively less focused boy band was candidly reflected on their music. To the American listeners who are obsessive about the message and the authenticity of music, BTS provided these unexpected dimensions

for a K-pop idol, which became the source of pride for the fans. This kind of pride strongly motivates fans to be voluntary and passionate in their fandom activities.

Fascinating turn of events continued to surface after another. Some of the fans who insist on the difference between BTS-pop and K-pop are beginning to consciously not identify as K-pop fans. Moreover, in certain cases, they are rather indifferent to K-pop or the idol music scene in general, if not negative toward the industry. Following BTS' emergence in the U.S. in 2014, I often encountered fans who like BTS but have never been interested in other K-pop idols. This was quite a shocking shift for me, who always considered Hallyu fans and K-pop fans based on the multi-fandom as more or less the same group. The reason I paid attention to this trend, as I mentioned, is because I suspected it might signify the overall transformation of K-pop fandom in America. So far, the globalization and localization of K-pop had always posited "Hallyu" as the big framework and K-pop as a subgenre. Such a perspective persisted throughout journalism and academia, and it is still effective in many cases. This approach was unavoidable because not only was Korean popular culture consumed by a very small portion of the population in the U.S., the demographics of consumers consisted of specific enthusiasts of Korean culture as opposed to the general public. However, the independent success of BTS and their presence beyond K-pop, as well as the fans' far and wide activism demands a new perspective in analyzing K-pop.

For now, let's limit the scope of global K-pop fandom to those in the U.S. Before K-pop landed officially in the U.S., up to the early 2000s, the K-pop fans consisted of Korean or Asian Americans who formed small minority networks of devoted fans. Some of them were Caucasian/European Americans, former fans of J-pop who were generally interested in Asian pop culture and languages. Since the advent of YouTube, K-pop fans have crossed over to include a wide range of ethnic demographics, including African American and Hispanic fans. A considerable number of them were not existing K-pop fans or unfamiliar to Korean culture. Instead of consciously consuming BTS as part of K-pop, BTS is just another pop stars to them, comparable to the likes of Ariana Grande, Justin Bieber, or One Direction. Once you remove the label of K-pop and as Korean musicians, you will notice the two separate trends.

By catalyzing the division of K-pop fandom, the emergence and success of BTS are inducing a different kind of revolution. The K-pop idol fandom, considered homogeneous as an overall current, is showing first signs of significant division through the expansion of the market through the BTS phenomenon, diversification of racial demographics, and the success in the mainstream. In turn, this reality may demand a revision of definition in the concept of "K-pop fandom." The success of BTS, who originated in the K-pop scene but didn't follow its formula, as well as the independent direction they are taking from K-pop's multi-fandom will require a new perspective in analyzing the future strategies of the K-pop industry and their

consumption. Ultimately, the BTS phenomenon is an indication that K-pop's future will result in "individualization" no longer bound by the category of K-pop, and the transformation of its nature to decontextualization from Korea.

Interview 05

The Perspective of Korean Popular Music Critics on the BTS Phenomenon

Chang-nam Kim, Chair of Korean Music Awards(KMA) Selection Committee



As BTS enjoys wide popularity abroad, attracting the focus of attention from mainstream American media, the domestic suspicion

about their reputation in overseas markets is gradually disappearing. However, most media coverage resorts to introducing the “international response” to BTS, just as any YouTube reaction video, without discussing the significance of their music in the context of Korean popular music, or what they have accomplished musically. In this sense, nominations and awards for the Korean Music Awards are an important basis for an objective examination of their prominence. This is the only critical popular music award that prioritizes musical achievement, as opposed to other awards that employ popularity as a major criterion. What did music critics, who have the most fastidious musical preferences, have to say objectively about BTS? I had a conversation with Professor Kim Chang-nam, the Chair of KMA’s Selection Committee.

Youngdae Kim BTS is writing a new history of Korean popular music.

The response overseas is even more amazing. The success in the United States, the global capital of pop music, is particularly astonishing. The two keywords that defined global K-pop in the 2010s are PSY and BTS. I also listened to a lot of American pop growing up, but you lived through the era when “pop” was synonymous with American popular music. As a critic and an activist who has been studying the developmental process of modern Korean popular music

since the 1980s, I'm sure it must be compelling to witness K-pop's success in the overseas market, especially the success of BTS in the U.S. market.

Chang-nam Kim Right. It makes me recall the days when I listened to American pop music on the radio and write down the English lyrics in rough Korean pronunciations. Billboard charts in those days were just stories from another world. When I heard that the Japanese female duo Pink Lady was on the Billboard chart in the late 1970s, I thought, "Japan is an advanced country." I never expected that our music could be there one day. But now I hear that American fans are writing down BTS' lyrics in rough English pronunciations. I would also see them singing the Korean lyrics aloud. It's a big deal if you think about it.

Youngdae Kim I'm not sure if we can conclude the success of the BTS as an exceptional phenomenon, or as the success of mainstream K-pop that encompasses the overall improvement in the general quality of Korean pop music.

Chang-nam Kim It's not my cup of tea to become excessively arrogant or nationalistic about it, saying things like "we've conquered the world" or "BTS has elevated Korea's prestige," but it's natural for people to feel proud of it once in

a while. But observing the success of the BTS isn't only delightful. PSY or BTS' success doesn't signify the development or success for the Korean popular music in general. Behind their fame, there still exists the reality of Korea's music scene, which becomes more and more frail in terms of genre and generational diversity. While BTS may be the legendary jackpot from K-pop, we must be wary against the misunderstanding that it's the success of Korean popular music in general.

Youngdae Kim In early 2018, KMA, where you serve as the Chair of Selection Committee, made an exceptional move by giving BTS the "Musician of the Year" award. Unlike other awards that judge based on commercial success and records, KMA's continued nomination and recognition are significant in itself. What do you think as the Chair of the Selection Committee?

Chang-nam Kim "Musician of the Year" is a general category that evaluates the comprehensive influence, including the musical accomplishment, their activities throughout the year, and the influence on the overall industry and society. As such, BTS' win was a matter of course. I'm sure in-depth discussion and evaluation will be continued about BTS' performance for 2019 KMA.²⁶⁾

Youngdae Kim Considering the nature KMA, it's also critical that they are the first to win "Musician of the Year" as an idol group. Isn't it comparable to an American pop idol winning "Album of the Year" or "Record of the Year" at the Grammys? If BTS wins major categories at this year's KMA, it will go down as a historical record in Korean popular music, not just for KMA.

Chang-nam Kim There is a misunderstanding that KMA ignores K-pop and idol music, but that's not the case if you take a look at our past award history. Because our awards are based on genres, more of our awards were given to indie musicians who belong in diverse genres. The quality of idol music is also evolving. More and more idols are becoming artistic as they compose their music. This is my personal opinion, but I think BTS is the most evolved group in today's K-pop trend. In some ways, their amazing external success might be overshadowing the musical accomplishment. Aside from their commercial performance, I insist that we need to evaluate their music more seriously.

Youngdae Kim A lot of media have attempted to analyze their success. I called them the new model of K-pop. As someone who has observed Korean popular music for a

much longer period than I have, I'm curious about your take on BTS' success.

Chang-nam Kim I generally agree with the media analysis of BTS' success, such as good music, great dance moves, high-quality music videos, fashionable styles, and looks, as well as sympathetic lyrics for the young generation and proactive communication with fans. However, other idols all have and pursue these factors. I think BTS' success was an outcome of reinforcing these elements in more earnest ways.

Youngdae Kim Amid the flood of idol music in today's industry, the path that BTS has taken is outstanding in multiple dimensions. By now, it's become rather difficult to comparably assess them with other idol groups.

Chang-nam Kim To add my impression, I think BTS was more successful in strongly establishing their artistic ego than other idol groups. Usually, the pervasive image of idol is having been "manufactured by agencies." This has hindered recognition of their identity as artists. In contrast, BTS was able to stress their identity as independent beings who think for themselves, and as musicians who tell their stories in their own ways. In other words, BTS successfully

demonstrated their musical authenticity considered to be lacking in most idol music.

Youngdae Kim That's what I think makes BTS the un-idollike idol. It's in line with what you said earlier about the evolved form and the reason I view them as the alternative of K-pop.

Chang-nam Kim I want to add again the attitude of how BTS treats their fans. When they make acceptance speeches or express gratitude, they always mention the ARMYs first. This differentiates them from other idols who bring up the president of their agency foremost. The fans can't help but be moved by BTS for being grateful to them before anybody else.

Youngdae Kim Indeed, because the global BTS phenomenon wouldn't have been possible without the bottom-up, grass-roots support of the passionate ARMYs. In that sense, I believe they must be understood independently from existing Hallyu. Could you address the significance of BTS' success in terms of cultural history?

Chang-nam Kim It might be too early to discuss their influence on cultural history just yet. However, they certainly won't be forgotten for peaking in terms of amassing the global K-pop

fandom. I'm especially keen on the amazing dynamic illustrated by their fandom. In particular, I was truly astonished by the White Paper Project that the ARMYs produced regarding the t-shirt controversy of a BTS member.

Youngdae Kim I was also impressed by how far the awareness within the fandom has evolved and thought would be a great case against those who used to deride idol fans. The well-organized research and acute analysis were on an academic level, and the scale of their work was overwhelming even for a critic. It was something only achievable because they are fans.

Chang-nam Kim Right. This is bigger than just on the level of fandoms. It's a dynamic new form of younger generation's participation on social issues, though we'll have to wait and see if this truly leads to a new type of participation that breaches the social order.

Chang-nam Kim

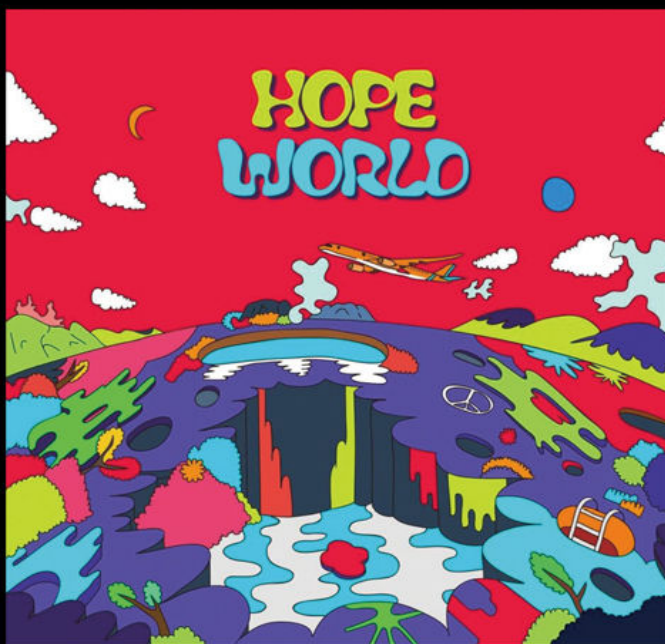
Chang-nam Kim is a professor of Media and Communications/Graduate School of Culture and Communications at Sungkonghoe University. He serves as the chair of Korean Music Awards Selection Committee and the chair of Korean Association

for the Study of Popular Music. Kim has written *Understanding Popular Music*, *Popular Culture*, *Activist Music*, and *Youth Culture*, and Kim Min-ki.

Review 12

HOPE WORLD BY J-HOPE

(2018, Mixtape)



Album

Review



If I had to pick one piece that surprised me the most out of the entire BTS discography, I wouldn't hesitate to pick *HOPE WORLD* by j-hope. The reason for the astonishment is because the agent of this album was j-hope, a member who was relatively less celebrated as a musical talent in the group. j-hope is the main dancer of BTS who is centrally responsible for the performance, but he has the role of a "sub-rapper" after RM and SUGA, and hasn't had a chance to prove his skills. Whenever he had time during their hectic world tour schedule, he progressed his ideas to complete this first mixtape.

Unlike the conventional mixtape of other rappers, which are collections of somewhat rough ideas, this one packs a punch of unique ideas and achieves a quality close to a full-length album, albeit just under twenty minutes. Musically, he utilizes the element of rap, but it showcases a whole variety of arrangements from 1990's house to the newest trap beats. Rather than a hip-hop album, it sounds like an assorted pop album. Any song

you play, the music lucidly reveals the artist and human being that j-hope is. It's noticeable how BigHit carefully produced music that can highlight j-hope's strengths as a solo artist. As a result, while its narrative and texture of sound are still in line with those of BTS, it successfully portrays j-hope's unique personality as positive, optimistic, and playful.

Track

Review

1 Hope World

(DOCSKIM, j-hope)

Produced by DOCSKIM

Opening with sound effects of someone submerging in water, it cheerfully introduces the major theme of the album and j-hope's determination as an artist. Inspired by *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea*, a novel written by a French pioneer of modern science fiction Jules Verne, the lyrics imply multiple symbolism. On the surface, it's an invitation that summons listeners to his world. But this world is undisclosed and hidden, just like an abyss. The creative passion for music that he had to himself during group activities, finally revealed now, is j-hope's world and a hopeful world filled with optimism.

2 P.O.P(Piece of Peace) pt. 1

(j-hope, Pdogg)

Produced by j-hope, Pdogg

This is the smoothest, most flawless well-made track on the album. On an unusual groove, the added steel drum-

like sound created a summery, cool Latin vibe. “Peace” in the title seems to refer to a painless, peaceful state of mind, instead of the antonym of war and conflict. In this sense, “peace” is another word for his name, “hope.” If the first track “Hope World” functions as an intro, this is the main track that embodies the central theme of the album. The chords and rhythm progression are rather slightly lonesome instead of all upbeat, subtly displaying his contemplative dimension as an artist.

3 Daydream

(Pdogg, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

This track has the most different style of arrangement. It combines numerous elements and sound sources from the late 1980s and early 1990s house and club/dance genres, with distinct low-pitch vocals and melody progression in the chorus that come together nicely. As he tries to change up the positive mood in two previous songs, the choice of “daydream” instead of just “dream” reveals that the various complexities mentioned in the lyrics cannot be compromised. But you can’t change reality with this apparatus of fantasy and imagination, as j-hope already knows. Ultimately, the song functions as a

temporary “break” for him to empty out all the thoughts that occupy his mind, as an idol and an artist.

4 Base Line

(j-hope, Supreme Boi)

Produced by j-hope, Supreme Boi

This track is musically unique, both for the chorus that starts right away and the simple flow that repeats itself throughout without much variation. It’s impressive that the groovy, simplistic, and humorous atmosphere is maintained until the end. This simple, easy idea without any decorative elements somehow makes it work.

5 HANGSANG (Feat. Supreme Boi)

(Supreme Boi, j-hope)

Produced by Supreme Boi

More than any other song on the album, this is the most authentic style of hip-hop that truly shows his dimensions as a member of BTS. On icy beats, j-hope flaunts playfully about success. The swagger in his lyrics doesn’t come off as immature or mean because the bottom line is about camaraderie and friendship.

6 Airplane

(j-hope, Supreme Boi)

Produced by j-hope, Supreme Boi

Also hinted in “HANGSANG,” the word airplane signifies success throughout BTS’ music. It’s not an uncommon metaphor in popular music, but BTS and j-hope’s usage sounds more legitimate because of their origins and background. All they had was passion before they dreamed of becoming musicians, left for Seoul, then turned into global stars. In this unbelievable success story, an airplane is an indispensable element that represents success itself. It’s a space that induces excitement about their extraordinary prestige, while also providing a lofty point of view that makes every concern on the ground look trivial.

7 Blue side(Outro)

(Hiss noise, ADORA, j-hope)

Produced by Hiss noise, ADORA

The images represented by blue, endless time and depression, are blended effectively in this song. With sensibilities in line with “Sea” by BTS, it is reserved in depicting a complex mixture of emotions and thoughts

about vague memories, forgotten sorrow, solitude,
dreariness, disappointment, and reluctance.

Review 13

LOVE YOURSELF 轉 'Tear'

(2018, Album)



Album

Review



While *Her* album brought about a worldwide BTS syndrome, it also was an unprecedented level of pressure over the members. In response to the international perspectives that began to treat them as musicians and artists, instead of a generic K-pop idol, they presented the most serious, determined, and solemn album. The title, *Tear*, was also quite apropos. “Fake Love,” which premiered globally at the BBMAs, is the defining song of the album. The level of solemnity, romanticism, and literary sensibilities are expansive for this masterful piece.

The album is filled with high-quality tracks. “The Truth Untold” most purely highlights the vocals out of entire BTS discography, and “134340” is brilliant with the experimental arrangement. “Magic Shop” is one of the most moving songs on the album. It elevates the position of “fan songs,” idol’s sweet serenade dedicated to their fans, to another level. The ample musical experience and expertise of BigHit production team, the assistance of overseas composers who imbued trend and

international sensibilities, and especially the progress of BTS members' skills as artists all successfully merged to culminate in their best artistic effort yet. In terms of message, music, and technicality of sounds, this is the "made in Korea" music that can compete anywhere in the world.

Track

Review

1 Intro: Singularity

(Charlie J. Perry, RM)

Produced by Charlie

“Tell me, if this pain is fake,
what was I supposed to do”

“Singularity” is the most hypnotic in aesthetics among BTS’ music. V’s trademark baritone vocals, extremely rare for an idols, superbly interprets the dark and jazzy mood of neo soul genre. This track is responsible for the trendy yet dense and complex qualities of *Tear*. His live stage that maximizes the dramatic appeal through a splendid performance is a must-watch.

2 Fake Love

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, RM)

Produced by Pdogg

“Love you so bad Love you so bad,
For you, I forge pretty lies
Love it’s so mad Love it’s so mad,
I’m erasing myself to be your doll”

The extraordinary narrative of LOVE YOURSELF series completely reveals its true colors in the title track, “Fake Love,” on *LOVE YOURSELF 轉 ‘Tear.’* When the protagonist realizes the contradiction of loving without being loved, he calls it out as “fake love.” Juxtaposed with what also doubles as a musician’s perpetual quandary—“wish[ing] love was perfect as love itself”—the musical catharsis becomes even more impactful. As expected of BTS music, the narrative is meticulously embodied in the choice of genre and the details of arrangement. The message of tortuous enlightenment on the subject of love, achieving musical congruity with the intrinsic melancholy of emo²⁷⁾ genre, produced a peculiar rendition of dark, tormented ambience rare among BTS’ recent music, if not K-pop in general. Whereas the original version on the album allowed the dynamic performance on stage through the contrasting tension between electric guitars and hip-hop beats, the “Rocking Vibe Mix,” released as a separate single, brings the signature moody, afflictive undertones of emo rock to the fore, which enables you to vividly appreciate the emotional fabric of the song. “Fake Love” graced a page of K-pop history by ranking no.10 on Billboard Hot 100, but its commercial success notwithstanding, the song’s musical accomplishment alone is undeniably one of K-pop’s most glorious breakthroughs of 2018.

3 The Truth Untold (Feat. Steve Aoki)

(Steve Aoki, Roland Spreckley, Jake Torrey, Noah Conrad, Annika Wells, RM, Slow Rabbit)

Produced by Steve Aoki

“Perhaps back then, just a little, bit by bit
If I was brave enough to stand in front of you,
would everything be different now?”

If *Tear* is trendier and most “pop” compared to BTS’ earlier works, the central basis of such an argument is “The Truth Untold.” The elaborate melody is entirely free of clutter, and the organically ascending progression that doesn’t artificially lead to climax is simply professional. Steve Aoki’s producing sensibilities are superb; though his major genre is EDM, Aoki’s capacity as a ballad producer is flawless. It showcases his breadth of the musical spectrum. Aside from the songwriting quality, the pleasant vocal performance of the members is worth listening. It demonstrates highly pure vocal pop.

4 134340

(Pdogg, ADORA, Bobby Chung, RM, Martin Luke Brown, Orla Gartland, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“You erased me, you forgot me
I once belonged in a world under the sun”

In the K-pop idol scene, it's extremely rare to find a producer who's as seasoned at crossing over retro and modern sounds and eclectically blending them as skillfully as Pdogg. “134340” exhibits Pdogg's excellent producing skills once again, in terms of stylistic arrangement and atmosphere. The track likens the status of Pluto (134340), now downgraded to a dwarf planet in the solar system, to the abandoned narrator himself. It also makes an interesting reference to Eris, another dwarf planet that used to be a candidate for planet status. RM's trademark brilliant rap contrasts SUGA's cynical and self-deprecating style, nicely matching the story of the song. He incorporated acid jazz²⁸⁾ and jazz hip-hop sounds, difficult to find in K-pop soundscape.

5 Paradise

(Tyler Acord, Uzoechi Emenike, RM, Song Jae-gyeong, SUGA, j-hope)
Produced by Lophiile

“It's alright if you don't have a dream
Everything you breathe out is already in paradise”

Musically, its future-style R&B is in line with “Dimple” in the previous album *Her*. But the theme and density of this track are more sophisticated. The general public may be unaware, but for a lot of musicians, their messages are intended toward their inner ego. They have been running restlessly without knowing where it ends nor why they keep running. This is a message of healing that BTS sends themselves. “It’s okay to stop” is also an encouragement to those who are experiencing similar conditions. The seven members take turns leading the song in delicate unity without a hint of discontinuity, enhancing the immersive experience of listening.

6 Love Maze

(Pdogg, Jordan “DJ Swivel” Young, Candace Nicole Sosa, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Bobby Chung, ADORA)

Produced by Pdogg

“In the worthless heap of lies, as long as we’re together, even an endless maze is a paradise”

Signified by the word “maze,” the complicated and ambiguous sentiment of romance are convoluted intricately in this track. It’s an urban pop that stresses the contrast of dense bass drums and upbeat rhythms, but the chorus melody expresses the most gentle and

sensitive emotions. The vocals delicately perform the poignant and affectionate sentiment throughout the song.

7 Magic Shop

(Jung Kook, Hiss noise, RM, Jordan “DJ Swivel” Young, Candace Nicole Sosa, ADORA, j-hope, SUGA)

Produced by Jung Kook, Hiss noise, ADORA

“Sipping a warm cup of tea, I look up at the Milky Way
You’ll be alright, oh, this here is the Magic Shop”

To any idol, the relationship with their fans is doubtlessly precious. The gratitude that BTS has for their fans, who were the central driving force that made them the global megastars, is especially exceptional. “Magic Shop” is a song that elevated the tight bond between BTS and their fans to a whole new dimension. It’s not just about the artist making good music and fans supporting them. When life gets hard, almost to the point of an unbearable state, having each other to give and receive consolation is incredibly special. Not only is the subject matter “magic shop” is refreshingly creative, but the warm sentimentality and the impeccable quality of songwriting in every aspect certifies this as the obvious choice for best track of *Tear*. SUGA’s hopeful rapping in warm voice is enough to make

you well up. In terms of the sound, it continues the sentiments from “Love Maze” seamlessly.

8 Airplane Pt. 2

(Pdogg, RM, Ali Tamposi, Liza Owens, Roman Campolo, “hitman” bang, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“We goin’ from NY to Cali, London to Paris
Wherever we go, it turns into a party”

They refer themselves as mariachi, the traditional Mexican bands, whose music originates in rustic tradition far from luxuries. Despite their superstar status that demands worldwide air travel, BTS won’t forget their innocent and passionate past, maintaining their humble identity just like the mariachi. The track joins the recent wave of Latin pop hits, such as Camila Cabello’s “Havana” and Luis Fonsi’s “Despacito.”

9 Anpanman

(Pdogg, Supreme Boi, “hitman” bang, RM, SUGA, Jinbo)

Produced by Pdogg

“I’m sure to fall again, I’ll make a mistake again
I’ll be covered in mud again, but I believe in myself ‘cause
I’m a hero”

It exudes the purest form of positive energy in the whole album. Anpanman (the protagonist of an anime of the same title), made of bread with red bean filling, is probably the weakest hero in the world. Portraying themselves as “ordinary heroes” like Anpanman is effective, once you remember BTS members started with nothing but passion for music are now inspiring millions in the world. It also makes you appreciate yet again Pdogg and Supreme Boi’s skillful usage of old-school hip-hop beats.

10 So What

(Pdogg, “hitman” bang, ADORA, RM, SUGA, j-hope)

Produced by Pdogg

“Sometimes run like a fool
With mistakes and in tears, we just go”

If the message in “Go Go” was paradoxical, “So What” simply says, sometimes it’s better to keep moving ahead without having too many thoughts. The music, compatible to the message, blazes through ruthlessly.

11 Outro: Tear

(Myungsoo Shin, DOCSKIM, SUGA, RM, j-hope)

Produced by DOCSKIM

“We thought we dreamed the same dream
Finally, that dream have become a dream”

One of the pinnacles of BTS hip-hop, this track is a splendid finale that condenses Tear’s core. The grand intro reminiscent of a film score is followed by a feast of fancy rhymes and flows that rappers bust out one after another, which makes it difficult to pick just one impressive line. RM, SUGA, and j-hope move out of their usual comfort zones to express their wide range of vocals and rap. The vivid portrayal of despair and tears at the end of farewell evokes immensely grave and dark ambience that is rarely found in idol music. It’s an underrated masterpiece.

Column 05

Is BTS Really Popular in the United States?

Consecutive Wins at the Billboard Music Awards and the “Popularity” of BTS

On May 20, 2018, I attended the BBMAs in Las Vegas. It was surreal to witness BTS as they received the “Top Social Artist” category and held the trophy amidst their fan’s thundering cheers. This was a consecutive win following 2017, an incredible feat that renewed their own historic record in the history of K-pop. At the venue, the crowd was divided between the fans who chanted their names and people who were unaware of why these fans were screaming at the top of their lungs. The wild fan response resembled a BTS solo concert, with loud cries whenever their faces popped on the screen. The

ushers, security agents, and the host of the night Kelly Clarkson couldn't help but chuckle at the incredible response. The journalists and audience at the venue were busy debating about the nature of this frenzy, flooding me, a Korean journalist, with random questions. I've covered K-pop for quite a while in the U.S., but this was simply beyond belief.

It was doubtlessly a historic moment for Korean popular music, but besides the astonishment that a Korean musician won an award, the verdict is mixed about how much significance we must place upon the "Top Social Artist" award in recognition of their "popularity." First, let's examine its meaning within the American pop music industry. As long as its history, a diverse array of music awards exists in American pop music. Each is valuable and meaningful in its own way. Similar to how the Oscars and the Emmys motivate the industry of film and television, popular music awards mean more than simply celebrating the artists' accomplishments. Besides the special genre awards such as Soul Train Awards or Country Music Awards, four awards are the most prestigious awards in the universal and comprehensive pop category.

One of them is the Grammys, organized and decided by a group of musicians called the Recording Academy. The Grammy Awards is practically the only award that prioritizes the artistic achievement of the music in the selection of its nominees and winners. This is the reason it continues to be respected despite the annual controversies. Besides the Grammys, the other major three decide the winners

based on the indices of popular success. These representative awards are AMAs, The MTV Video Music Awards (VMA), and BBMAs, the last of which BTS has attended as an awardee. BBMAs are well known for strictly selecting their winners based on their popularity, compared to any other awards listed above. This is only natural because the basis of their evaluation is the Billboard charts, published weekly by the host of the award, Billboard. The exact nomination standards for the BBMAs is unknown to the public. Same goes for the Billboard charts, which have rough guidelines, but the precise formula is undisclosed as a sort of trade secret. We only know that the numbers indicate a sum of several statistics, including physical and digital sales, downloads, streaming, and airplay, from authoritative databases like Soundscan. What we know for certain is that the BBMAs are based on the actual numerical and quantifiable data, as opposed to musical evaluations by critics and journalists.

This begs the question: isn't the "Top Social Artist" award that BTS won two years in a row, a redundancy? Why is the BBMAs, which already hands out awards based on quantified measures of popularity, separately giving an award based on the statistics from social media? Indeed, we must take into account the extravagant characteristic of awards in general. All awards, regardless of the host organization, try their best to divide as many categories as possible between genres and specialized areas to celebrate plenty of awardees. For instance, the Grammys honor over 80 categories, most of which aren't recognized or understood by the general

audience. BBMA's also awards nearly 60 categories, and each of them celebrates popular songs and musicians in specific genres in distinct ways.

Out of so many awards, what does the "Top Social Artist" category represent and signify? This is the only category where the fans can vote, reflecting the popularity of the artist on social media. In other words, it prioritizes the numbers obtained through social media, such as reactions and voting with hashtags. Then, why is Billboard operating a category that decides the winner based on social media voting? Most importantly, it's to grab the attention for the award. It's the younger audience in their teens and twenties who utilize social media, and this generation is more passionate and attributes higher significance to their favorite artist's winning an award. In short, the premise of Top Social Artist is to attract their enthusiastic interest to lead the success of the award. And there's more. The emergence of Top Social Artist awards is correlated to the consumption pattern of core American music consumers. This is the convincing evidence that BTS, a Korean artist, is on par with American artists.

According to the BBMA's, the winner of every category is determined based on key fan interactions with music. These include physical and digital album and single sales, radio airplay, tours, streaming, and interactions through online social media. We must pay attention to the fact that BBMA's, the award most sensitive to trend, has directly stressed the role of social media such as Twitter,

Facebook, and YouTube. The trend of mass consumption has already shifted from the era of physical sales and radio airplay to those of consuming music, images, music videos, and related content on social media. Now, social media plays the role of distributing knowledge and information, previously performed by music magazines. Also, YouTube is doing everything, including the traditional broadcast format, such as MTV. In the age when social media has become the ultimate platform of music consumption, gauging popularity through it is not only intuitive but just as authoritative as the traditional method. BBMA was quick to pick up on this trend.

What about this point? If BTS is as popular as a “Top Social Artist,” why weren’t they even nominated in other major categories? To understand the reason, we have to consider various issues including the status of foreign music such as K-pop in the United States, and the characteristics and limitations of how popularity is measured. In the United States, the music industry has a unique structure. It is the only nation with multiple regional “scenes” across its vast territories. Aside from the mainstream, the music industry is divided into a multiplicity of local, indie, and genre markets and audience for each of them. Inherently, the universal popularity of pop music is abstract and difficult to quantify accurately. The traditional index of popularity has been physical sales at major record stores and airplay count from mainstream radio stations. However, these two elements are strictly dominated by capitalist logic. It’s practically

impossible for an album to be a national hit without the full support of major records, distributors, wholesale and retail stores, promoters, the media, and advertisers. In particular, radio stations covertly have led the popularity of selected music by conspiring with record labels and promoters to establish specific playlist system. This playlist reflects the level of popularity, but as most of the radio stations repeat the list within a set period, the popularity of music is distributed in a top-down style from these stations to the masses. They weren't playing the songs with most requests; the songs they played became popular from more attention.

As such, it's nearly a miracle for songs to become popular by chance, considering the sheer amount of new songs that flood the industry in the U.S. To make things worse, BTS' music is in a foreign language. Traditionally, American mainstream radio is adamantly against playing and promoting foreign music, in fear of backlash from their mainstream audience. When PSY's "Gangnam Style" became a phenomenal viral hit, American mainstream radio stations were hesitant to play it because it's a foreign song. It was a major disadvantage that hindered the song from topping the Billboard Hot 100. In such a hostile structural environment, it's nearly impossible for BTS, who rose to stardom solely on their fans' support, to compete equally with American pop stars to become nominated in the major categories. Things are different on social media, however. Fans are free to vote for their favorite artist without any restrictions, reflecting their fierce support directly on the result. It's hard to say

that BTS is the most popular artist in the United States at this point. To the general audience, relatively slow to the changing trends and diversity, they are still little known. However, when we narrow down the age bracket to the younger generation, the major consumers of pop music, the gap is markedly smaller. That is evidenced by their accomplishment the Top Social Artist category, where the influence of the core audience is amplified. BTS is redefining the meaning of “popular” in popular music. It’s not about what’s right or wrong, just that we are on the verge of a momentous transformation.

Anyone can have an opinion of their own regarding the significance of BBMA’s Top Social Artist win. But there is a more intuitive way for everybody to grasp its meaning. The easiest way to find out about an award’s characteristics is retracing its past winners. The conclusion from the Top Social Artist category’s list of past winners is simple and clear. It was dominated by Justin Bieber. Undoubtedly, the popularity of the greatest idol in American pop in the 2010s was displayed plainly by this award. Since the inception of the category in 2011, he never missed the nomination and has won for six years consecutively until 2016. Other nominees of this award are also contemporary icons among the youth: Katy Perry, Rihanna, Taylor Swift, Miley Cyrus, Selena Gomez, Ariana Grande, and Shawn Mendes. Their commonalities are not only that they are great musicians and famous artists. They are the “idols” of the day who command the most explosive, impassioned fans. There’s no doubt about it. Justin Bieber’s popularity based on his powerful fandom

was incomparable to his contemporaries. Even One Direction, the biggest boy band before the emergence of BTS, was unable to surpass Bieber.

In 2017, BTS was the surprise winner who interrupted Bieber from continuing his streak. Besides Bieber, it was amazing that they won against the most celebrated pop stars such as Selena Gomez, Ariana Grande, and Shawn Mendes. It clearly stirred the hosts of the award, if not the American pop industry as a whole. Both in Korea and abroad, the press was busy figuring out who they were, indicative of the temporal delay before an online phenomenon was picked up by the mainstream media. Then, a year later, BTS won this award again at the 2018 BBMAs by a landslide. The industry accepted the results immediately, and the hosts seemed to have expected their win. They proposed BTS to premiere their new song right before the finale, the best offer they could provide to an artist. It was an exceptional treatment to a K-pop group, a target of indifference or ridicule only a few years back. Billboard, which had been first-hand observing every single step of the process, was the first to notice the grand transformation.

Top Social Artist award certainly doesn't signify the greatest honor at the BBMAs nor the complete takeover of the American mainstream market. They still have a long way to go before discussing any sort of "takeover." What the award really does is proving that BTS is the "hottest" artist in America and a pop star with the most loyal and fierce fandom. Aside from British pop, the

American music industry has never yielded the position of the top idol to a foreigner since Elvis Presley. Now, they've awarded the throne to BTS, a Korean group, for two years in a row. This special treatment came from America, a culture that embraces anything exceptional as their own, where capital and competence prevail above all. It's not insignificant at all.

Interview 06

The New Mechanism of K-pop Industry

Jeff Benjamin, Billboard's K-pop columnist



The global success of BTS was predicated on the explosive response from the U.S. market. The response of the American market was widely known through overseas media reports, including

Billboard. I discussed the reason and the essence of BTS' success in the U.S. with *Billboard*'s K-pop columnist Jeff Benjamin.

Youngdae Kim Let's go back to 2014 when BTS first appeared at KCON. I was there, and so were you. We talked a bit about this before, but at the moment BTS made a KCON debut, we both knew that something was happening there.

Jeff Benjamin There were two main aspects that struck me when seeing BTS at KCON in 2014. The first was, of course, the crowd reaction. I noted in my *Billboard* review that "rookie boy band BTS might have been the newest artist on the bill, but the huge crowd reaction could have made you think otherwise" and I then made a mental note that I should keep my eye on this group.

Youngdae Kim As you know, BIGBANG and EXO were at their peak, and Block B was the first to receive the limelight among other boy bands. But BTS, all of a sudden, started attracting amazing reactions. They were rookies who were still not very famous, but I still can't forget the ARMYs who were waiting in long queues for the Meet and Greet and the concert, wearing black hats and masks.

Jeff Benjamin I knew they were from a smaller company from watching their debut and mixing that information with the crowd reaction didn't totally compute in what I thought K-pop to be at the time—which was heavily controlled by certain companies and only a rare few being able to breakthrough for their company. Even those that did break through were not typically hitting the same levels of success as those in the bigger companies. BTS were not only opening my mind to about the types of group that could break through, but also opening my mind about how the industry worked.

Youngdae Kim Upon returning from KCON, I remember writing how it seemed to signal the beginning of a new era. I mean, not that I actually knew they'd become the worldwide stars they've become (laughs). As you said, I thought the topography of the industry may change. To me, it was amazing that the phenomenon started in the United States. Out of all the American journalists, you formed relations with BTS from the start, and you've been most closely covering American reactions to BTS.

Jeff Benjamin The other aspect I remember most vividly is how open BTS were to U.S. media. Instead of me needing to request

an interview, it was actually the KCON staff telling me ahead of time how open BTS was to press and that really struck me. Working in K-pop media has been really interesting in balancing the American and Korean expectations in the press, but here was one of the few acts being very open to me, my questions and working with me as a representation of American media.

Youngdae Kim I have been calling BTS a “new model of K-pop” for their raw messages and sincere musicality, as well as their organic method of production. I believe it’s not simply their spectacular performances, but the element of authenticity is the central reason for their sensation in America. What do you think is the most distinctive feature of BTS and their music?

Jeff Benjamin I’ve always felt the most distinctive part of BTS and their music is the personal aspects they incorporate into their art. Whether it’s the lyrics or the concept or larger themes of what their music stands for, it always feels like it’s a personal representation of who BTS are at the moment and what they stand for as people. Take away the fact that they are good-looking, stylish dudes—they want to speak for their generation in a unique way in which only they can and do that in very accessible ways.

Youngdae Kim In K-pop idol music, it's quite difficult to find groups like BTS that take up social critique as subject matter or directly speak to their contemporary youth and deliver the message of consolation. Perhaps that's what made the international fans who were already familiar with K-pop feel that BTS' music is different.

Jeff Benjamin I see that in a song like 2017's "Go Go." I got to speak to RM as the only international interview ahead of the *LOVE YOURSELF 承 'Her'* album and he explained how he felt today's generation had low expectations for themselves. This song spoke to the "YOLO" culture he experiences in Korea. One example I'll never forget is his explanation of claw crane machines in arcades Where young people are spending loads of money trying to win stuffed animals and dolls in these machines designed to take your money. That isn't necessarily part of the culture I see here, but when I went to Korea the following year, I saw these machines and watched couples play the game as a boyfriend tries again and again to win his girlfriend a plushie. I imagined RM noticing this himself too and what went through his mind to be able to turn that into universally appealing song lyrics; It's such a specifically unique experience that you can't conjure up at, say, an industry-created songwriting camp. The fact

that this experience is put into a song like “Go Go,” which is very fun and catchy, makes it all the more fascinating of a piece of music.

Youngdae Kim That kind of authenticity of the message and organic process of music-making is definitely what differentiates BTS. I think it’s also critical that they started music from the genre of hip-hop, and still create music based on such culture and attitude. But in hindsight, they weren’t the first hip-hop idols in K-pop. As for international expansion, other agencies had more elaborate systems in place. Besides their music, what do you think are some of the most crucial elements for their success?

Jeff Benjamin I do think BTS’ savvy way of connecting to international media was extremely important in their crossover. Some acts have been very selective about media or doing absolutely no media when spending time in America, and I think that was a big mistake since it gives more and more people and outlets a chance to see the fan response. Of course though, one doesn’t get a big response by simply being a hip-hop boy band or doing media. There needs to be a core fanbase that is active and passionate about their artist. I cannot stress how important BTS’ ARMY has been in their crossover in just showing the rest of the

world why this band matters and what makes them so passionate about BTS. It's been the fanbase interacting with influential, impactful ways—both on and offline—that took them to this next level and changed the game.

Youngdae Kim As I wrote in the column for *Vulture*, the culture section for New York Magazine in 2018, boy bands have a long history in western pop music that spans over half a century, tracing back to the Jackson 5 and the Osmonds, followed by New Kids on The Block, NSYNC, down to One Direction. As we know, K-pop is deeply rooted in American pop music and culture, and K-pop idol music is a descendant of American and J-pop idols. However, BTS also originated in that tradition but doesn't look like another boy band to me. Their musical root is hip-hop rather than producer-led bubble gum pop²⁹⁾ of western and Japanese idols. Their message and attitude are also not what we expect from a boy band's music.

Jeff Benjamin At this point, I agree and think BTS having its roots in hip-hop feels like a better fit than pop for sure. Hip-hop comes from a place of necessity and struggle, and it always felt like that's where BTS operated. The group didn't necessarily need to release music that spoke to their mental, cultural and generational struggles, but they did it

because—Well, I'm not entirely sure—because they had to? Overlook the fact that the members that made up BTS were strategically put together by BigHit Entertainment but how they operated after being put together is where I think their pop roots wither away. The group created music and art together out of necessity and it seemed like it was never because they were told they were releasing a certain song or portraying a certain concept. They did what was inside of them and that's what connected. This is also seen in their social media strategy. It was always personal messages and photos from them, not filtered through a manager or agency.

Youngdae Kim Ultimately, I think BTS is unsettling the established formula of American pop and K-pop boy bands.

Jeff Benjamin In the greater scope of pop history, I think BTS is going to be somewhat of an epiphany to many. Throughout the history of boy bands, as mentioned the Jackson 5 or the Osmonds, there was a pretty standard structure of five members, usually black or white, and not particularly known for taking creative license with their music. Here's BTS as a seven-member, all-Korean outfit who write and compose their music. I think many wouldn't think this structure could work given what literal decades of pop history has shown

us, but BTS has already earned accomplished on par or greater than some classic boy bands.

Youngdae Kim Aside from the Jackson 5 and New Edition, who were exceptions, most boy bands only consisted of handsome white men. Needless to say, that's the barrier of the mainstream America. But despite their limitation as Asians, BTS is now being called the greatest boy band in the world by the U.S. media.

Jeff Benjamin That's right. This is hugely significant in just the barriers and BTS is breaking down and stereotypes they are changing not only for boy bands, But also for Asian people and, specifically, South Koreans. They are also showing how important equal representation is by having the far greater hurdles to overcome than other boy bands, but defying every odd still.

Youngdae Kim You've met and talked with them several times since their early career. (And you were on their DVD footage!) How were they in person? Could you share some of the memorable moments, especially about their personalities?

Jeff Benjamin I've been lucky to be able to observe BTS throughout their careers in person a few times! I remember in 2015, I

set up a studio interview and performance session with Billboard where I really got to see BTS' work ethic. It was a very hot July day and, unfortunately, the studio in which we filmed could not have air conditioning running while filming due to the noisy sounds it made. e. Still, BTS did a full interview, one rehearsal run and two filming takes of each song. The songs were "I NEED U" and "Dope," which ARMY knows are two very difficult routines! After every take the guys would be drenched in sweat and run to the air conditioning machines to cool off, but I never saw a complaint or hint of annoyance in their eyes. They seemed very grateful and happy to be given the opportunity and I always appreciated that. It made an impression on me.

Youngdae Kim I met them at the BBMAs for the first time. Even when they've graced the most prestigious stages, considered possible only in dreams for Korean musicians, I was impressed by their modesty regarding their capacity or prestige. I also felt their genuine and sensitive attitude toward others.

Jeff Benjamin Without getting too far into specifics out of respect for the members' personal lives, there have been personal conversations I've had with some of the members where they noticed what was going on in my personal life via SNS

and actually took the time to speak to me, as a person, and give me some reassurance of uplifting words. What's so shocking to me is that they are celebrities with very busy lives and so many people following them, yet here they were offering me some comforting words? It was a bit mind-blowing and very humbling. I think they knew the connection I had with many ARMY via social media and took time to recognize that, which I thought was really, really special.

Youngdae Kim Koreans and BTS' fans are waiting for the day that BTS is nominated at the Grammys. As a music fan myself, I also dream of Korean musicians standing on the Grammy stage one day. I think BTS is the closest candidate so far. It wasn't a music category, but they recently were nominated for "Best Recording Package." This is unquestionably a milestone in K-pop history, but they are yet to be nominated for the major categories of music awards. BTS is already labeled one of the most popular bands in the world, but it's a shame that it's not being reflected on the outcomes of American awards. As they gain more recognition in the United States over time, do you think the circumstances may change?

Jeff Benjamin Personally, it feels like the U.S. is still undermining BTS' actual successes and chalking them up to being an act

that only does well online. It's not only award shows, we see American TV and radio stations only interacting with BTS content on Twitter or other SNS accounts and not talking about BTS on their larger, mainstream platforms. We don't see BTS covered on TV the same way other chart-topping artists are nor do we hear them on the radio the same way. It's a shame and almost feels like these brands are taking advantage of their fans and I always encourage fans to really watch what outlets are actually supporting BTS and not just using them for boosted social numbers. I always encourage fans to really watch what outlets are actually supporting BTS and not just using them for boosted social numbers.

Youngdae Kim Some people undermine BTS' popularity and say that only the social media or the few fans are behind them. But such views don't really understand the U.S. market. Their success is already proven statistically through the Billboard chart and RIAA certifications. I believe it's about time the major awards recognized them a bit more.

Jeff Benjamin I think if award shows like the American Music Awards or the iHeart Awards did away with their bias that BTS is a "social" or "online" phenomenon, and actually looked at the numbers, there would be a great recognition for what BTS

has accomplished. I do believe BTS will score more recognition at the 2019 Billboard Music Awards after such a huge 2018 which I hope sets the stage for more legitimate recognition at these highly coveted award shows.

Youngdae Kim Do you know there has been an interesting debate among K-pop fans about BTS and the nature of K-pop, about whether BTS is K-pop, or a different kind of pop. I think this is a very interesting situation because it's not the typical A vs. B, but it had to do with the essence of K-pop. In a way, the debate expanded unnecessarily because they were all defining K-pop differently to begin with. At the same time, I fully understand why they think BTS is different from other K-pop, especially idol, music.

Jeff Benjamin I understand how the debate came about and always feel a little bad discussing this since I almost feel like it's an attack on the word or "idea" of K-pop, which I don't think is a bad thing. BigHit CEO 'Hitman' Bang spoke about how BTS represented K-pop and he wanted BTS to do what they did best as K-pop artists. Like I said earlier, one can't forget that BTS was strategically put together by BigHit Entertainment—which is very much an aspect of the K-pop world—and the way they release music and style themselves is also very much a part of the scene. But how

BTS operates now is what I think makes them truly stand out. I've spoken to people like their lawyer, publicity and record label heads in the U.S. and they all say that BTS is writing a whole new set of rules with their career. They're not changing who they are as artists or as a Korean group crossing over to the global pop market. Instead, they're having the rest of the world adopt their model and workflow.

Youngdae Kim Lastly, what's your favorite BTS album and what are your favorite songs, and why? (I know I'm torturing you....)

Jeff Benjamin Ha, this is torture!! When it comes to songs, I've always been really partial to "Butterfly" from *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life, Pt. 2* and its soothing tone and imagery has always had a special place in my heart. I also really liked the metaphor from "Fallen Leaves" in that album too and the idea of wanting a love to soar, but it falls to the ground and rots away. But the "Whalien 52" track, also from Pt. 2, may have been when I realized BTS were lyrical geniuses with such a fascinating song about "the loneliest animal in the world" that can only speak in a frequency unable to be heard by others. I think we've all felt like there are times how we are or the way we speak is only understood by us and it feels like we're alone in this world. I also really like the metaphor of "134340" in *LOVE*

YOURSELF 轉 ‘Tear’ that I got the chance to explain live on CNN, which was kind of a rare but cool opportunity. I also love BTS’ ability to take universal themes and have them apply to so many people regardless of speaking Korean.

Youngdae Kim “Butterfly” is also one of my favorites. Then, which one is your favorite album?

Jeff Benjamin In terms of the overall album though? Hmm...I do think *WINGS* was a really major accomplishment in what they achieved not only as a group but in their solo songs as well. But I think *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life Pt. 1* will also have a special place in mind because I see that as the album where it all truly clicked for BTS. I was rooting for them before, but found their previous albums more difficult to get fully into and thought they needed to refine themselves a bit more. Clearly, they put in the work for *Pt. 1* and it’s only gotten stronger from there.

Youngdae Kim Just as much as BTS albums, I was impressed by the musical quality of their solo albums, such as RM’s *mono.*, Suga’s *AGUST D*, and j-hope’s *HOPE WORLD*. They are meaningful for showcasing each member’s potential as an individual musician, not only part of an idol group.

Jeff Benjamin I'd also love to point out RM's *mono*. His "playlist" is probably the best example of creating an atmosphere and total vibe of music in a project. I think K-pop at its core is very much focused on working in multiple genres and sounds, and BTS certainly loves to do that, but *mono*. feels like a story through and through, and it's very tough to ignore the clear artistic vision.

Jeff Benjamin

Jeff Benjamin is a music journalist. He is a K-pop columnist who has been writing for *Billboard* since 2013. He is a contributor to *The New York Times*, *Rolling Stone*, and *NPR*, and a commentator on CNN and other broadcast programs on K-pop. Since his first studio interview with BTS, Benjamin has been most closely following their footsteps.

Review 14

LOVE YOURSELF 結 'Answer'

(2018, Repackage)



Album

Review



LOVE YOURSELF 結 'Answer' is the ultimate completion and conclusion to the discourse of youth and growth that BTS has continuously developed since *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life*. It's also a high level of concept album, unrivaled in purity within idol music and the greater Korean popular music. The album doesn't just rehash existing songs or add a few new tracks as "repackage." All the new songs in *Answer* are placed with new meanings within the narrative of introduction, development, turn, and conclusion. Musically, they have distinct roles between the songs released through *Her* and *Tear*. They begin with the excitement of love, experience the pains of farewell, then become enlightened in self-love through which they discover hope within sorrow. This epic journey is not only logical in structure, but the excellence of the narrative is specifically expressed in terms of the grammar of music arrangement. The series of stories connected in "Epiphany"-*"I'm Fine"*-*"Answer: Love Myself"* that close the first part are especially memorable. Considering that

today's K-pop trend mostly consists of easy and simple messages, their attempt is absurdly experimental. This monumental work offered a new standard of K-pop, set the bar way up, and exquisitely closed a chapter of BTS' career.

Track

Review

1 Euphoria

(Jordan “DJ Swivel” Young, Candace Nicole Sosa, Melanie Joy Fontana,
“hitman” bang, Supreme Boi, Adora, RM)

Produced by Jordan “DJ Swivel” Young

“Just like me, were you wandering around
Looking for a lost dream?”

This song is used as the narrative theme song for a short film called “Love Yourself 起 ‘Wonder’” in the LOVE YOURSELF series. The lyricism and beauty of the song resemble “Spring Day,” while the direction of arrangement and sound is reminiscent of “Magic Shop.” It particularly moves the listeners through the unity of lyrics and sound; the initial electric guitar depicts the palpable excitement in romantic feelings, and the tension created by added instruments reflect the surge of emotions before the encounter. Finally, the confession, “you are the reason for my ecstasy,” explodes with the refreshing melody of synthesizer, producing pleasant aesthetic accordance. The lyrics and composition of the track are well-made, but the most defining element that completes the story of this song is the vocals. Jung Kook’s voice is

specifically notable, for both the techniques and his detailed, expressive capacity that attributes a lot narrative to ordinary notes.

2 Trivia 起: Just Dance

Produced by Hiss noise

“I like the feeling of being with you
I like the dances that I do with you”

j-hope has such positive and harmless energy that can't be explained with a few notes and lines of lyrics. “Just Dance” is an upbeat dance number that epitomizes his signature, bright personality, organically in line with his mixtape *HOPE WORLD* in the direction and tone of the sounds.

3 Trivia 承: Love

(Slow Rabbit, RM, Hiss noise)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“I know because of you
Why a ‘human being (saram)’ sounds like
‘love (sarang)’.”

Following the sentiments of *Her*, “Trivia 承 : Love” organically weaves the universal theme of life, humanity, and love. RM’s stylistic straightforward, yet intellectual lyrics decorate this romantic hip-hop track. He fills the entire track with his voice alone, doing a fine vocal work. In terms of the arrangement, the brass instrumentals strongly resemble vintage soul genre.

4 Trivia 轉: Seesaw

(Slow Rabbit, SUGA)

Produced by Slow Rabbit, SUGA

“Don’t mind who’ll get off first
Don’t drag it out, do as your heart says”

This is one of the hidden gems of *Answer* created by Slow Rabbit and SUGA’s production synergy, which always guarantees fantastic results. The elastic groove of disco-funk takes center stage, but the overall sound also embraces the bitterness from the “ups and downs” of a romantic “seesaw,” involving both excitement and distress. SUGA’s techniques in both warm-hearted and cynical tones generate an interesting contrast.

5 Epiphany

(Slow Rabbit, “hitman” bang, ADORA)

Produced by Slow Rabbit

“I finally realized, so I love me
I’m not perfect but still beautiful”

You might think rock ballad isn’t something you would expect from BTS, but it’s one of the most central tracks on the album considering the overall structure, progression, and the emotional development. Jin explodes every bit of his emotions as if he met the song of his life, and the sentimentality of *gayo*-like melody (in a positive sense) is perfect for the desperate delivery of the message, “the enlightenment at the end of despair.”

6 I’m Fine

(Pdogg, Ray Michael Djan, Ashton Foster, Lauren Dyson, RM, Bobby Chung, Yoon Guitar, Jordan “DJ Swivel” Young, Candace Nicole Sosa, SUGA, j-hope, Samantha Harper)

Produced by Pdogg

“My cold heart has forgotten how to call you
But I’m not lonely, I’m fine, I’m fine”

Based on the reverse melody of “Save Me,” an endearing song for BTS fans, it rushes toward the central narrative of *LOVE YOURSELF*. This track is in charge of the

album's climax. The dynamic rhythm recalls drum & bass,³⁰⁾ popularized in the late 1990s. Though it emphasizes the signature break beats and syncopation, the melody is full of sentimentality and grief. Amid the rushed rhythms, the melancholy parallels that of self-consolation as the narrator utters to himself, "I'm fine."

7 IDOL

(Pdogg, Supreme Boi, "hitman" bang, Ali Tamposi, Roman Campolo, RM)

Produced by Pdogg



'IDOL'(Feat. Nicki Minaj) official MV

"Inside me, I find tens and hundreds of myself
Today, I encounter a new me
But they're all me anyway"

I still can't forget the moment when the teaser of "IDOL" was released. The aggregate Koreanness evoked by kkwaenggwari, hip-and-gable roof, and "eolssu" isn't necessarily an independent trend, but it nonetheless represented the roots and identity of BTS. It was a confirmation that BTS was contemplating this issue seriously. The special version, featured by American rap diva Nicki Minaj, is not significant just for the celebrity

participation. Rather, it denotes that a top American star created a spectacle by warranting the music of BTS, who has now become the greatest boy band in the world. “IDOL” ranked 11th on Billboard Hot 100, and its existence heralded the new era of K-pop.

8 Answer: Love Myself

(Pdogg, Bobby Chung, Jordan “DJ Swivel” Young, Candace Nicole Sosa, RM, SUGA, j-hope, Ray Michael Djan, Ashton Foster, Conor Maynard)
Produced by Pdogg

“I’ll answer with my breath, my path
Myself from yesterday, Myself from today
Myself from tomorrow”

The most important chapter, *LOVE YOURSELF*, finally comes to a close. *Answer* is not only the response but the ultimate conclusion from enlightenment for a new beginning. In western music, the strand of pop music identified by positive and universal messages has disappeared. Now, to have an idol group from Korea present such a profound message is marvelous as it is indicative. What a touching finale.

Column 06

Eolssu: a Presentation of “Korean Authenticity” in K-pop

The Historical Context and Significance of “IDOL” by BTS

Through the past two decades, K-pop has established itself as an unquestionable international phenomenon. But it is still controversial what the word “K-pop” actually denotes. Such uncertainty arises because we have lacked the basis to define it. Is it K-pop if it’s created by a Korean label? Is K-pop something produced by someone with a Korean “nationality”? Does K-pop mean idol music? The questions come from various angles, and nothing can be answered with conviction. But there is the ultimate question K-pop has to face: Is K-pop really “Korean” in nature? As we refer to popular music originated in the U.S. as “pop,” the word “K-pop”

sounds contradictory. What in the world is western popular music of Korea (or Korean in nature)? Is it possible to begin with? BTS' music, specifically "IDOL," released last year presents an interesting answer to these questions.

"IDOL" isn't *gugak* (Korean traditional music). It's hardly a crossover based on *gugak*, either. Still, from the musical intent and details, we can assume it aimed to portray certain Koreanness. As soon as the teaser for this song was revealed, it immediately became the center of attention. It incorporated sounds of *kkwaenggwari* and *gugak* rhythms using the virtual Korean instruments created by Seoul National University. In the album, the track follows their original intention as it highlights African house beats, instead of using Korean instruments. Considering the striking resemblance of *gugak* rhythms in the polyrhythm³¹⁾ of African beats, I don't think the approach was that obscure. The Koreanness of "IDOL" is expressed in a passive, rather unconventional way. "Eolssu," "jihwaja," and "deonggideok kungdeoreoreoreo" are *chuimsae*, ad-lib responses used in *Pansori* (Korean epic chant). It's difficult to call this a fusion of popular music and *gugak*, but the intention is there. We should consider how the musical intention isn't only expressed through sound in K-pop music today. In the music video of "IDOL," their previous usage of Asian or Korean setting as part of exotic ambience went further this time, visualizing Korean tradition itself as the main theme. The hip-and-gable roof, a tiger, ink-and-wash paintings, and

fashion inspired by hanbok all indicate the song's allusion to the elements of Korean tradition.

As global stars, I think BTS' attempt to use Korean cultural elements in their music and visual effects is valuable by itself. Since the 2000s, the outward strategy of K-pop targeting the global stage avoided expressing Koreanness extensively. K-pop has embraced transnational production and strategies based on non-nationalistic aesthetics. Such a vision essentially created visuals in music videos that eliminated Koreanness and any hint of locality, while aiming to produce perfectly western sounds imitating music from Scandinavia, the U.S., the U.K., and Japan, that resulted in cosmopolitan hybrids. When you broaden the perspective to other genres, there were others who pursued Koreanness. A most notable example is "Bulhandangga," produced in a combined effort by underground rappers. It samples a phrase from "Jeokbyeokga (Song of the Red Cliffs)", a Pansori piece, and blends hip-hop with gugak rhythms. The experimental attempt is considered one of the monumental moments in Korean hip-hop history. While such an endeavor is very rare among idol music, "Shangri-La" by Vixx in 2017 introduced *gayageum* and hanbok to their music visual elements, exploring the theme of Asiatic fantasy.

In the entire history of Korean popular music, not limited to twenty-first century K-pop, the investigation of Koreanness is extremely unusual. Shin Jung-hyeon, dubbed "Godfather of Korean rock," is a pioneer in the field. He released interesting pieces that

illustrate how Korean musicians tried to find their identity when they were practically living in a cultural colony following Liberation. Blending Jimi Hendrix-esque psychedelic rock³²⁾ with the pentatonic scale,³³⁾ he wrote “Beautiful Woman,” which resembles blues and gugak. “A Cup of Coffee” and “Beautiful Rivers and Mountains,” also composed by Shin, have become the archetypal Korean-style pop that embraced both the distinct sentimentality specific to Korea and the grammar of western rock music. Compared to the eclectic style of Shin, “Little Giant” Kim Soo-chul experimented more extensively, tackling Korean aesthetics as a rock musician. In Shin’s footsteps, Kim peaked as a rock musician throughout the 1970s and 80s with Korean-style heavy metal and hard rock. Past the 1980s, the prime of pop, he attempted metamorphosis in search of a new identity as a Korean musician. Kim began to study gugak from scratch, meticulously and thoroughly researching how he would fuse it with his roots in rock music. The masterpieces produced through this process include *Hwangcheongil*(1989), *Sopyonje*(film score, 1994), and *Guitar Sanjo*(2002). The earnest crossover of gugak and popular music was partially inherited by Shin Hae-chul’s “Komerican Blues” or *Monochrome*(2001), and now being developed more liberally by a fusion group 2nd Moon and a post-rock group Jambinai in the 2000s.

There’s another unforgettable piece: “Hayeoga” by the 90’s icon, Seo Taiji and Boys. In terms of their musical genre and industrial aspects, Seo Taiji and Boys are the progenitors of modern K-pop. I can’t think of any other musician on par with the level of prestige and

influence they wielded over Korean society as the idols of teenagers. While “Hayeoga,” a follow-up single after the success of “I Know,” was shocking for its disconcerting hybrid arrangement, it’s not necessarily a gugak crossover. To young Seo Taiji, who mastered his musicality based on rock and absorbed a variety of genres including hip-hop and techno, gugak probably seemed an interesting element to integrate for the originality of the sound. “Hayeoga” is a masterpiece that blends his imaginative artistry with the sound of gugak. The insertion of *taepyeongso*, played by gugak musician Kim Deok-su in the middle of the song, portrays the grief of breakup in the distinct Korean sentiments of han. This created probably the most memorable eight measures in the history of Korean popular music. It was reflected in the performance on stage. Seo Taiji and Boys’ members Lee Juno and Yang Hyun-suk added Korean folk-dance style dance moves to the choreography based on hip-hop, remarkably rendering the Koreanness of the song. Gugak and Korean sensibilities in “Hayeoga,” apart from the musical components, alluded most impressively to gugak melodies and rhythms. It was all the more sensational because Seo Taiji and Boys was the hottest rap group idolized by teenagers.

“IDOL” is similar to “Hayeoga” in a number of ways. If “Hayeoga” is the ultimate crossover between thrash metal,³⁴⁾ reggae-style rapping and fashion, rhythms and sentiments of *pungmul* (Korean percussion tradition), “IDOL” intermixes Gqom, a house genre originated in South Africa, with hip-hop, idol-style choreography, and rhythms

inspired by gugak. The common element of hip-hop and hybridization of genres are some of the obvious resemblances. Their performances are even more similar. In fact, “Hayeoga” was more expressly Korean on live stages than the music video. At “93 Last Festival” in 1993, Seo Taiji and Boys staged a spectacular show accompanied by a band of *pungmul* percussion players and Jang Sa-ik’s taepyeongso performance. In terms of representing Koreanness, the most exquisite performance of “IDOL” was at 2018 Melon Music Awards in December 2018. More than making up for the absence in the album version, BTS blended gugak rhythms and dancing with the chorus of “IDOL” for nearly three minutes. Once the performance started, j-hope began his intense modern dancing next to samgomu drum dancing, considered one of the most beautiful repertoires among Korean traditional music performances. It then continued to a fan dance by Jimin, perfect for his sensible, detailed dancing style, followed by Jung Kook’s dynamic mask dance as the grand finale of solo performances. But it wasn’t over. The mask worn by Jung Kook turned into a huge mask that filled the stage, which commenced a round of exciting Bukcheong lion dancing and pungmul drumming before returning to BTS’ main performance. This again illustrates BTS’ position as the legitimate heir to Seo Taiji and Boys.

Then what’s the biggest difference between the two? It is the nature of the audience watching the performance. The pungmul and taepyeongso performances of “Hayeoga” are clearly directed at their

domestic fans in Korea because the piece was written in the era before K-pop's globalization. "IDOL" and BTS' Melon Music Awards performance also target the Korean audience. They almost seem like a fan service by a boy band that now has reached the top of the world. But in the age of YouTube and other activities on social media, where the world shares content simultaneously, BTS was well aware that their music and performances are now content enjoyed by the global audience. The crossover with gugak and performances and costumes filled with Korean aesthetics both inspire cultural pride from Koreans and intend to flaunt their identity as a Korean group to their global fans.

It's not only the excellent music or performances that make "IDOL" special. The lyrics also provide food for thought. Interestingly enough, the song is about their identity as an "idol." An idol speaking about being an idol is surprising, but the content is even more novel. Starting with "you can call me artist, you can call me idol," they soon declare that no matter what others say, "I am who I am." Their self-affirmation flushes out the last bit of concern with a round of jolly fun, developing into a harmonious, festive arena joined by everybody. Much like the participatory character of pungmul folk music, the style of flash mob dancing generates a serious mood despite the upbeat music, as it corresponds to the message of self-love and affirmation. From a broader perspective, the lyrics of "IDOL" also correspond to their consistent message, "love yourself." In this sense, the track is not just about their identity, but a message of consolation and

reconciliation to all the youth who live this day and age. The identity of Korean popular music is not only preserved in the tradition of Korean ethnicity but in their intimate relationship with the society and the general public, about how positive their influence can be. This is how “IDOL” and *LOVE YOURSELF* 結 ‘Answer’ embody the identity and zeitgeist of Korean popular music, radiantly distinguished amid the western, “non-national” music created by the K-pop industry.

The Koreanness in BTS’ “IDOL” was revealed before anyone expected. Following their consecutive winning of the BBMAS’ Top Social Artist award in 2017-18, they have become one of the hottest musicians in the world. Moreover, they topped the Billboard 200 for the first time as an Asian pop artist with *LOVE YOURSELF* 轉 ‘Tear’. American mainstream media began to release a tsunami of reviews and interviews, and their world tour tickets were sold out in minutes. “IDOL” was released at the apex of such popularity and attention. It’s not just a search for identity to localize western music in Korea; it’s a “provocation,” fully aware of the global audience. For aesthetic, or more importantly, strategic reasons, the K-pop industry has purposely avoided Koreanness. Their releasing something so Korean is certainly an expression of their confidence and responsibility as a leading K-pop group.

“IDOL” is not a crossover between pop and gugak, nor does it intend such an outcome. All they did was to place conspicuous elements of Koreanness within and outside of their music. As pioneer Kim Soo-chul commented on the song, blending gugak

doesn't necessarily mean presenting it at the forefront. The context of Koreanness in "IDOL," the latest single by a globally influential group BTS, cannot be solely determined by the percentage of gugak in the song. The Korean aesthetics embodied in "eolssu," in allusion to African rhythms and western pop, thus cannot be taken lightly. After all, it is the music of an internationally ambitious pop idol group, BTS.



2018 Melon Music Awards

Review 15

mono. BY RM

(2018, Mixtape)



Album

Review



The second mixtape of RM, rejecting conventional titles, is called “playlist.” Following the tracks one by one, the intention becomes clear. The two central themes throughout *mono.* is the sense of loneliness and the sentiment as a stranger. Here, being a stranger isn’t limited to being a “foreigner.” It is the realization that you can belong anywhere but cannot wholly belong to one place, therefore becoming an eternally unfamiliar being. This view is suggested in the contrast of two early tracks, “tokyo” and “seoul.” If Tokyo is an exotic space that turned him into an “other” as a foreigner, the personal and intimate place called Seoul, where he must belong, still makes him feel lonely. This is often expressed as an exploration of duality. RM constantly swings between the sun and the moon, love and hatred, eternity and emptiness, contrasting them with one another to describe his solitude. In “forever rain,” he prays that it rains eternally because only rain can be his friend. In turn, this track compactly embodies all the stories on the album. Still, the rain is only the medium. What he really

seeks to find is himself, and “I” am both the fundamental origin and the answer to my solitude.

Short for “monologue,” this album is an extensively personal confession. Every single message is directed inward, every theme explores the duality and contradictions that divide why “I” am, and the origin of it all, solitude. Aside from the thematic dimension, *mono.* is in the format of a playlist that RM composed by himself, for himself. It’s not a hip-hop or rap album in the traditional sense. He examines multiple genres, but instead of investigating genres, he’s investigating sentimentalities. It’s such a huge contrast from his first mixtape, filled with the raw verbal vindication of himself. Vulnerability, lyricism, and RM’s signature intellect are all thoroughly balanced in this album, that may as well be his new beginning as an artist. The music that was always directed at others is now pointed inward.

Track

Review

1 tokyo

Produced by Supreme Boi, RM

The album kicks off in a foreign city of Tokyo. It can seem both far or close from Korea, depending on how you look at it. Tokyo is a very modern and exotic place. The pentatonic scale-based piano sound is perfect for depicting its complex multiplicity. The empty sound creates the spatiality of estranged loneliness experienced in a foreign country. Alarm sound effects seem to denote some unknown pressure. It's an appropriate opening to a "monologue."

2 seoul(produced by Honne)

Produced by Honne, RM

To Koreans, Seoul isn't just a city. It's their spiritual hometown. It's a metropolis where millions live without forming any relations with one another. It gives you a sense of belonging, but also one of deprivation. It's a place of loneliness and anxiety you cannot hate or leave, a city that becomes your home before you're even

attached. The simple and classic quality of songwriting makes “seoul” the best track on the album. Following opening without pomp, his rapping calmly recites the melody, followed by an overlapping flow of mundane thoughts without technical articulation or exaggeration. “If love and hate are the same words, love you Seoul; If love and hate are the same words, love you Seoul.” Signified by these lines, the song takes on the bigger theme of duality and the contradictory feelings that swing between the two entities. It emphasizes the spatial ambience, while dry and warm synth pop sound mingles nicely with RM’s essay-like rapping. On a side note, it’s interesting that “tokyo” was in charge of a Korean producer while a foreign producer worked on “seoul.”

3 moonchild

Produced by RM, Hiss Noise

The children who are born under the subtle moonlight, not the bright rays of the sun. “moonchild” refers to the people who embrace sorrow and gloom. If the moon here is perceived as the opposite of the sun, this can be another examination of duality. The moon only reflects sunlight and cannot illuminate on its own. As such, moonchildren are not individuals who exist in independence. Perhaps they are the alter ego that

appears when the sun sets and darkness falls. The most captivating and sensuous hip-hop song on the track, it couples nicely with bleak cityscapes. The melody, however, is warmly emotional. It reveals RM's sentiments as a melody maker.

4 badbye(with eAeon)

Produced by RM, El Capitan

Its solemn, melancholy tone almost sounds like an original soundtrack for a film. At the same time, it paints a very picturesque image associated with throwing yourself into an abyss, or swimming during a nightmare. The title "badbye" and lyrics "break me apart into pieces" generate an extremely pessimistic mood for the song.

5 uhgood

Produced by Sam Klempner, RM

The title wittily plays with the word meaning "disjointed." The theme of duality reappears with ideal and reality. The narrator, who finds out he will always be disjointed from his ideal self regardless of how much he changes, discovers his true self as he faces reality. Although the lyrics portend a depressing journey, the music is more on

a hopeful tone. It has the most BTS-like sentiment on the album.

6 everythingoes^(with Nell)

Produced by RM, JW of Nell

“everythingoes” has the most modern rock elements in *mono*. RM’s liberal composition style ranges across genres, and he knows how to create sensible melodies. There are many ways of overcoming anguish and anxiety, but knowing how to let go of desires always arrives at last. The constant sense of solitude, contradiction, and anguish throughout the album is concluded by the simple mantra, “everything goes,” but it sounds more positive than pessimistic.

7 forever rain

Produced by RM, Hiss Noise, Adora

He ultimately expresses the album’s central sentiment of loneliness by provoking the innermost depth. The languid, helpless mood of the track joins RM’s slow rap to form the lethargic sense of the verses, but the reversal of the electric guitar that follows turns it upbeat. He says the rain is his only friend, but the real friend is himself,

encountered by the medium of rain. When he realizes that loneliness is not just depressing but becomes a companion to artists, RM wishes the rain will never stop. The hazy guitar sound that continues to the latter half also makes you wish the music won't end. Throughout BTS discography, this is one of the best works produced by RM.

Column 07

Massive Sing-along in Korean in the Heart of New York

The Essence of BTS Phenomenon in LOVE YOURSELF U.S. Tour

Nearly 50,000 audiences gathered at Citi Field, the home field of the New York Mets. Watching the multiethnic crowd as they sang along the grand finale of “Love Myself,” I couldn’t help but recall two concerts from my childhood in Korea. In 1992, New Kids on the Block held their first concert in Korea, where they enjoyed nothing short of sensational popularity. Then in 1996, Michael Jackson finally set his foot on Korea for a show at the Olympic Main Stadium. Back then, America’s idols were also Korea’s idols. Now, what was unfolding in front of my eyes was a Korean idol becoming America’s idol. For all of my life, I was fascinated by American popular music. I

came over to the U.S. to examine their music and culture more closely. To someone like me, the loud cheers of over 50,000 Americans who gathered for BTS was not just an indication of one group's popularity, but a harbinger of a great paradigm change. Suddenly, I got goosebumps.

LOVE YOURSELF Tour is different from the character of any other K-pop idol's concerts on the stateside. Previously, K-pop concerts either targeted limited audience or promotional events advocate their presence to the unfamiliar American public. That's what BTS' first tour WINGS was about. But by LOVE YOURSELF, they were situated in an entirely different context. This time, it was a huge celebration, a festivity to show off BTS' popularity and prestige as a superstar in America. The size of the tour alone confirms this analysis. All forty-plus shows of the tour, started in Seoul Olympic Main Stadium in August 2018 and held in twelve nations, were sold out. Out of the total shows, fifteen were held in the U.S. and Canada. The fact that they sold all four shows at the STAPLES Center, the heart of LA, speaks for the prominence of this tour. The grand finale of their large-scale arena tours, unrivaled in K-pop, was a mega stadium show that only top stars could stand in America. Unlike the conventional promotional schedule of general K-pop groups, BTS rarely had interviews or attended events, focusing entirely on the tour schedule. It resembled the career style of American superstars more closely than that of a K-pop idol promoting in the U.S. At their shows, especially in metropolitan areas LA and New York, quite a

large number of journalists from the local media attended and wrote reviews and analysis. They weren't K-pop specialized media or music bloggers but included the mainstream heavyweights such the *New York Times*, *Rolling Stone*, and *New York Magazine*. Far from the suspicion harbored by some people, the local interest on BTS was beyond negligible.

Four days before the Citi Field concert, I visited United Center, the home field of the Chicago Bulls and the Chicago Blackhawks. This venue is an arena, the most basic unit of BTS' shows. It provides more concentration and unity with the audience compared to a stadium. I was already expecting the response from their local news and Twitter, but witnessing it firsthand was surreal. On the day of the show, it wasn't difficult to spot ARMYs dressed in black with prints of BTS members' names, all over Chicago O'Hare International Airport and in downtown Chicago. Since the morning, police officers were dispatched near the venue to control traffic and pedestrians. It wasn't necessary to ask the location of the arena—you just needed to follow the droves of fans. Fans had been camping outside United Center for three days before the concert started, surrounding the venue almost like a campsite. BTS' banner was flying behind the statue of Michael Jordan, the legendary player for the Chicago Bulls. Watching countless fans take photos with this background was truly wild. Then, the show started. As expected, the atmosphere was sizzling at the arena venue of over 20,000 seats.

Three days later, October 6th finally came. As soon as I finished and sent my review of the Chicago concert to a Korean daily newspaper, I hopped on the night flight to New York. Arriving in the morning, New York gave off a different vibe from Chicago. On the city streets, I found some BTS fans heading to the venue in the early hours. It was easy to recognize groups of BTS fans waiting for the train and subway to go to Citi Field at Pennsylvania Station, one of the busiest stations in New York. Already expecting a large crowd of passengers, New York City Transit provided extended subway lines between downtown and Citi Field, and even posted transportation guidelines written in both English and Korean everywhere. I couldn't believe this was happening in front of my eyes. Citi Field was surrounded by tents camping out, just as in Chicago, and a massive crowd of fans queueing to purchase BTS merchandise. I met a lot of fans who were also at LA and Chicago shows, almost touring with BTS. Some fans flew in all the way from the West Coast because they couldn't work out the schedule, and one avid fan quit the job to join the tour because she thought it might be the last opportunity. Such enthusiasm from BTS fans was enough to realize how significant the show was. More than anything, everybody was truly touched by the historic importance of a stadium concert, reserved only for the top superstars.

BTS' Citi Field concert is the first K-pop stadium show in the U.S. I felt something similar during the coverage of BBMAs, but I've never imagined that Korean popular music would have a chance to

be on a stage like this. As a professional critic who has written extensively about Korean popular music for nearly twenty years, it was both touching and surreal. It felt even more special because I witnessed BTS' first year of activities in the United States. It was only four years ago when they were the youngest of K-pop boy bands, still new to the scene but so full of passion. Now, they are closing their North American tour with a grand finale at a stadium filled with 50,000 audiences and receiving full attention of American mainstream media and critics.

I was most impressed by the diversity of fans, spanning across generations and races. The audience of American pop concerts is usually divided by genre. In particular, the proportion of African American attendees is significantly low in concerts of general pop or rock stars, compared to hip-hop or R&B. I noticed that a large pool of BTS fans are people of color, including African Americans and Latino/as, quite rare for a pop group, especially as a K-pop artist. A few reasons come to my mind. In terms of their genre, BTS' mastery of hip-hop and urban, and their gentle and masculine attitudes may be familiar to African American and Hispanic Americans. The other factor is their performance. Even when compared to other K-pop groups, the charisma and energy exuded by BTS are outstanding, appealing to African American and Latino/a audience who favor the intense style of dancing. With such tendencies, the proportion of POCs among K-pop fans has drastically increased in the 2010s. They are the critical driving force behind K-pop's wide expansion in

both North and South Americas. This concert confirmed that BTS is the leader of that trend.

As is the case with American pop stars' shows, it's easy to spot whole families who come to watch BTS' concerts, usually led by the younger members. Still, the wide range of their fan's generations is extraordinary for an idol's show. In particular, BTS' concerts are attended by a significant number of middle-aged female fans. This is a scene more often found at reunion concerts of singers past their prime or at concerts hosted by casinos. The diversity of fans' age groups for a trendy idol group, only four years into their career, attests to the fact that their music has an across-the-board appeal even for the older generation. Furthermore, the middle-aged female fans I met in person all mentioned that there was something extra, beyond good music and stunning performances, that attracted them to BTS. They referred to it as "nostalgia." At first, it sounded strange that they would feel such a sentiment from a trendy K-pop boy band. I assume this is based on the signature sentimental and candid lyrics of BTS, represented by *The Most Beautiful Moment in Life*, rekindles the youthful sensibilities from the middle-aged fans. This is consistent with their reaction to BTS' music, which gives them consolation. Ultimately, this impression is linked to the message of mental healing through the realization of self-love, proclaimed in the LOVE YOURSELF series. BTS' music touches the hearts of those who are nostalgic about their days of youth, those who still have youthful hearts, and the parents see their children and recall

themselves. The universal message and music of BTS are uniting the fans who belong to different age and ethnic groups. I wonder if anyone ever expected K-pop idol music to spread such powerful empathy.

After covering BTS' tour over a span of two cities, it was disappointing when I looked up the Korean media reports on the tour. The interest on BTS from the domestic media is still at the elementary level that stresses national pride. The attention and accolades are superficial veneer; instead, we must explore the essence of the phenomenon. To me, it was more important that their range of fans is far wider than any other young pop star in the United States than the numerical count of the audience who gathered at Citi Field. It was the birth of universal pop music that Asians, Latinas, blacks, and whites can all go wild about. Listening to the massive crowd singing along in Korean in the heart of New York, I realized such an age has already arrived.

Column 08

The Implication of Grammy Awards Nomination

Historical Significance of the First K-pop Grammy Nomination

When I heard that BTS was nominated in the Grammy Awards, I was hoping for a nomination in one of the major categories and genres, the first ever for Korean popular music. To my dismay, it didn't happen. In Korea, the press called this a "failure." It was opposite from the American media that focused on the accomplishment. It's because they weren't nominated in the major categories, but if you know what the Grammy Awards is all about and are well knowledgeable about the past and the present status of K-pop, you would recognize the myopia of such expressions. Let me recap. Before the 1990s, Korean popular music industry wasn't even recognized in the world, like an uninhabited island. *Gayo*, Korean style of trendy music, were simple catchy tunes, undervalued when

compared to imported music from abroad. “Pop” was synonymous with American music, and it was mandatory for music enthusiasts to follow pop and rock music from the U.K. and the United States. Young people who were sensitive to trend listened to pirated copies of pop music from Japan, the nation more advanced at catching up with the west. This is also the process of how I became a music fan as a teenager. Once we entered the 1990s, the rise of young musicians like Seo Taiji and Boys, 015B, Shin Hae-chul, and Yoon Sang established the foundation of K-pop as we know. It was after the 2000s that K-pop, mainly idol music, finally branched out of the country, but nobody expected our pop to be competitive and successful in the United States, the global capital of pop music.

But what happened over the course of last few years? BTS was recognized as the most popular group in the world at the BBMAs. Two albums they released both topped the Billboard chart, with “Fake Love” and “IDOL” at the tenth and eleventh places on the single chart, proving their sustained and substantial popularity. Now, their prestige has elevated to the level of being invited by the Grammy Awards. It’s even more amazing that this accomplishment is unrelated to the support and influence of their home country. Americans discovered BTS first, acknowledged their potential and transformed them into international stars, and now are treating them as equivalent to their local pop stars. Despite such exceptional level of achievement and significance obtained by the emergence and success of BTS, why are they still underrated by a considerable

number of people, who would even as far to describe to the Grammy nomination as a “failure”? Is it perhaps the exceptional nature of the BTS phenomenon is too overwhelming in scale, which makes it difficult to grasp the situation? Still, I’m frustrated.

Every nomination in the Grammys is a success in itself. Its significance may be greater than what most people think. Before we get to the details, let’s examine facts one by one. The Grammy category they were nominated this year with *LOVE YOURSELF 轉 ‘Tear’* is officially called “Grammy Award for Best Recording Package.” “Package” here denotes all the components that comprise the packaging, including the cover image and wrapping of CDs or LPs. As is known, it’s not an award for their music. The category was first established in 1959 as “Best Album Cover,” which evaluated the artistry of album (vinyl records) covers. For a while, it was divided into “Graphic Arts” and “Photography,” but the two subsets are now combined as “Recording Package,” for assessment of the overall design of albums. The names of the artists and records are both stated, but the nominee is the record itself. The winners are not the artist of the record, but the designer of the cover and packaging.

The Grammy nomination of BTS’ album is significant progress. Sure, we may be slightly disappointed that it’s not a musical nomination but for album design. Did BTS’ music fail to receive recognition from the Grammys? To properly answer this question, we have to carefully examine what the award is about and the significance of being nominated (or not being nominated). The Grammy

Awards is the oldest award ceremony that represents the American popular music industry. It's not only an arena of recapitulating music of the past year; it also often functions as a catalyst for the entire industry. In the United States, the Grammys is one of the most important honors for a musician's career, just as an Olympic medal is for amateur sports players. This is because the Grammys is known for not considering the numerical measure of popularity, unlike other major music awards. Every category of the Grammys is evaluated and selected by the members of its host, the Recording Academy. Only the select few who are qualified as voting members earn the right to participate in this process. The membership at the Recording Academy is divided into three types. The one associated with the Grammys is the highest level, called "voting membership." Everyone in this category is musicians who have participated in the production of multiple records. Only after passing their very rigorous and strict qualification process, a member is approved as a voting member to participate in the evaluation and selection of the Grammy Awards. The tradition and authority of Grammy Awards originate from this fastidious process that already starts with the selection of evaluating panel. There's more. The records also go through extremely selective processes to become nominated. When records are submitted for evaluation, the specialists in each category first divide them into each genre and field through the initial screening. They are then selected as "Grammy Nominees" through voting.

The Grammy Awards is known as the most conservative music award, as evidenced by their history of recipients. The most marked example is their attitude against hip-hop, one of the trendiest genres in popular music. The Grammys were long overdue in introducing the “Best Rap Performance” category, ten years after the first hip-hop record was released. Ten more years had to pass before they awarded the first and only major music award to an artist of this genre. It was “Album of the Year” given to Lauryn Hill’s *The Miseducation of Lauryn Hill* in 1994 at the 41st Grammys. This is not to say that the voting members of the Grammy Awards, with a large pool of membership, have been ignoring or not recognizing the musicality of this genre. However, because of the procedural characteristics of the Grammys, which prioritizes each voting member’s musical preference over vox populi, it takes longer for the popular trend to reflect on the outcome. As a result, the award is inevitably more conservative and middle-of-the-road than progressive or radical. Due to the characteristic of the Recording Academy, the majority of its membership demographic belongs to the American mainstream society—older, white, and middle-class. This is also the reason pop and rock are prioritized over black music, as are safe and well-trained music over experimental and trendy. Among the new trendy genres, only a rare few that achieved phenomenal commercial success was enough to galvanize the Grammy members. Historically, only a handful of boy bands or pop idol music have been nominated.

Let's come back to the question about the nomination of BTS. What can we infer from their nomination in the "Best Recording Package" category? Again, I think we should read between the lines instead of what we see on the surface. I see this as the signal from the Grammys that they are at least aware of BTS' music, if not recognize them already, instead of just recognizing the packaging design of their album. In the end, every category of this award aims to celebrate the efforts of professionals in the music industry. They honor engineers, photographers, and even designers, who aren't even known to the general public, because they absolutely understand that these professionals are the critical agents of music production. What's intriguing is the fact that BTS is a K-pop artist. While they released records in the United States that topped the Billboard chart, it's still belongs in the Korean music industry. In spite of such conditions, it's an exceptional opportunity from the Grammys, whose goal is to celebrate the professionals in American music industry, to nominate an album produced in Korea. They didn't even include the statistics from social media reactions, as did the BBMAs. Coincidentally, during BTS' tour last year, the Grammy Museum had invited BTS for an in-depth interview session. It goes to show that their attention isn't only about the commercial success of BTS. In turn, albeit in a design category, it led to the nomination of BTS' album. Instead of isolated facts, we should connect the dots and see the bigger picture. First and foremost, the overall design of their album packaging was certainly outstanding, but it's more

convincing to argue that the Grammy members have begun to notice the BTS phenomenon, which took America by storm last year.

Due to their conservative nature, the Grammy Awards have rarely nominated a pop group, much less a boy band, in a major category. Though it isn't a major or a musical genre category, BTS received their initial recognition in the category of design, profoundly related to the aesthetics of their music. Perhaps it was a token of appreciation that the slow, conservative award could demonstrate at the moment. It seems quite roundabout, but it's still unprecedented in the history of K-pop and not insignificant at all. One more thing: the caliber of Korean popular music isn't determined by the recognition of the American music industry. The excellence of music isn't something vindicated by awards, either. I'm certain that we'll overcome the old-fashioned perspective of judging everything based on the perspective of the United States. At the same time, we must stay realistic. Nobody can deny that the authority of American record industry is still absolute, and American pop dominates the global music trend. The Grammy Awards, despite the limitations, are still the most authoritative and respected awards. There's no doubt about it. It is within such a context that BTS became the first Korean popular musician to be nominated. That's more than enough to be recognized and celebrated. Unbeknownst to our knowledge, immense transformations are taking place, and this won't be the end of it.

Interview 07

A Conversation with a Korean Voting Member of the Grammy Awards

Hyung-joo Lim, Popera Tenor



BTS' invitation to the Grammy Awards is an incredible feat and an important milestone for Korean popular music. Still, there is a

ridiculous shortage of objective analysis of its significance. Tenor Hyung-joo Lim, who is globally active as a popera singer, is known as an avid supporter of BTS as well as a member of the Recording Academy and a voting member of the Grammy Awards. I asked his opinion on the appeals of BTS and the meaning of their Grammy nomination.

Youngdae Kim Including myself, music fans know you as a popera tenor. But you have a special place to the supporters of BTS' music because you have openly supported and cheered on BTS through social media, more actively than any other celebrity. I'm curious about how you started having an interest in them.

Hyung-joo Lim As I recall, I first learned about BTS around the time of their debut in 2013. At Universal Music Group, where I was signed at the time, launched a rookie idol group named Boys Republic. BTS also debuted around that time, so I found out who they were soon enough.

Youngdae Kim How did you first start to pay special attention to their music? Was there something different about them compared to other idol music?

Hyung-joo Lim The song that first attracted me to BTS was “Blood, Sweat & Tears” released in 2016. To me, their music had the authenticity that was hard to find in other music, completely free of any trace of artificial exaggeration. The lyrics and melodies they dug up from deep inside their soul, and their explosive passion in every single dance move were so overwhelming, I think I was fated to fall for them.

Youngdae Kim To me, a music critic, BTS is a team that breaks the existing framework about idols because they participate in the production of music, write their own lyrics, and always exhibit unaffected and authentic character. To you, what kind of musician is BTS? As a fellow musician, what is the reason behind their immense global popularity?

Hyung-joo Lim It has been over two decades since my debut. In my twenty-second year as a musician, you could say that I am a seasoned professional in the field. I’ve always thought that no matter which genre you’re in, musicians must thoroughly base their work on authenticity and embody their individuality and genuine message in it. That is my fundamental idea and belief about music. From this perspective, BTS is an absolutely excellent musician. Their music isn’t contrived. They don’t confine themselves within

the typical hit formula or seek to ride the hottest trend to garner people's attention. Instead, they built an ingenious formula unique to themselves, established a special world view, created their own trend and led the people. I think they took the world by storm by maximizing these strengths.

Youngdae Kim For almost a decade, I've been observing and recording the response to K-pop as a resident in the U.S. It first started as a curiosity of a music critic, but I also feel proud when PSY or BTS promote Korea and inspire people in the world. In such a way, although you are in different genres, your trajectory is similar to BTS. You've also promoted Korea as a cultural ambassador for a long time, both in and outside of Korea. On overseas classical music magazines, you've been recognized as a world-renowned popera tenor and played an important role as a Hallyu promotor yourself. You've performed in numerous peace concerts and even received a United Nations Peace Medal. I'd say BTS' current path is similar to you among the K-pop idols. If you think about it, they also recently gave a speech at the United Nations.

Hyung-joo Lim Personally, besides my musical career, I wish to contribute and give back to our society on issues such as global peace, universal humanity, and protection of cultural

and religious diversity through music. To fulfill this goal, I have been a longtime goodwill ambassador for international and domestic NGOs including UN, UNESCO, and Korean Red Cross. I've performed pro bono for related concerts and events, participating and donating during my spare time. It was only natural that I felt very proud and really appreciated BTS' special speech at the UN Headquarters and their excellent project through UNICEF's official campaigns.

Youngdae Kim At the BBMAs, I had an opportunity to meet and talk to BTS. It was memorable how reserved and humble they were despite the tremendously festive atmosphere. It looked as though they were under enormous pressure for unintentionally being in a position to represent K-pop, if not Korea as a whole. I assume this kind of otherworldly experience is unfathomable to the general audience and something only shared between the artists who are in similar situations.

Hyung-joo Lim Yes, I am well aware of how tremendously burdening and stressing it is to promote Korean culture and represent their nation on the global stage, which may seem like a roller-coaster ride. It's the reason why I genuinely cheer them on and stoutly support their activities. I am a little embarrassed to say this myself, but I've identified and

sympathized with them throughout BTS' footsteps. Some of you may know that I debuted from a small one-man agency, not a big classic label. As a musician who advocated a minor crossover genre called "popera," quite unknown in Korea at the time, I've struggled alone for a long time to promote the genre to the wider audience. I had to endure the indifferent domestic media and rarely having stages to perform, bitterly swallowing my tears in the dark. Thanks to the devoted support of my official fan club, the Salley Gardens, I was able to establish myself as the only active Korean popera singer on the global stage.

Youngdae Kim That reminds me of BTS' fan club, ARMY. In their interview with me, BTS members also expressed their special gratitude for their fans numerous times. They seem to have a different kind of bond from those between the rock stars and music fans in the past.

Hyung-joo Lim BTS also started from a small agency and struggled through every step of the way. They could rise to where they are thanks to the immense love and support from the ARMYs. I'd like to think that to BTS, the ARMYs became the driving force of their success, and to the ARMYs, BTS was the energizer of their daily lives. You can no longer think of BTS apart from the ARMYs. Their strong bond is beyond the

relationship between fans and an artist, more like the bond between family members.

Youngdae Kim In their MAMA acceptance speech, BTS indirectly mentioned their distress and concerns of being a top star. Unlike the extravagance you see on the outside, the pressure they must feel as creators and artists is something that general audience cannot easily understand. In your early teens, you also stood on large-scale stages and juggled studies and musical activities abroad, and as someone who challenged an unfamiliar genre such as popera, I assume you aren't a stranger to hardship and despair. Though the genres are different, is there anything that you feel personally when you observe BTS' activities?

Hyung-joo Lim Through a media report, I learned that they even discussed disbanding before renewing their contracts. Listening to their story about all the troubles and burden, I couldn't help but ruminate various thoughts. I debuted at the tender age of twelve, for twenty years, I've undergone through hell and high water on the global stage. As a senior who is now in mid-thirties, in terms of both music and life, I can presume all kinds of anguish and anxiety they must experience musically, concerns as world stars, and vague pressures about the future. Although I probably can't fathom

all of their burdens, I am certain of one thing: as they have always done, BTS will continue to overcome them just fine. Deep inside their hearts, they have an undying passion for music, and the ARMYs will stand by them firmly to love and protect them until the end of the world.

Youngdae Kim The attractive elements of BTS can be divided into music, performance, and more, but each member's individual vocal tones and abilities are also important. As a vocalist, how do you assess BTS vocal members' abilities and individual characteristics?

Hyung-joo Lim First off, I've always thought that the essential virtue for the members who are vocalists in groups is the "caring heart" for creating the perfect musical harmony. As a vocal professor and a popera vocalist, I will evaluate them in general. I noticed from Jimin's vocals his clear diction, high-pitch skills that extend straightforwardly, and excellent falsetto techniques in R&B sensibilities. This is very effective for emotionally appealing to the listeners. Jung Kook's voice shows incredible restraint. I highly appreciate his vocal techniques, especially when he connects the elegantly beautiful voice with a smooth head voice in legato.³⁵⁾ As for V, the timbre of his baritone voice is very attractive and sounds more masculine than other members. He is also

talented at expressing sweet and soft tones, very good at imbuing the music with his deep emotions. Being able to seamlessly express emotions through singing is a terrific strength for musicians in any genre. I'd like to describe Jin's voice as "silvery." Almost like a murmur, his voice may not be the fanciest or the grandest, with a lower volume to begin with. But he has stable breathing, along with the ability to interchange freely between moist falsetto, modal and head voice with natural vibrations, which is quite a useful advantage. He also progresses more than expectations in each album, a reflection of how much effort and consideration he is always investing in vocal training. I am highly anticipating how much he will continue to grow. Other members, who may not be vocal positions, also basically know how to handle chords elaborately, in addition to their outstanding rhythmic skills. Whether it is dancing, rapping, or singing, their genuine attitude toward music is a role model for musicians in any genre.

Youngdae Kim Is there a song that you consider special among BTS' songs, and what is the reason for your selection?

Hyung-joo Lim I've listened to most of BTS' songs, and I've discovered impressive characteristics from each of them, it's difficult to discriminate between the tracks. If I had to pick

special few songs, I'd say "Blood, Sweat & Tears," for making me fall for them; "DNA," among one of their global hits; and "Paradise," a heartfelt serenade for the ARMYs.

Youngdae Kim Do you have a bias? (laughs).

Hyung-joo Lim Well. This is the most difficult question (laughs). Each and every member is very attractive to me, it's extremely hard to pick one person.

Youngdae Kim In your career, we can't disregard the title as a "voting member of the Grammy Awards." It is such a meaningful position and I'm very proud of you as a music critic. You also became a member of the Recording Academy, famous for their rigorous selection process. When BTS was nominated in the Grammys this year, you celebrated the historic moment as a voting member. Could you tell us about BTS' accomplishment as a voting member of the Grammys?

Hyung-joo Lim As you said, in early 2017 I was approved as a member of the Recording Academy, which presents the Grammy Awards. I qualified in the highest level as a voting member and a nomination committee member. It's such an honor to contribute as an Asian musician in the Grammy

Awards, considered the award of all musicians' dreams. It certainly became an indispensable part of my music career. BTS was nominated in the "Best Recording Package" category at the upcoming Grammy Awards. They didn't make it in the expected "Best Pop Duo/Group Performance" and "Best Dance/Electronic Album" categories, but as I left on my official social media account at the moment of their nomination, this is a miracle in itself and a partial success. I would like to stress again my disagreement and resentment at some of the domestic press for using the words "disappointment" and "failure" in their headlines.

Youngdae Kim Grammys are also well-known for being fastidious in every aspect. Plenty of excellent musicians were never even nominated. Well, in that sense, it's encouraging news for both BTS and Korean music that there is someone who really understands their music among the voting members now (laughs).

Hyung-joo Lim I'm going to abide by the obligation to maintain neutrality as a Grammy member. But aside from being Korean and their musical senior, even when I evaluate them according to objective standards, I am certain that BTS will be nominated in major categories of the Grammys in the very near future. That's how highly I regard their music.

Youngdae Kim BTS has become a household name, but commercial success and critical recognition are two different things. Some western media still have cultural prejudice against BTS' success. But it's frustrating as a journalist myself to see how Korean media cannot properly recognize BTS' accomplishments. Perhaps it's because they have no idea how difficult it is to succeed in the music industry monopolized by the west.

Hyung-joo Lim It's such a shame. That's why I explicitly asserted my view through social media. As a Korean and their senior in the music industry, I was indescribably happy and proud just by watching the projection of BTS' career. They have continued to break records by a large margin every time they ranked on the Billboard main chart, indisputably the world's most respected and nearly inconceivable for Asian musicians. I can still vividly remember the thrill and ecstasy I felt when they finally topped the Billboard 200 and reached no. 10 on Billboard Hot 100. Yet, the lukewarm attitude of domestic media and rather reserved response of other idols puzzled and almost offended me. And there's more. How pathetic are these anti-fans who spread groundless rumors that are no different from fake news? Nevertheless, as stated by immutable truth, the truth will prevail in the end.

BTS are overcoming all kinds of limitations and obstacles on their path as a successful world star. We must continue to encourage and empower them, because they are beyond Korea and now BTS of the world.

Youngdae Kim Your career is over two decades already. Despite your difference in genres, BTS is a colleague and far younger juniors. As a fellow musician, do you have any advice you would like to give?

Hyung-joo Lim When I debuted in 1998, celebrating my twentieth anniversary was an unfathomable duration of time. It's as if time flew past me. It's not an exaggeration to say that the only secret to my longevity on the global stage is my passion for music and endless effort. BTS is pioneering a special path that nobody has gone before, in the most successful way possible. Don't try too hard to improve; just do your best to maintain your innocence and passion for music, and the heartfelt gratitude for the ARMYs. Once you do that, you will doubtlessly become everlasting stars, beyond living legends.

Hyung-joo Lim is a popera tenor and an Endowed Chair Professor at the vocal music department of Civica Scuola delle Arti di Roma. In 2017, he became a nomination committee member and a voting member of the Grammy Awards, and is a goodwill ambassador for UN and UNESCO.

Column 09

Beyond “the Greatest Boy Band on the Planet”

The Potential as a Universal Pop Artist Beyond the Boy Band Formula

When BTS arrived in Los Angeles International Airport for their LOVE YOURSELF World Tour, the local US media started to allude their American expansion to the Beatles’ “British Invasion.” The unprecedented grand scale of arena tours and their historic New York Citi Field performance were directly compared to the legendary Shea Stadium show of the Beatles, and the local broadcasting stations frequently reported the massive queue of people who gathered to watch their concerts. Even if you take into account that

American media are prone to hype, it was definitely something exceptional.

The fact that BTS is even being compared to the Beatles, the greatest artist in pop history, is an honor itself. But when you trace the historical context of the BTS phenomenon, it's not something that came out of the blue. Imagine, the sight of how seven young men from Asia, bringing about the inexplicable response from hundreds and thousands of audiences with an explosive performance unobserved in the recent pop history. To the fans of rock and roll, who remember the sight of fervent fans welcome the Beatles at the JFK Airport in 1964 and their U.S. tour that took the nation by storm, this was certainly a *déjà vu*. It was only a year ago that they were invited to the AMAs as rookies called "global sensation," but now almost all media outlets are referring to them as "the greatest boy band on the planet." It's important that these titles came from the American mainstream press, not the domestic news hyped by nationalism.

Nobody expected such a day would come this early. Just a few years ago, K-pop was considered a quirky hybrid or an imitation of American popular music. Even when "Gangnam Style" by PSY nearly topped the Billboard chart, K-pop was nothing beyond an odd viral culture produced by the age of the internet. Who would have thought, in their wildest dreams, that an idol band from Korea would ever be discussed as the next generation prospect in the trendiest music industry in the world, following the globally sensational boy

bands like New Kids on the Block, NSYNC, and One Direction? I don't think this is just a hype that the American media is known for, and limiting them solely as a boy band may underrate the weight of the BTS phenomenon. This is something that anybody who has examined their distinct music and messages in depth will certainly agree with.

The concept of "boy band" is a product of western popular music, especially a tradition from American pop that goes back to the age of rock and roll. The definition falls under specific conditions. In the 1960's American popular music, the Jackson 5 and the Osmonds, which became the archetype of boy bands, basically consisted of family members in the form of vocal harmony groups. During this time, a domineering producer would recruit talents and trained them in music and performances. Every musical decision was made by this producer, in other words, they were manufactured pop groups completely under the control of the producer. This trend was partially inherited by DeBarge and New Edition until the 1970-80s. By the late 1980s, a complete model was showcased by New Kids on the Block. This group of white boys, recruited through auditions and trained by a talented composer and producer Maurice Starr, had almost every aspect of a modern boy band. The "New Kids" became a syndrome that took over the U.S. and branched out to the rest of the world. Their success perfected the formula of "pop group formed of young, handsome men who perform music created by a domineering producer," nearly establishing a new genre. In

every way, New Kids on the Block was an archetype of modern boy bands. Presenting bubble gum pop, a sweet subgenre of pop originated in rock and roll and R&B, they specifically targeted girls in teens and twenties, catering their music and messages to what they want to hear. Sweet, romantic stories, and not too serious thoughts about life were wrapped with beautiful looks and smooth moves, giving birth to the ultimate easy-listening pop for anyone. The concept of boy band music, represented by NKOTB, was different from experimental or adventurous, and this trend hasn't changed much in the tradition of western pop boy bands.

BTS is also historically categorized as a boy band, as they are produced by the K-pop scene, rooted directly in the production system of American and British pop idols. Lee Soo-man, the head of SM Entertainment who was inspired by NKOTB's syndrome that stormed by the U.S. and Korea in the early 1990s, realized quickly that the future of Korean music industry was in idol music. He merged the trendy dance music from the U.S. and the idol training system that Japan had been developing for a decade to create an incredible hybrid called "K-pop idols." JYP and YG, agencies established by musicians who grew up listening to the 1980s American pop, also joined this trend as they built the K-pop industry centered around today's "trainee system," sharing the glory days of K-pop idols. Bang Si-hyuk, a producer who honed his music and business foundations at JYP, continued this tradition with his own agency BigHit Entertainment. BTS, an idol group selected through

talent recruitment and training system, is positioned within the context of boy bands starting with the Jackson 5 and NKOTB, which leads to K-pop. As is the case of numerous idol boy bands in pop history, they also inherit the historical continuity as a group of handsome young men focused on visual aesthetics and attractive performance. But this is where the concurrence with the existing boy bands end, at the external traits. As soon as you delve deeper beyond the formative similarities into the details and attitude toward music, it's easy to recognize that BTS has essentially different characteristics from previously popular boy bands and that they are operated in a new model and content that can appeal to a wider range of audience.

The decisive distinction of BTS from other boy bands is that they don't completely rely on their producer for creating music. Every member has partial control over their music. Looking back at the history of pop, boy bands have been the reflection of musical vision, the persona of the manager or the music producer who recruited and organized the group. Such an example is Motown, the first to establish the concept of idol groups centered around the producer and the management. The Supremes of the 1960s and the Jackson 5 of the 1970s, the top girl and boy bands of the times, have always remained under the strict control and musical vision of Barry Gordy. All of their music was in charge of their in-house composition teams, the Corporation or Holland-Dozier-Holland, and each idol member's individual musical participation or voice was not allowed or minimal.

This was the same in more contemporary history of boy bands. Organized by composer Maurice Starr, New Edition and NKOTB were almost twins with different racial composition. They were both the same in terms of being the outlets to express Starr's musical vision. In particular, NTOTB couldn't overcome their stereotype because they continued to focus on bubble gum R&B pop that Starr favored, despite the members' wish to try something closer to hip-hop. The reason for such a choice was because it was the "safe" route commercially. Moreover, every musical decision, including composers and arrangement style for Backstreet Boys and NSYNC, two groups that continued the success streak of boy bands, were all strictly made by manager Lou Pearlman. One of the greatest boy bands in the 2010s, One Direction, is also a boy band organized by Simon Cowell from an audition, operated entirely under his control. K-pop isn't far from this model, as the industry was built based on western examples. K-pop idol music, represented by SM, JYP, and YG Entertainments (as assumed from the agencies' names matching the name of the founder's initials), generally are created as the persona that reflects each producer's preference and direction. In that process, the musical initiative of the members is extremely limited. The only exceptions are the groups who have already accomplished a certain level of success. Conversely, the fact that creative freedom and musical initiatives were limited to trained idols was accepted as the virtue and the commercial advantage for idol music.

However, there is a clear difference when you examine the relationship between BTS and BigHit. Producer Bang Si-hyuk prioritized the individuality and artistic freedom of BTS over specific styles that the agency came up with. The members were proactively involved in writing lyrics, as well as deeply engages in composition, arrangement, and every other process of music production with the help of few in-house producers. Undoubtedly, Mr. Bang and BigHit producers' influence is significant in BTS' music. Still, as they incorporated BTS members' ideas and opinion liberally instead of top-down control by the producer, their music gained organic appeals. The fact that they are musically rooted in hip-hop, with high bars on artistry and authenticity, probably also had an influence. BTS was intended as a hip-hop group with the external qualities of an idol, and whether they have certain control over the rap lyrics or music became the standard for determining "real" musicians from "fake" ones. Fortunately, because BTS wrote their lyrics and participated in rap making since the early stage of their career, they were able to imbue their personalities into the group's music.

Having that musical control within BTS' identity signifies that their music retains the kind of originality difficult for traditional boy bands to obtain. And that originality is powered by honest about who they are. The artistic value of BTS shines through the lyrics and messages they wrote personally, just as much as the trendy music. Though they also sing of romance like any other idol groups, the appeal of introspective and philosophical messages about myself

and the surrounding world is something distinctively exhibited by BTS' music. They have the most open attitude about being honest, conventionally considered taboo for idol music. Their lyrics aren't artificial or abstract, but always realistic and specific. They have no qualms about revealing their emotions and vulnerabilities. While critical and rebellious against their enemies and the challenges in society, but they sympathize with the contemporary youth and sends the message of encouragement and consolation. The important point is that these messages were organically derived from what they felt and experienced. In the history of K-pop, in fact, of the global boy band, no other group with such an ingenious, honest, and wholesome messages have ever existed.

This is not only a factor that differentiates BTS from other K-pop idols, but it also distinguishes from the "greatest boy bands" that have existed prior to their emergence. Now, it has become the decisive reason why they enjoy the far bigger size of fandom than any other pop idol boy bands. BTS' fandom ARMY encompasses a far wider range of demographics in terms of culture, race, and generation. This is due to the universality of their music that transcends these categories. In music, "crossover" is a term that refers to the versatility of popular music, originated in American pop that includes various markets and consumers who belong in different races, regions, and genres. It signifies the literal "crossing over" of a certain type of music between different groups. I believe the worldwide popularity demonstrated by BTS is the first true

“crossover” phenomenon in the history of K-pop as well as boy bands. The ARMYs are dispersed all over Asia, North America, South America, the Middle East, Africa, and Europe. The scale of their numbers and passion far exceeds those of previous popular boy bands and contemporary K-pop idols. At BTS’ LOVE YOURSELF tour, it was easy to spot middle-aged women, not just those in teens and twenties, the usual suspects at a boy band concert. It’s not common for boy bands to attract middle-aged fans en masse, unless it’s a reunion concert. That wasn’t the case for BTS. Two, three generations of female fans would come to watch their show together. It wasn’t hard to find daughters who tagged along with their mother who are BTS fans.

As such, the musical authenticity and transcendent appeals that BTS has as a boy band inevitably results in comparison not with previous idol groups, such as NKOTB or One Direction, but with the pop legends with even greater influence and musicality. If the Beatles is the closest model in terms of the cultural impact of the BTS phenomenon, as an external “invasion” from Asia, they remind me of Michael Jackson as a talented total-package pop star who encompasses diverse races and cultures with universality and transcendental qualities. Their stunning performance and charisma on stage also resemble Freddie Mercury and Queen. These artists share one thing in common. Musically and culturally, they never remained stagnant inside the existing framework and continued to pioneer new territories, while always managing to persuade the

general audience. The Beatles started with rock and roll in the style of Chuck Berry, the founder of American rock and roll, or singer-songwriter Buddy Holly, but they continued to innovate and absorbed Indian and classical influences to initiate the era of art pop and psychedelia. Michael Jackson, as the first black artist on MTV, explored beyond R&B genre that the existing black artists were accustomed to, boldly embracing rock and pop. Attracting even the white audience as his fans, he marched on the path as a pop artist. Also, Freddie Mercury denied the typical category of a rock band, inventing entirely new styles of performance and crossover musicality that characterized him as the most one-of-a-kind frontman in the history of rock music. As for BTS, though they are a K-pop group, they are breaking all the rules of a K-pop idol. Equipped with every dazzle that a traditional boy band can have, they don't remain within that model. BTS stepped on the American mainstream market, still out of reach for K-pop, absorbing a far wider range of audience that existing boy bands could only dream of. Their target of comparison is no longer other K-pop idol groups.

Whether it's American pop, J-pop, or K-pop, all boy bands identify with pop. A myriad of groups has emerged and disappeared, but none of them have reached the transcendental prestige of pop of the Beatles, Michael Jackson, and Freddie Mercury. Most western boy bands consisted of Caucasian members that appealed mainly to middle-class white teenagers but didn't have much influence over Africa, Latin America, or Asia. They rarely attempted unconventional

or experimental music, and in many cases, the coordination of their looks, dance, and singing were not the most accomplished. But BTS took a step further. In every aspect, they are faithful to the formula of modern idol pop founded in America and inherited by K-pop, but also offer an evolved model that breaks the rules. Unlike western boy bands who are all vocal members with one or two main singers and other K-pop idols who are mostly singers, BTS has three fantastic rappers and four excellent vocalists with different timbres, which allows them to span a wide range of the musical spectrum. Such versatility provides them with the freedom to experiment with different era and genres within one album constantly. The rappers in BTS have the proficiency on par with those in the hip-hop scene, and their vocalists are equivalent to any other R&B singer. Most importantly, they are successful in obtaining transcendental inspiration and sympathy that most idol music has neglected or failed to achieve. Their universal, wholesome, and deep qualities, rare for a boy band, allowed them to be part of the anti-violence campaign for UNICEF and to give a speech at the UN General Assembly.

Today, both Korean and American press are ceaselessly searching for a model to explain the abrupt storm that is the BTS phenomenon. But it's something they cannot fully explain using the terms they know, like Hallyu or K-pop. Thus, they arrived at the inevitable conclusion, "the greatest boy band on the planet," based on the historical precedence. While it is an unprecedented honor in the history of Korean popular music, it's not a phrase that deciphers

the character and the essence of the BTS phenomenon. BTS is already overcoming the racial limitations as an Asia-based boy band. Despite the linguistic barrier as Korean-language music, they are captivating a wide variety of demographics with the aesthetics of performance and the universal appeal of their messages. The variegated, experimental music based on hip-hop is entirely different from those presented by other boy bands. People are calling BTS the greatest boy band on the planet, but what we are witnessing is the emergence of a new pop group that exceeds the limits of an idol boy band.

Epilogue

The Missing Link in Media Coverage of the BTS Phenomenon

I had never thought I would be writing a book about BTS. But in retrospect, perhaps it wasn't entirely unexpected. In 2006, I wrote the very first publication on the history of Korean hip-hop, its culture and industry titled *Korean Hip-hop: the Footprints of its Passion*. I have kept a close eye on the ways in which Korean hip-hop was popularized (or commercialized), including the TV show "Show Me the Money" and how K-pop has subsumed or negotiated with hip-hop, in cases such as 1TYM and BIGBANG. Since I came to the U.S. to study music in 2007, my interest in K-pop and hip-hop started to develop more academically. My initial focus was on Asian-American musicians who are active in the U.S. But when I arrived in America, I

began to notice a particular trend among young students who were wild about K-pop. While I was wondering what it was, the unforgettable craze of “Gangnam Style” stormed the nation. Everyone started talking about K-pop, and thanks to the song, America was introduced to diverse dimensions of Korean popular music. I had to become keener about the issues.

As usual, the trend seldom flows according to a critic’s expectations. Sometimes, it’s rather reassuring that way. Contrary to my pessimistic outlook for its establishment in mainstream Korean music, hip-hop started to gain traction as it accomplished commercialization and critical recognition. “Show Me the Money” became sensational from the beginning with its extremely dramatic structure and narrative. The second solo album by G-Dragon of BIGBANG, despite the onslaught of controversy and harsh criticism on his first album, put hip-hop at the forefront and received series of acclaim from numerous hip-hop media. His success peaked when he won a KMA in hip-hop category. G-Dragon and Missy Elliott’s collaborative performance of “Niliria” at KCON 2013 was an unforgettable moment for Korean hip-hop history.

This coincided with the period I began to pay special attention on the format of hip-hop idols. More than anything, I expected the American public to react positively to this new form, considering the cultural specificities of hip-hop. At this opportune moment, I heard from Bong-hyeon Kim (also an interviewee in this book) that a hip-hop idol named “BTS” was preparing for a debut. When I spotted their name

on the lineup for KCON 2014, I felt an irresistible curiosity. The fiery responses that I felt from the crowd in LA that day made me vaguely wonder if it could be the harbinger of a new era. It could've been a longtime critic's gut feeling, but talking to various media outlets and the fans on site, I was assured that it wasn't entirely unwarranted. I visited KCON every year to follow the trend, and as witnessing the unbelievable reaction to BTS when they returned in 2016, I realized that something had already happened. Looking back, if I wasn't in the U.S. and physically experienced the new wave of change through KCON, I wonder if I would have stayed as interested in the BTS phenomenon as I am now. Life is a series of fateful connections that seem coincidental.

After returning from KCON, I kept bringing up BTS and the new trend of hip-hop idols whenever I had a chance. But nobody was particularly interested. Perhaps it was indifference toward BTS, but I speculate that it was more about the disinterest or rejection of their contradictory format as a hip-hop idol. While keeping up with their career, I started presenting my thoughts on this new current in K-pop represented by BTS, at academic conferences, college lectures, and seminars in the U.S. In 2017, when BTS finally won an award at the BBMAs, I finally felt the wind of change. Following their invitation and special performance at the AMAs, domestic media began to copy the report the explosive coverage from the foreign press. As someone who noticed them from the beginning, I was frustrated with the insufficient understanding of Korean media on the essence and the

context of this phenomenon. Through my personal YouTube channel, I started to analyze the significance of their popularity in the U.S. and the meaning of their music, which gained modest sympathy from the viewers. Whenever I had time, and as BTS expanded their radius of activities, I posted analyses to the extent of my knowledge. These videos were then countlessly cited by internet users, journalists, and academics. I still receive related questions regularly. Though it was a busy year for me, I didn't expect to publish a study or a critique on BTS.

Fortunately, when BTS attended the BBMAs, I had the opportunity to witness first-hand their performance and the flood of reactions toward them. It was exciting to attend and interview pop stars on the red carpet at the BBMAs, which I had only watched on TV as a young boy, but there was something even more unforgettable. It was the encounter with BTS at the BBMAs. Luckily, I was given the opportunity to interview them despite their busy schedule. Albeit short, I was able to meet them face-to-face and listen to the stories that are difficult to find out through the media. After the interview, on the flight back to Seattle, I decided to reorganize my previous thoughts and lectures systematically into a book. LOVE YOURSELF Tour, which followed, was another opportunity to develop my ideas further. After four days on the road, spanning Seattle, Chicago, and New York, I fleshed out my impressions through YouTube. Some of the content has been published on the news and magazine articles. I have rewritten and

rearranged the content I have discussed on TV, newspapers, or magazines, in the unexpectedly busy past year and developed new ideas to complete this book. Some have expressed concerns, and I also had a burden of publishing a critique about an artist who still has an ongoing career. The analysis in this book are my interpretations as a critic, but since they don't reflect their career in the future, the nuances may change over time or my insight may become contradictory. Certainly, my arguments may be refuted or revised in the future. Still, the current perspectives may hold importance on their own. I hope to add depth to the analysis as their career progresses, with more research and investigation. My only wish is to convey my sincerity toward music and artists.

Let's return to the question that opened this book: "What is the essence of the BTS phenomenon?" As I iterated in the prologue, if you were inspired from listening to their music, and nodded along as you read my story, that moment of inspiration and empathy has every answer to the question. The essence of the BTS music and phenomenon must be found in the universality that generates empathy and consolation. Instead of the existing power structure of the broadcast system, that universality is amplified by multifold through intimate interaction with their fans. BTS and the music they create comprises 80%, which persuades the ARMY and the general public to form an intimate relationship with them to fill the remaining 20%, completing the chemical composition for a "phenomenon." BTS' music has the universal quality in the entire twenty-first century

K-pop. Their message is persuasive without a dogmatic manner. They admit the darkness and despair inside without resorting to defeatism. Their music may be trendy, but the layers of sentiment and expertise since the 1990s, accumulated throughout the history of Korean popular music, function as part of the DNA. The universal appeal that BTS music performance has reconciled the youth and the older generation, different cultures and races, the western aesthetics and Korean values, and me and my other selves inside me. In the age where everyone speaks aloud only what they want, the important—though banally spoiled—virtue of “communication” is renewed through the deep music and beautiful performances by BTS. The most critical basis that makes this a worldwide phenomenon is the ARMYs, who exist throughout every culture in the globe. Their voluntary passion is creating a massive wave that transcends nations and cultures. The BTS phenomenon isn’t something BTS created alone; it’s a movement that BTS and ARMY created together. The universality of their music and the synergy created by their relationship with the fans is the point that I want to emphasize throughout the book, and the substantial essence of the BTS phenomenon that nobody had identified properly.

Notes

- 1) BTS' fandom name "ARMY" literally denotes the "military"; it signifies that just as "bulletproof" armor and the army are always with one another, BTS and their fan club will always be together. It is also an acronym for "Adorable Representative M.C for Youth."
- 2) A subgenre of American Southern hip-hop, characterized by 808 drum beats split into small rhythms and the extreme dependence on the synthesizer sound with a strong tendency as dance music.
- 3) The origin of siren effects goes all the way back to the legendary American hip-hop group Public Enemy. It is a signature sound effect in hip-hop.
- 4) This is the oldest style of traditional hip-hop originated in the mid-1990s East Coast.
- 5) An R&B genre that highlights sensuality and focuses on creating a romantic ambience.
- 6) An electric guitar sound that uses effectors that switch video and audio signals into electric signals to create various effects.
- 7) Anti-fans who unconditionally slander from jealousy and envy toward others.
- 8) Experimental electronic dance music developed in the U.K. in the 1990s.
- 9) A legendary black music label that enjoyed their prime in the 1960-70s. For their easy-listening, popular style, sometimes the name is considered a subgenre of R&B. The Jackson 5 and the Supremes are some of the notable artists from the label.
- 10) Japanese popular music, the second largest market in the world following the United States.
- 11) High-pitch vocal registers higher than those created by head voice, mostly attributed to male vocals.

- 12) Lowering of half a note in the third and seventh major scales, often used in jazz and blues genres.
- 13) In October 2018, a photo of BTS member Jimin became a topic of online controversy. In it, Jimin was wearing a t-shirt printed with a picture of the Nagasaki atomic bomb being dropped, a scene of Koreans celebrating the end of World War II and liberation from Japanese colonial rule, along with English words “patriotism,” “our history,” “liberation,” and “Korea.” Due to the photo, Japan’s Asahi TV canceled the scheduled appearance of BTS on *Music Station, and four days later, an American Jewish rights advocacy group called Simon Wiesenthal Center (SWC) released a statement that condemned BigHit Entertainment and BTS for mocking the past. Although BigHit Entertainment released a statement on Nov. 13th, SWC’s response and the way international press handled this issue seemed problematic. Over thirty ARMYs who were frustrated with the turn of events published a white paper to examine and trace the controversy and the related incidents. It includes the summary of the controversy, mistaken press coverage, false investigation, the historical context to understand the issue, their fan reactions, and a statement by a Japanese fan.
- 14) A sudden change in musical atmosphere through alterations in rhythms and bass.
- 15) Someone who creates the beat and the instrumental for the song.
- 16) Beats per minute; a measure of musical speed.
- 17) A type of virtual instrument that imitates the upbeat, refreshing sound of plucking strings, frequently used in EDM.
- 18) “Lining” the “top” of the score, in other words, adding melody to instrumental accompaniment.
- 19) A co-composition method that originated in the late 1990’s Northern European music scene, where a group of producing teams and musicians gather at one place and share opinions within a short period to compose and record music together.
- 20) A process or technique that uses turntables and mixers to manipulate or edit sounds.
- 21) Using extreme settings on auto-tune, originally for correcting off-key notes, to remove vocal characteristics to sound as if it’s sung by a machine.

- 22) A fusion genre of reggaeton and house from Puerto Rico, characterized by heavy bass and dramatic structure.
- 23) A subgenre of R&B that became popularized in the mid to late 1990s, which excludes the pop-influenced R&B, while blending jazz and hip-hop to return to the essence of "soul" genre.
- 24) An electronic musical genre originated in Chicago. When the wave of disco in the 1970s perished due to backlash from the establishment audience, this genre was born from a new experiment in an attempt to revive disco at gay clubs in Chicago.
- 25) A fusion dance genre of electronic pop music, including synth-pop, garage, and house.
- 26) BTS won the "Musician of the Year" in the 16th 2019 Korean Music Awards. They became the first artist, not just a K-pop idol, to receive this award two years in a row in KMA history. "Fake Love" also won "Song of the Year" and "Best Pop Song."
- 27) A fusion genre of alternative punk rock and hip-hop, characterized a combination of minor scale, trap beats and lyrics about emotional distress and gloom.
- 28) A genre of club music that fuses funk, jazz, and soul, characterized by an upbeat groove.
- 29) Rooted in bubblegum pop and R&B, this popular style of music aims for easy melodies and light sounds.
- 30) A genre of electronic dance music from the U.K.
- 31) Simultaneous use of two continuous rhythms.
- 32) A popularized genre in the 1960's San Francisco, characterized by dreamy organ instrumentals and distorted guitar sounds, mirroring the effects of hallucinogenic drugs.
- 33) A musical scale with five notes per octave, common among Asian folk music.
- 34) A subgenre of heavy metal originated in the U.K. and the U.S. in mid-1970s, characterized by fast bass and drum beats.
- 35) Vocal or instrumental style of smoothly connecting between notes.



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A Comprehensive Look at the Music of BTS

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rank No. 1 on	Social Artist Award	2018 American	Package" 2019
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The Beatles of the YouTube generation *_Le Figaro*

BTS, Next Generation Leaders *_TIME*

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BTS